

My Twin Sister Took My Place as His Wife

A Marriage-in-Crisis Betrayal Second-Chance Romance

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First Edition

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Chapter 1 — Maud

The first wrong thing was my coat, because I had left it on the third hook in the front hall on August 3 and it had just walked out of my front door without me.

Camel wool, a man's cut, \$11 at a thrift shop in Wilmington, worn through at the right cuff where my wrist used to rest on the bench edge eight hours a day. I would have known it in the dark, and it was dark, and the rain on Brown Street was coming down at the slant it only finds in November, so that every streetlight turned the drops into short bright scratches.

The coat stopped on the top step, under the lamp, and put my phone to its ear.

I had been standing across the street for six minutes by then, under the Dunns' sycamore, with a taxi idling at the curb behind me and my suitcase still in its trunk. The license on the partition said the driver's name was Ibrahim and that he had been driving in Philadelphia since 2004. When I got out he had looked at my face in the side mirror, at the left eyebrow, and then away, which was polite of him.

"That your house?" he'd said.

"Yes."

"Looks like a party. You want me to pull up closer? I can double-park. Nobody's going to say anything in this."

"Here is fine."

"You're getting wet."

"I'm aware of that," I said.

He had rolled his window down once since, to let the cold in and a question out.

"Ma'am. You want me to wait, or you want your bag?"

"Wait."

"Meter's running."

"That's what it's for."

He rolled the window back up, and I didn't blame him. I was a woman in a linen jacket in November, with a black brace on her right wrist, standing in the rain and staring at a lit house, and the house was mine.

It was a three-story brick rowhouse with a bay window on the first floor, and the bay window belonged to the dining room, and the dining room was full. Both leaves were in the table. Somebody had counted out ten chairs, and laid a white cloth that caught the brass fixture's light and threw it back up warm under every chin, the most flattering light I know of and the least honest, because it filled the lines in. There were candles in my pewter sticks. I have always held that candles at dinner are a performance. At the far end, nearest the kitchen door, sat my husband in the blue shirt I'd bought him in March, sleeves turned back twice, which meant he was carving. At the near end, in my chair, with her back nearly to the glass, sat a woman with my hair in a loose clip.

My sister Cora was born eleven minutes after me. She had my face and my hair, the color of wet sand, and she had not in thirty-five years worn it in a braid, because she said a braid made a woman look like she was about to do something difficult.

Her phone buzzed on the cloth beside her plate. She looked at it, said something to the room that made a man laugh, and went out into the hall. Through the glass I could follow her to the hooks. She took the third one down.

So that was the coat.

She had turned the collar up. She had my phone in her right hand, in the gray silicone case with the chipped corner I'd been meaning to replace since spring, and on her right wrist, over the cuff of my coat, a beige elastic brace of the kind they sell beside the reading glasses at a drugstore. I looked down at my own. Mine was black, rigid, molded over the plate and the nine screws beneath it, and nobody sold it beside anything.

"Mr. Abruzzo! Hi, hi, this is Maud."

Brown Street was narrow, and Cora had never needed a microphone in her life.

"Oh, I'm still in Bologna, can you believe it? It's half past one in the morning here, that's why I sound like I'm under a blanket. I'm resting, I swear. Text only, that's the rule, my sister would kill me if she knew I picked up. She's been an angel, honestly. She's handling everything," she said, and laughed. "Don't you dare dust it. It's survived a hundred and ten years without your help, it can survive till Christmas."

That was my joke, about that same frame, a gilt cassetta with a split in the lower left miter, and he must have laughed at it a second time, because she held the phone away from her ear to let him finish. She had the timing, down to the small drop at the end where I let a client decide whether I was serious. She even had my habit of pressing my lips together just before the punch line, and I had not known it was a habit until somebody else did it on my front step, in the rain, from forty feet away. And she had just told an eighty-one-year-old man, in my voice, what a help she was.

"The studio? Oh, who knows, Mr. Abruzzo. I've been thinking maybe I'm done breathing solvent for a living, you know? Kidding. Mostly kidding. Text me a picture of the corner? The line here is terrible. Okay, okay. Bye-bye."

I have never in my life said bye-bye. It was the only mistake she made, and Mr. Abruzzo, who referred to me on the telephone as "the girl," would never have caught it. The other thing she said I folded away for later, like a loose flake of paint in a square of tissue.

The front door opened behind her and let out a slab of yellow light, a smell of rosemary and lamb fat I could pick up across the street, and Joan Teague in a red wrap dress, holding a napkin.

"Maud! Get in, you'll catch your death. Who on earth calls at dinner? Was that the clinic? Is it the wrist?"

"Just a client. He's a sweetheart, he's eighty-one, he wanted to talk about his frame."

"You're working? Declan, she's working! Tell her to stop."

From somewhere behind her came my husband's voice, the words lost under the rain, and a laugh from the whole table, the kind a room gives a line it has heard before and liked.

Joan pulled my sister inside by my sleeve. For the four seconds before the door shut I had the whole hall, the radiator under its painted cover and the table where I dropped my keys into a blue glazed bowl. Where the bowl should have been there was a stoneware jug of white ranunculus, cut short and packed tight, arranged by someone who used to do it for a living.

Then the door closed and took the light with it.

I stayed under the sycamore. Water had found the shoulder seams of my jacket. Fourteen weeks ago a scaffold board in a chapel near Ravenna gave way under me, and the board left me the scar through my left eyebrow and a surgeon left me the plate in my wrist, and I kept the rest. Nobody in Philadelphia had seen the eyebrow. I had made sure of that. What Brown Street had been told about was a wrist.

Tomorrow was our sixth anniversary. I had told Declan I would land on Saturday at 2:10. The clinic released me on Thursday instead, and I changed my ticket and told nobody, because for once I wanted to arrive somewhere as a surprise instead of a schedule. I had imagined the key, the hall, the smell of whatever he was making for himself. I had not imagined that he would be making it for ten.

Inside, Ray Teague got to his feet.

Ray had a voice that was built for warehouse floors and had never been told otherwise. It came through the window and across the street without losing a syllable.

"To Maud! Finally among us! Fourteen weeks, people, and look at her. Look at that color. And to Declan, who cooked, God help us all."

Ten glasses went up, and I counted them, because I count things when I don't trust what else my hands might do. My husband stood with everyone else. He lifted his glass toward the near end of the table, where my sister had sat back down in my chair with my coat over its back, and he drank, and he sat.

"Speech!" Ray roared down the table at her. "Come on, Maud, give us a speech!"

My sister put both hands up, the brace and the bare one, and shook her head and laughed, and Ray sat down complaining to the whole table that she'd gone shy on him.

I waited for him to look at the window.

It was eight feet wide and the only dark thing in that room, and it would not have been hard to find. Declan had a habit at dinners of glancing out at the street every few minutes, in case something out there needed rerouting, and I had seen him do it at a hundred tables. I gave him one minute, counted in my head the way I count a swab. Then I gave him another.

He looked at Ray, and at Joan, who was pressing the corner of her napkin under one eye, and at a woman on his right I didn't know, and at the lamb. Once, he

looked down the whole length of the table at my sister and nodded to her, a small nod, the one I had heard him give a dock supervisor over the phone when the truck was in. Then he picked up the carving knife.

Under that warm, lying light his face was the face of a tired man at the end of a long week. If you stayed on it, and I had spent my working life staying on things, it was the face of someone with nothing left to worry about. That is a different face entirely, smoother at the jaw and looser at the mouth, and I had not seen it on him in years.

I could have crossed the street. I had the key on my ring; I could feel it through the lining of my pocket with my left thumb, the brass one with the square head, and the lock was old and wanted a lift before it turned, and I knew the lift. I could have walked into my own dining room dripping on the runner and said good evening and given ten people the job of fitting what they were looking at into what they had been told. Joan would have cried properly. Cora would have said "Oh," and then, because it was what she said when a floor gave way, "Let me get you something."

And Declan would have put down the knife. I could not get further than that. I tried, and I could not find his face after the knife.

When I find a later hand under a varnish, I photograph first and scrape later. The paint has waited sixty years.

I looked at the street instead.

The brick fronts shouldered together over their iron boot scrapers, and the sycamore was letting go of its leaves into the same gutter as in August. On my top step stood a terracotta pot of rust-colored chrysanthemums with a card on a plastic stick, the ink run but legible: WELCOME HOME MAUD! XO THE DUNNS. A cloth grocery bag hung on my railing with a clean Pyrex dish in it. In Mrs. Kessler's front window the china spaniel wore a get-well balloon around its neck, gone soft and wrinkled, a month old at least. The whole block had moved two inches to make room for a woman who was resting, and doing so well.

The Dunns' front door opened behind me and their older boy came down the steps with a beagle on a leash and a hood up. He was fifteen, I thought, or near it, all wrists. He got as far as the sycamore before he looked at me.

"Oh. Hey, Mrs. Hale." He looked from me to my lit window and back. "Aren't you at your party?"

"I stepped out."

"In this?" The beagle wrapped itself once around his ankles. "My mom says you're not supposed to get the wrist wet."

"Your mom is right," I said.

"You still like the flowers? We got the orange ones. My mom said pink was wrong for you."

"It is. Thank you for them."

"Cool." He hitched the leash up over his wrist. "Okay, feel better."

He went off toward the corner, the beagle looking back at me over its shoulder.

I turned around and got back into the taxi. It smelled of pine air freshener and wet wool, my wet wool, a summer weight that had been the wrong decision since the jet bridge.

Ibrahim met my eyes in the mirror. "Somebody in there you know?"

"All of them," I said.

"That's worse," he said. "Airport, or the bag?"

"Neither. Frankford Avenue, in Kensington." I gave him the cross street. "There's an old glove factory with a neon sign in a second-floor window. The third floor is mine."

"That's not here."

"No."

"You told me this one was your house."

"It is," I said. "I'm going to work."

He thought about that for the length of a wiper stroke. "Eight o'clock on a Friday night."

"The building's empty at night. I like it empty."

"Okay," he said, the way cab drivers say it, and reached over and reset the meter, which I took as a kindness.

The door was still open on my side. I couldn't pull it with the right hand anymore, so I had to twist across myself and reach with the left, and while I was twisted like that, half out in the rain, my front door opened again. My sister came out onto the step in my coat to carry the chrysanthemums in out of the weather, because she was a good hostess and a good florist and could not leave a living thing out in the cold.

"Maud, honey, your dessert!" Joan called from my doorway, and my sister turned toward the name, and I pulled the taxi door shut.

Chapter 2 — Declan

Okay. So.

One: the dishes, tonight, all of them, so the kitchen was clean when she walked into it. Two: Cora's bags in the back of the Outback by eleven and Cora at her mother's in Havertown by noon. Three: Terminal A at 2:10, flowers from the place on Fairmount Avenue, and Maud.

It was three moves, and he had run regional networks on fewer.

He started with the dishwasher because it was the bottleneck. Ten settings in a machine built for twelve, thirty glasses, a roasting pan, the bone-handled spoons that couldn't take hot water. First load by 10:52. The stemware went by hand, Maud's rule, and he had never asked her why.

Behind him Cora was sitting on the counter by the fridge with her shoes off and the beige brace in her lap, rubbing her wrist where the elastic had left a ridged pink mark.

"Joan hugged me twice," she said. "Twice, Declan, at the door, and then again at the door, because she came back for her scarf. She said my color was so much better. She held my face, like, with both hands."

"She likes you."

"She likes Maud." Cora laughed and pressed the brace against her mouth. "Sorry. I'm so keyed up I could throw up, honestly."

"Drink some water."

"I had water. I had so much water." She turned the brace over and over. "And Ray did the toast again. 'Finally among us.' He's done it, what, four times now? And Pat Varga asked me how the physical therapy was going, and I told her about the putty, the green putty, you know, the squeezing thing, and she said her sister had the same thing with a wrist, and I just sat there being Maud's wrist for twenty minutes. And then Mr. Abruzzo called in the middle of the lamb and I had to go stand on the step."

"You told him she was in Bologna," he said, rinsing a plate.

"She is in Bologna." Cora looked at the oven clock. "For, like, sixteen more hours."

He didn't ask what else she'd told Mr. Abruzzo, or anyone. Maud's messages were Cora's to handle. That had been settled in August, in Bologna, with Maud saying it herself from a hospital bed, and it was not his queue. He set the plate in the rack and took the next one.

"Declan."

"Mm."

"What do I tell her?"

He turned off the tap. The question was simple, so he answered it simply. "Nothing. I'll tell her."

"You'll tell her yourself." Cora nodded several times, fast. "Okay. Okay, that's good. That's probably better coming from you, right? Because I'll cry, I'll just cry, and then she'll be comforting me, and that's so backwards, you know?"

"I'll tell her in the car."

"In the car." She bit the side of her thumb. "Not in the car. She'll be so tired. Tell her at home, with tea. She likes it milky, did you know that? Like, milky milky."

He did not know that. He put it in the place where he kept things to check later, and the place was fuller than it should have been.

"Okay. At home, then."

Cora slid off the counter. She folded the dish towel over the oven handle, squared it, took it off and folded it again. "I was thinking," she said, "and you can say no, obviously, it's totally your call. But maybe I could stay until Sunday? Just so there's someone around for the first day. She can't do her hair with that hand. She can't do the braid. I could do her hair and then go. I'd be invisible. I'm very good at invisible."

In Maud's apron, the blue one with the burn on the pocket, she looked exactly like his wife. Nine weeks of that, and he had stopped seeing the apron.

"What's the ask?" he said.

"That's the ask. Sunday."

"Noon tomorrow," he said. "Your mother's expecting you. I'll load the bags at eleven."

"Right, totally." She smiled, fast and bright, the smile she used on guests when a glass broke. "You're right, of course. Noon."

She picked the brace up off the counter and put it down again. "What about Joan? And Ray, and Pat, and Nadine. And the Dunns. Oh God, the Dunns and their flowers."

"I'll handle it."

"How?"

"One at a time. Starting Monday."

"Ray's going to be so weird about it."

"Ray's my problem."

She looked at him for a second as if he had given her something heavy to hold and then taken it back. "Do you think she'll be mad? Maud?"

"I think she'll be tired."

• • •

The first load went on at 10:51, one minute early.

He did the glasses at the sink with the water as hot as his hands would take, a soft cloth over two fingers inside each bowl. Thirty glasses, one at a time. He had big hands and Maud had told him once, watching him do this, that it was like watching a bear thread a needle, and she had not meant it as an insult, and he had

been oddly pleased for a week. He set each glass upside down on the towel in rows of five, because rows were faster to count.

He knew why he was doing this at eleven at night, and he did not look at it directly.

On September 11 he'd been stuck on a call with the Carlisle building about a dock door that wouldn't seal, and by the time he got home Joan had been in the house fifteen minutes. He came through the front door and heard it before he saw it: Joan in the dining room, the high happy voice, "Maud, sit, sit, don't you dare lift that," and Cora in Maud's apron by the sideboard with a corkscrew. Cora looked at him over the corkscrew. Joan turned around, beaming, to share the good news. He could see the cost of the truth from the doorway: Joan's face falling, twenty minutes about a scaffold in Italy at a dinner meant for third-quarter numbers, Ray asking about insurance, Cora mortified. Against that, a bottle that needed opening.

He took the corkscrew from Cora and opened it and poured.

It had taken three seconds.

The next Friday it was easier, because it was already true for the people at the table, and every week after that, keeping it was the option with the fewest moving parts. By October the neighbors had it. Mrs. Kessler next door had sent over a ziti. The Dunns had left a pot of mums on the top step. Nobody visited, because the story was that Maud was recovering and wasn't up to visitors. Cora had lost her apartment in August and her shop in June and, as far as he could tell, most of her reasons to get dressed in the morning. On Saturdays she put on Maud's coat and the beige brace and came back with clementines and a little color in her face.

He was being efficient: that was the phrase he'd used in his head in September, and every Friday since.

The second load was pans. He scrubbed the roasting pan with the coarse side of the sponge, left-handed, long strokes toward himself, and the lamb fat came away in gray ribbons.

His mother had cleaned office buildings in Scranton at night for twenty-two years. She left at ten and came home at six, and when he was eleven he started getting up at a quarter to six to have the eggs done before she got in, because the first time he'd seen her sit down at the kitchen table still wearing her coat, too tired to take it off, he had decided something. He had decided it the way you decide things at eleven, all at once and for good: nobody I love is going to spend energy they don't have to. Not if I can carry it. He had built a career on that sentence, fourteen buildings and eleven hundred people of it.

He put the pan in the rack and stood holding the sponge.

The house was very still. Cora had gone up to shower; the pipes knocked once in the wall. Out on Brown Street a car went by slowly in the rain. It had been like this since September. Nobody had needed anything from him in this house in nine weeks. On nights without guests Cora kept to the third floor, and she had not once asked him how his day had been in a way that required an answer longer than "Long." Maud, in Bologna, said "Nothing" every Sunday when he asked what she needed.

The quiet had suited him. That was the thing he did not want to be true, and it was true, and he put the sponge down.

• • •

Ray had stopped him at the door at 10:15 with his coat half on and Joan already down on the sidewalk under the umbrella.

"A week from Monday," Ray had said, low for Ray, which meant only the first two houses on either side could hear it. "Keep your calendar soft, Dec. Big news."

"Good big or bad big?"

"Would I come to your house and eat your lamb if it was bad?" Ray had clapped him on the arm. "Your wife looks great, by the way. Really great. Whatever they did over there, bottle it."

"I'll pass that on," Declan had said, and Ray had laughed, because he thought it was a joke.

From under the umbrella Joan had called up the steps, "Dec! Tell her I'm bringing flowers tomorrow for the anniversary, and don't you let her say no!"

• • •

At 11:20 Cora came down in a sweatshirt with her hair wet.

"I put my stuff by the door upstairs, two suitcases. And there's a box of shoes in the hall closet, sorry. And I changed the sheets up there already, so." She stood on the bottom stair. "Do you want me to wrap that?"

He had the box on the kitchen table. Plain white cardboard, a conservation supplier's label, ordered in July before any of this, a pair of headband magnifiers with two sets of lenses because Maud's old ones had a cracked hinge she kept fixing with tape. It had been in the bottom drawer of his desk since August. He had brown paper from a delivery and a roll of packing tape.

"I've got it."

"I used to do this for a living. I could do a bow, a real one. Thirty seconds."

"I've got it, Cora."

She watched him fold the paper over one end, square it, run the tape. He was not good at it. The corners came out thick. "That's really sweet, Declan. She's going to cry when she opens those."

"She needs them," he said, which was the reason he'd ordered them.

"Declan?" She had one hand on the newel post. "Thank you for letting me be useful."

"Get some sleep, Cora."

She went up, and he heard the third-floor door, then the box fan she ran all night, even in November, for the noise. Once she went up at night, she stayed up. He locked his study, as he had every night since he was twenty-two and running the night dock at a building near Tobyhanna where anything not locked walked out by morning.

He carried the box into the hall.

The jug of white flowers was on the hall table where the blue bowl used to be. He picked it up, dripping, and looked at the table, and could not have said where the bowl was or when it had gone. Somebody had moved the place where Maud put her keys, and he had walked past it twice a day and not seen it. He took the flowers into the dining room and put them on the sideboard. Then he came back and set the box on the hall table, beside the empty space where the bowl had been.

Upstairs, in their room, he set two alarms on his phone. One alarm was a single point of failure.

He set the first for six, and the backup for 6:05. He was awake at four.

Chapter 3 — Maud

My key still fit, which meant that in nine weeks nobody in that house had once thought of me as a risk.

The lock wanted its lift and I gave it the lift, left-handed, at 6:40 on Saturday morning, with my suitcase standing where Ibrahim had left it, by the freight elevator in Kensington. On the hall table, where my key bowl should have been, there was no bowl and no jug of flowers either, only a box in brown paper and packing tape with the corners folded thick and taped twice, by somebody with big hands who had never in his life wrapped anything that wasn't going on a truck. My coat was back on the third hook. I left it there for now.

The kitchen was at the back of the house and got the morning first, a low gray light that lay along the counter and showed every fingerprint on the steel of the coffee machine. It was a cruel, accurate light, and I had always liked it.

There were eggs in the pan, soft-scrambled with chives in a great deal of butter. I have refused eggs that way since I was nine. My sister was at the stove in my green flannel robe with her hair in a loose clip and her bare feet crossed at the ankle. From the doorway she looked like me on a good morning. Two steps in, she looked like me on a morning I had never had, one where somebody else had already made all the decisions and left me only the eggs.

Beside the fruit bowl lay the beige brace, folded in half. Beside the toaster, charging, lay my phone.

She turned with the spatula up.

"Oh."

It came out of her small and round. Then her face did what it had done since we were six, when she broke our mother's cut-glass dish and went straight to the broom closet before anyone could shout: it reorganized itself around being useful.

"Let me get you something."

"No."

"Coffee, there's coffee, I just made it, it's the good one, the Ethiopian, or tea, I can do tea, I know you like it with a lot of milk. Sit down, Maudie, sit, you must be so tired, you look so," and she stopped, because her eyes had gone to my eyebrow and stayed there. "Oh, it healed, it healed so nice. It's so much better than in Bologna."

"Where's Declan."

"Upstairs, shaving, he's, we thought you were landing at two, he was going to get flowers, he had a whole plan with the flowers." She put the spatula down on the granite instead of the spoon rest, and a smear of egg went across the stone, and she stared at it. From her face, it was the worst thing that had happened yet. "Sorry, sorry, I'm just all over the place. Can I make you eggs? Not these, hard ones, the way you like them, or toast. I can do toast."

"No," I said, and went to the coffee machine because it was mine and would not talk to me. A blue-and-white tea towel hung down over its face, tucked into the top of the water tank. I lifted it with two fingers. Under it, held to the steel by the magnet shaped like a lemon, was a square of notepaper in my handwriting, written on the morning of August 3, in the black felt-tip I use on Tyvek labels.

Back in 6 weeks. Call me.

The paper had yellowed where the steam wand reached it. Every morning for nine weeks my sister had made coffee eighteen inches from it.

"I didn't take it down," Cora said behind me. "I would never take it down, Maudie, I just couldn't look at it every single morning with my coffee. It made me want to cry into the mug, honestly, it made me feel like I was in the way, you know?"

"You were."

I put the towel back exactly as it had been, because I did not want to be the person in that room who changed things first.

The fourth stair from the bottom creaked, and my husband came down and stopped on the last step with a towel over his shoulder and shaving cream on the left side of his jaw. The right side was done, and he had nicked himself under the ear. He had the face of someone who had been awake since four building something careful and had just seen it fall down in the doorway of his own kitchen.

"You said tomorrow," he said.

"That's accurate."

"I was going to pick you up at Terminal A. 2:10. I had it timed to the minute, Maud, I had flowers ordered."

"I know, I gave you the time."

I took off my linen jacket and hung it on the back of a chair and did not sit in the chair. I stood with my right arm in its brace against my stomach and my left hand flat on the cold granite, and I asked the three questions I had worked out on the cot between two and five, in the order I had worked them out, starting with "How long?"

"September 11," Declan said. He did not have to think about it.

"It was only supposed to be one night," Cora said. "Just Joan, just that one dinner, because she came early, and she walked in and saw me in your apron and she just grabbed me, Maudie, she was crying, she was so glad, and Declan wasn't even home yet, and what was I supposed to do, stand there in your apron and say surprise, wrong twin?"

"Then I got home," Declan said, "and Joan was in the dining room, and Cora had the corkscrew, and she looked at me, and I took the corkscrew and opened the bottle and poured."

"You poured the wine."

"It was three seconds."

"It was nine weeks."

He nodded once, because the number was right.

"Who knows?"

He took the towel off his shoulder and folded it in half, then in half again. "Everyone who's been at the table. Ray and Joan, Nadine, Lou and Pat Varga, some of the Harrisburg people, Mrs. Kessler. The Dunns."

"The Dunns' boy," I said. "He asked me last night if I still liked the flowers."

"What do they think happened?"

"That you came home early in September," Declan said. "That you're recovering upstairs and you're not up to visitors. That you don't like to talk about the accident."

"And that you're doing so well," Cora said. "Everybody says it. Mrs. Kessler says it every single time, she says you're doing so well, Maud, you've got your color back."

"I was in Bologna," I said.

"I know, I know you were."

"Learning to hold a fork."

Cora put her hand flat on the counter as if the counter had moved.

"Every week it was easier to keep it than to undo it," Declan said. "Undoing it meant a call to everyone at that table, and Ray, and the street, and every week there were more people on the list. So every Friday the cheapest thing was to leave it one more week."

"So you kept it."

"I kept it."

"And on Sundays?"

For a second the question had no handle for him, and then it did. "On Sundays I told you the house was fine."

"I told you I was helping out," Cora said quickly. "I did tell you that, Maudie. Every Sunday I said I'm helping out at the house, don't you stress about a thing."

"Helping with what," I said.

"With, you know, with everything."

"Mr. Abruzzo," I said.

Cora blinked and said, "He called. Last night, during the lamb. I just told him you were resting, that's all, I always tell everybody you're resting."

"You told him I was done breathing solvent for a living."

"I said kidding. I said mostly kidding, Maudie, it was a joke. It was your kind of joke, the dry kind, he laughed so hard."

Declan looked from her to me. He hadn't known that one, and I watched him find out.

"It wasn't mine," I said.

On the stove the butter had gone past brown, and the smell of it filled the kitchen, and nobody moved to turn off the gas, so I reached across my sister with my left hand and turned it off myself.

"Last night," Declan said.

"Seven-thirty. I was under the Dunns' sycamore with a taxi. Ray made a toast. 'To Maud, finally among us.'" I looked at him. "You drank it."

He did not look away from me. The shaving cream had started to dry at the edges and crack, the way gesso cracks when it goes on too thick over a surface nobody prepared.

"Where has she been sleeping?" I said, to the towel in his hands.

"Third floor, in the guest room. Maud, nothing has ever, not once, not in any way, nothing."

"I didn't ask that."

"I know you didn't," he said. "I'm telling you anyway: nothing. I lock the study at night like I always have. She's upstairs with that fan going. That part is exactly what it looks like, which is nothing, and I need you to have it from me, plainly, before anything else."

"I have it," I said.

"Okay," he said, and nothing else.

"Who did you tell?"

"Nobody."

"We were going to today," Cora said. "Today, Maudie, that was the whole plan. I was going to be gone by noon, I was going to be at Mom's, and Declan was going to get you at the airport and tell you, well, not in the car, at home, with tea, I said with tea, and it was all going to be done right. Everything was going to be put back. We were going to tell you today."

"Were you."

Her mouth opened and nothing came out of it. In thirty-five years I had seen that perhaps four times.

"Does Mother know?" I said.

Cora's eyes went to Declan, then to the floor. "She knows I've been staying here."

It was true the way a clean patch on a dirty canvas is true, and it was very small.

Declan came down off the last stair into the doorway, and then he looked at me properly, at my face, now that it had stopped being a photograph. On Sunday afternoons on a laptop I had kept my hair forward and the camera low, and he had never asked me to move it. Now his eyes found the scar, two and a half inches of it, pink and puckered where the board went through my left eyebrow and up into the hairline, and stayed there. Then, before he could stop them, they went to my sister, to the same place on her face, the clean, unbroken arch of her brow, and then they came back to me.

It took him less than a second. In fourteen weeks nobody had needed to tell us apart.

"Okay," he said, and his voice went very level, the voice he uses on the phone when a load has shifted on a truck. "Okay. So. I can walk you through it, start to finish, the whole sequence. It's not complicated, it's just bad. If you'll sit down for ten minutes, I can lay out exactly what happened and when, and who was told what, and what I was going to do about each of them."

"No."

"I was helping," Cora said, and her voice cracked down the middle. "You told me to. In the hospital. Take my phone, tell everyone I'm okay. You were on so many pills you called Mom by Dad's name, and I did it, I told everyone. And then everybody was so glad, and I was so good at it, Maudie. Mrs. Kessler said I was the most gracious patient she'd ever had next door." She pressed the heel of her hand under one eye. "Sorry. I keep saying that."

"You wore my brace."

"I bought a brace at the CVS on Fairmount, it's not yours, it's beige."

"You wore my coat."

"It was cold out."

"It still is."

"Cora," Declan said, "go upstairs."

"But I want to explain, I can explain the brace, the brace was so people wouldn't try to shake your hand—"

"Go upstairs and pack the rest, please."

She looked at him, and then at me, and something went out of her shoulders that I recognized, because it had gone out of mine in Bologna when the surgeon held up the X-ray and showed me nine screws. She took the clip out of her hair and put it back in tighter, and went past me to the hall without touching me.

On the stairs she stopped.

"It's your anniversary," she said, to the banister. "Sorry, sorry, I wanted it to be nice for you."

Her feet went up two flights, and a door shut, and a fan came on.

Declan and I stood in the kitchen with the burnt eggs between us.

"I didn't know you'd come early," he said.

"No."

"If I'd known." He stopped, and the rest of the sentence arrived in his face, and he decided to say it anyway, which I will give him. "If I'd known, I'd have had her out by Thursday. I'd have found the bowl and put it back. I'd have had the guest room stripped. I'd have met you at 2:10 with the flowers and told you at home, with the tea, and every piece of it would have been back where it was when you left."

"And I'd never have seen it."

"That was the idea," he said. "Yes."

"A very good repair," I said. "Invisible."

He heard it land, and looked down at the towel he had folded into a square and tried to fold it once more, but it was too small.

"Do you want me to make you coffee?"

"No."

"Do you want me to drive you somewhere? I can take you wherever you need to go. Your mother's, or Odalys's. Or I can have Cora out of here within the hour and you can have the house. I'll go somewhere, I'll get a room, I'll stay out of your way for as long as you want."

"Declan."

He stopped, and I went to the counter and unplugged my phone. The chipped corner of the case caught on the side of my thumb where it always used to catch, and it was the first thing in that house that felt like mine. The screen lit with a column of notifications so long it scrolled. I dropped it into my bag, screen to the lining, without reading any of it.

"There's a lot on there," Cora called down the stairwell. She had, of course, been on the landing all along, listening. "I kept track of everything, I swear, I can walk you through all of it, there's some stuff on there you really need to know about before you—"

"No," I said, loud enough to carry two flights, and the landing went silent.

I went out to the hall. Declan followed two steps behind and a little to the left, where he walks in a crowd in case I need a wall. I took my coat down from the third hook.

The coat knew the shape of my shoulders. It had spent nine weeks on a pair exactly like them, and it smelled of gardenia. I have never worn gardenia. The right arm had to be worked through in stages, because the shoulder will not yet go back that far and the brace catches on the lining, and halfway through it Declan's hands came up off his sides.

"Don't," I said.

They went back down, and he stood with them open at his sides, those big careful hands, with nothing in the hall for them to carry.

I did up two buttons left-handed. I took out my key ring and worked the brass house key off the split ring. It took a long time with one thumb, and he did not offer again. I set the key down beside his badly wrapped parcel, straight, the way he would have set it.

"That's yours," he said. "The box. I ordered it in July."

"In July."

"Before. Before any of this."

I left it where it was.

The studio key I kept.

"Where are you sleeping?" he said.

"The studio."

"There's no heat in that building on weekends. Pappas turns the boiler down on Friday night."

"There's a cot."

"There's no shower, Maud."

"There's a sink."

"Do you want me to bring your suitcase over? I can have it there in twenty minutes."

"It's already there," I said.

"Maud," he said, and his voice had changed. "Today's the fourteenth."

"I know what day it is."

"Where are you going?"

“Work,” I said, and opened the front door. The rain had stopped before dawn and Brown Street was gray and shining. The Dunns’ chrysanthemums were back out on my top step, and I had walked past them at 6:40 without seeing them. My sister had been up before that, setting them where she had decided they looked best.

Behind me, from the hall, with the shaving cream dried white on his jaw, my husband said, “It’s Saturday.”

Chapter 4 — Declan

Okay. So. One: catch her on the step. Two: get her back inside, into a chair, coffee or no coffee. Three: the sequence, start to finish, in ten minutes, without stopping, without making it sound better than it was.

At 7:02 he opened the front door and the step was empty.

Brown Street was wet and gray and lit at the far end by one taxi with its engine running, idling at the corner. She'd had it wait, of course. The back door closed, the brake lights went off, and it turned toward Fairmount Avenue and was gone, and he was standing on his own top step in bare feet with shaving cream drying on half his face and the Dunns' chrysanthemums against his ankle.

"Morning, Declan!"

Mrs. Kessler was on her step next door in a quilted housecoat, bending for the Inquirer in its plastic sleeve. She was eighty and had lived on the block since the Bicentennial and had opinions about recycling.

"Was that Maud? Out already, in this cold?"

He looked at the corner where the taxi had been.

"That was Maud," he said.

It was the first true thing he had said to the street in nine weeks, and she smiled at it.

"Well, good for her. Tell her I said she looks wonderful."

He went back inside and shut the door and stood in the hall. Her house key was on the table, lined up beside the box. He picked it up, and it was warm, from her pocket or from his own hand, and he put it back down exactly where she had put it.

. . .

Cora had sat down on the third stair from the bottom with her arms around her knees.

"I heard," she said. "I heard all of it. She looked at me like I was a stain, Declan. Like I was something on a painting she was going to have to take off with a little stick."

"Bags by the door at eleven-thirty," he said. "I'll book you a car for quarter to twelve. Your mother's expecting you by one."

"She hates me."

"I'll call your mother and tell her you're on your way."

"She's never going to speak to me again. She didn't even sit down. Did you see that? She stood the whole time. She always sits." Cora pressed her forehead against her knees. "I just thought, I thought if I kept everything nice, if I kept it all so nice, then when she came back it would be like she'd had a rest, you know? Like coming home to a clean house."

"Check the bathroom. You've got stuff in the bathroom."

“Declan.”

“And the hall closet, the shoes.”

“Declan, you’re bleeding.”

He looked down at the towel in his hand. He had been wiping the shaving cream off his jaw with the towel while he talked, and he had done it hard enough to open the nick under his ear, and there was a bright spot of blood on the white cotton. He folded the towel over it so he couldn’t see it.

“It’s fine. Eleven-thirty.”

Cora wiped her face with both hands. “I have to call Joan. Oh God, and Mrs. Kessler, and the Dunns, they brought flowers, I have to go over there and tell them, I have to tell everybody, I don’t even know how you say it—”

“I’ll do it,” he said. “Let me take that off your plate.”

She looked up at him with Maud’s face, wet and blotched, and for a second she looked so grateful that he could not stand to be the thing she was grateful to, and he went into the kitchen.

• • •

The burnt eggs were still on the stove. He scraped them into the trash and scrubbed the pan and dried it and hung it on its hook, and while he was doing that he was not angry, he told himself, only sequencing. There was a list, and he was at the top of it, and anger was a cost with no output, so he kept both hands on the pan.

He broke a glass putting it away, a tumbler, nothing good. It slipped out of his left hand at the cabinet and went into four clean pieces on the counter, and he stood looking at the four pieces for a while before he swept them into his palm.

At 9:40 Pauline called.

“Declan, dear.” Her voice was soft and well-modulated, the voice of a woman who had spent thirty-one years at the front desk of an elementary school and could make “Have a seat” sound like a sentence handed down. “Corabelle just called me in pieces. In absolute pieces.”

“She’ll be with you by one.”

“Whatever Maudie said to her, I’m sure she was exhausted. All that flying. We don’t do scenes, Declan. We never have, not in this family.”

“Nobody did a scene.”

“Cora was a blessing to you both. A blessing. Who else would have dropped her whole life to look after that house? And you. She looked after you.”

“She did.”

“Men never notice what it takes to keep a house nice, dear. Corabelle noticed. She had dinner on that table every Friday for your people, and I never heard her complain.” A small pause, the length of a teacup set down. “We just think it seems a little hasty, putting her out on the street like a cat. On the anniversary, of all days.”

“Pauline,” he said, “what’s the ask?”

“Ask? I’m not asking anything, dear. I’m only saying it might be kinder to let Corabelle stay through the weekend. Until Maudie’s calmer. Until everyone’s had a chance to rest.”

“She’ll be in a car at quarter to twelve.”

“I see.” There was another pause, longer this time. “And is that what Maudie wants? Or is that what you want?”

He opened his mouth to answer and found he didn’t know.

“She’ll be with you by one,” he said again, and Pauline said she was sure she would, and hung up first.

At 10:15 his phone buzzed on the counter.

Joan: Ray says it’s the big 6 today!! Can I swing by around 3 with flowers for you two? Won’t stay, PROMISE.

He typed: *Joan, the woman at dinner last night was not Maud. It was her sister.* He looked at it and deleted it. He typed it again with “twin sister” and deleted that too, because there was no version of it that belonged in a text message to someone who had cried into her napkin at his table.

He sent: *Please don’t come by today. There’s something I need to tell you and Ray, and it has to be in person. As soon as Ray can see me.*

The reply came in under a minute. *Of course!! Is Maud ok??*

He turned the phone over on the counter and left it there.

• • •

At 11:48 a white Camry pulled up outside and Cora came down the stairs with two suitcases, the big blue one and the carry-on, bumping them one step at a time because she would not let him carry them. She had changed into jeans and her own coat, a short black thing with a fake-fur collar, and her hair was in its clip, and she had put on lipstick. He couldn’t tell if it was for the driver, or Havertown, or herself.

“The good dish towels are in the dryer,” she said at the door. “And there’s soup in the freezer, the white bean, the label says Thursday. And I left the guest room stripped, the sheets are in the machine, you just have to switch it. And the brace is in the trash, I put it in the trash. Sorry. Sorry about all of it.” She stood with one hand on the handle of the big suitcase. “Tell her the soup’s for her. She likes white bean.” She looked down at the suitcase handle. “Will you text me later? Just to say if she’s okay? You don’t have to say anything else.”

“I’ll text you.”

“Okay, thank you, okay.”

He did not know whether that was true either.

He carried the big suitcase down the steps, because she couldn’t stop him on the steps, and the driver popped the trunk. Mrs. Kessler was back out on her step with a watering can, watering nothing, a pot of dead geraniums she had not dealt with since October.

“Maud, honey!” she called. “Are you off to the doctor? Is it that hand again?”

Cora stopped with one foot off the curb. She looked at Declan, and her face asked him the question it had been asking all morning, and he answered it.

"Mrs. Kessler," he said, "this is Cora. Maud's sister."

The watering can tipped, and a thin stream ran down onto the step.

"Her sister."

"Her twin. Maud's been in Italy since August. She got home last night."

Mrs. Kessler looked at Cora, and then at Declan, and then down at her own wet slippers. "Then who," she said, and stopped, and started again. "I sent ziti," she said. "In October. I sent over a ziti."

"I know. It was very good. That's on me, Mrs. Kessler. Not on Cora."

Cora got into the back of the Camry without a word and shut the door herself. Mrs. Kessler set the watering can down on her step, carefully, as if it had become valuable, and went inside her house and closed the door, and he heard the deadbolt.

• • •

He did it in the study, because that was where he did things.

He put on his glasses and opened a spreadsheet and typed a title in the first cell, then four column headers: Issue, Owner, Fix, Due. Six rows took him the afternoon, and he checked each one twice.

Tern leadership believe Cora is Maud (Teague x2, Okoro, Varga x2, Harrisburg) / DH / In person, Ray first / Mon 11/16.

Neighbors (Kessler, Dunn) / DH / Door to door / Sun 11/15. Kessler done 11/14.

Cora resident at house / DH / Relocated to Havertown / Done 11/14.

Maud housing / DH / House is yours; DH to short-term rental, three options attached / Sun 11/15.

Anniversary / DH / Sabine's, 7:30, table held / Sat 11/14.

The sixth row he left for last. He typed Trust, tabbed to Owner and typed DH, then tabbed to Fix, and the cursor blinked, and after a while he typed Ongoing under Due and left Fix empty.

He saved it as Remediation Plan v1 and wrote the email in three lines.

Maud, this is where I'm starting. Every line on it is mine. Tell me what's wrong with it and I'll fix it. D.

He sent it at 4:10.

At 4:11 her reply came in. He opened it with his glasses still on.

No.

He took his glasses off, folded them and put them in his shirt pocket. He looked at the one word for a while, the way he looked at a load figure that came in wrong, waiting for it to correct itself, and it did not. Then he picked up the phone and called Sabine's, the eleven-table place on Fairmount Avenue where she always ordered the trout.

"Sabine's, good afternoon."

"Hi. Hale, two people, seven-thirty tonight."

“Yes, Mr. Hale, I have you right here. Oh, and it says anniversary here. Congratulations! We’ll do something nice with the dessert.”

“We won’t need the table.”

“Oh, I’m so sorry. Do you want me to move you to another night? We have next Saturday at eight.”

“No,” he said. “Thank you. Give it to someone else.”

When he came out of the study he pulled the door shut behind him and turned the key, the way he had every night for sixteen years. His hand did it on its own, and he stood on the landing holding the key in the lock, with nobody upstairs, nobody in the house at all.

He turned the key back and opened the door and left it open.

• • •

At 7:10 he put on his coat. In the hall he picked up the parcel and held it, and thought about putting it on the passenger seat, and put it back down beside her key.

The drive to Kensington took eighteen minutes on a Saturday night. He parked across Frankford Avenue from the old glove factory, under the one streetlight on that side of the block, and turned the engine off. The building was dark on the ground floor. On the second floor a red neon sign in Hamid’s window said OPEN 24 HRS. It had never been true. On the third floor, behind the tall north windows, one light was on, a low, hard, white one, the kind she worked under.

He did not ring the bell, and he did not call. He sat with his hands on the wheel at ten and two and watched her window, and every so often a shadow crossed it, and once he thought it stopped at the glass, but it was too far to tell. Two blocks over the El came through, and he timed it without meaning to, every eleven minutes, nine trains in all. At 7:30 he thought about the trout, and at 8:15 the shadow stopped crossing. At 9:00 the white light was still on.

On the dashboard his phone lit once, for nothing, and showed him the last thing she’d sent.

No.

Chapter 5 — Maud

“Boiler is off,” Mr. Pappas said through the door. “You know the boiler is off. Eight years you rent from me, eight years you know this.”

It was ten to eight on Sunday morning. I had slept in my coat on the cot under the quilted blanket I keep for wrapping frames, and when I opened the door my breath went out ahead of me into the corridor and hung there and settled the argument before he could make it. He had a radiator heater on a hand truck, the brown oil-filled kind with fins, and a shoebox under one arm. His eyes went to my left eyebrow and stayed there.

“Hamid calls me,” he said. “Two nights your light is on. He says, Mr. Pappas, the lady is back, she is sleeping up there in the cold like a cat in a garage.”

“Hamid was in the building on a Saturday night?”

“His sign says twenty-four hours.”

“His sign has never been right.”

“Last night it was right.” He wheeled the heater past me across floorboards that a century of glove cutters had worn into shallow valleys. “Where do you want it, by the bench or by the bed?”

“By the cot.”

He plugged it in, crouching with a grunt, then stood and pointed from the work lamp to the outlet and back. “Not on the same with this one. Lamp and heater together, the breaker goes. You call me Sunday, I don’t answer. Panel is by the elevator. Third switch.”

“Third switch.”

“So,” he said, and set the shoebox on my bench beside the vise. “Your mail. From September I keep it. Before that, the other one came for the bills, and I give her what I had.”

“Which other one?”

“Your sister. Very nice. She says thank you three times, thank you, thank you, Mr. Pappas, thank you so much. You say thank you one time if I’m lucky, and you say it to the radiator.”

“That’s accurate,” I said, to the radiator.

“So after, I keep the mail.” He studied my face again, the way he looks at a water stain on a ceiling to decide whether it is old or getting worse. “From the fall, this?”

“A scaffold board, in a chapel.”

“My brother, a ladder, 1979. Same eyebrow. Forty years he tells girls it was a knife.”

“And did that ever work for him?”

“He married two times.” He took the hand truck by its handles. “Rent is the first. Same like always.”

“Thank you for the heater, Mr. Pappas.”

“See,” he said from the corridor, “one time.”

• • •

The studio light came from the north, through four tall factory windows with wire in the glass, and at eight on a November morning it fell flat and colorless across the long bench with its clamps and jars of swab sticks and across the big table under its dust sheet, so that every surface in the room told the truth about itself and nothing looked kind. My old headband magnifier hung on its hook with the cracked hinge taped in three places. The place smelled of rabbit-skin glue and, very faintly, when the radiators came up on a Monday, of lanolin, which was the gloves.

I wanted coffee more than I wanted anything else in Philadelphia.

I had bought a jar of instant at the store under the El, and I got the lid a quarter turn with my right hand before the tremor started at the base of the thumb, fine and fast, like a phone vibrating in another room, and the hand quit. So I stood the jar upright in the jaws of the frame vise on the end of my bench, closed them until the glass ticked, and turned the lid with my left hand, and it came.

I drank the coffee at the window in my coat. Across Frankford Avenue the streetlight was off for the day. On Saturday night a gray Outback had sat under it from half past seven until nine, and I had stood at this window with the work lamp behind me, so that he could see me and I could not see him, and neither of us had done anything about it.

The shoebox held catalogs, and under them the October statement for Alder Conservation. I opened the statement with my teeth and read one line of it three times.

10/09 OUTGOING TRANSFER ST WENCESLAUS PARISH 11,400.00

It was the deposit, to the dollar, for a painting I had touched through exactly one small window. Under it the closing balance sat in its box looking unbothered, a figure I would once have called thin and would now have called brave.

At three that morning on the cot I had made a rule, because a rule is the only thing I know how to make at three in the morning: texts and email were my sister’s voice in my name, and I would read them later, sitting down, in order, under a good light, an inch at a time, the way you go through a canvas somebody else has already worked on, but voicemail was other people.

Of forty-one voicemails, thirty-eight had no blue dot, so somebody had already listened.

I played them oldest first. My dentist. Mr. Abruzzo, wanting to know when the girl was coming back. Odalys, the week I fell: “Alder, I don’t care what the rule is, I don’t care if it’s text only, you pick up this phone or I’m getting on a plane.” And on Thursday, October 8, at 4:52, a man clearing his throat.

“Ms. Alder, good afternoon. Walter Wozniak, at St. Wenceslaus. I have your email of this morning, and I’ve shared it with Father Kowal and the committee, as you asked. The committee accepted your withdrawal with regret, Ms. Alder. With

real regret. We'll see to the deposit on our end once it comes. Please don't trouble yourself to call back. You're in our prayers, and I hope the hand mends."

As you asked. I played it twice. The next was his too, from last Wednesday.

"Ms. Alder, forgive me, it's Walter Wozniak again. I said I wouldn't trouble you, and here I am. It's about your little window, the blue corner. The Monsignor's office tells us we're to hang the painting for Christmas Eve as it stands, and Father worries that corner will look like a hole in it, to people who don't know. Our maintenance man has offered to paint it in to match. I didn't like to let him without asking you. One word would do. Thank you, Ms. Alder."

Last Wednesday my phone had been in my sister's coat pocket, which was my coat pocket. She had listened to this, and two days later she had set the table for ten.

I put the mug down, because my right hand had started again and I did not want to watch it.

The newest message still had its dot, my mother, from last night at 6:15. "Maudie, it's Mother. Corabelle is here. She hasn't eaten a thing. We'd all like you to call when you've had a chance to rest. We don't do this, Maudie. We never have."

A text slid across the top of the screen, and I read it, because a banner is not the same as opening something.

Cora: There's white bean soup in the freezer at the house. It's for you. Sorry. You don't have to answer

I put the phone in the shoebox with the catalogs, screen to the cardboard.

• • •

Odalys came at one, up the stairs, because she has never trusted the elevator, with a tote bag in each hand.

"Alder," she said from the doorway, and looked at my face, the brace, the blanket on the cot, the jar of coffee standing in the vise, and my face again. "Damn, Alder."

"Hello, Odalys."

"Hello, she says to me, like I'm the mailman." She came across the room and hugged me with her chin hooked over my left shoulder, keeping clear of the right side as if somebody had shown her the X-ray, and then she held me off by the elbows. "What did they do to your eyebrow?"

"It's the same face with a line through it."

"It's a good line. You look like you won a duel. My mother made soup, chicken and rice, two quarts, and if you don't eat it she'll know. Where's your microwave?"

"I don't have a microwave."

"Of course you don't have a microwave." She looked at the vise. "Is that coffee in a vise?"

"The lid wouldn't open with this hand."

"So you clamped it in a vise like a frame."

“And then it opened.”

She stood there in her coat with her keys in her hand, and I watched her choose which of forty things to say first. She looked furious around the eyes. If you waited, it was something worse: she had been right for five weeks with nobody to tell, and it had thinned her mouth.

“You told me you were done with restoration,” she said. “In October. I thought it was the concussion.”

“I did not.”

“Alder, I got a text from you every day.”

“Every single day?”

“Since the end of August. Good morning, how’s the museum, what’s on your bench, send me a picture. You have never in your life texted anyone every day. You don’t send texts, you send verdicts.” She shoved the keys in her pocket. “And they sounded like you, which was the creepy part. They sounded like you on a good day.”

“I don’t have good days by text.”

“That’s what bothered me. So the second week of October I called your mother, because you weren’t picking up and she was.” She did the voice before I could stop her, soft and level, the front desk of an elementary school. “‘Maudie’s sleeping sixteen hours a day on those pills, dear, and the doctors want no telephone calls. She asked me specially to keep you from flying over. She’d hate to be seen like this. You know how private she is.’” Odalys dropped the voice. “And you are. So the first time I had a ticket open, I closed it.”

“My mother has never once in her life called me private,” I said. “She calls me difficult.”

She took her phone out and held it, locked. “I screenshot everything when something smells wrong, it’s a sickness, I have a whole folder. You want to see?”

“Not today.”

“Fine, hell, fine,” she said, and put it away at once, because she is that kind of friend. “When you want.”

She set the soup on the hot plate in my one saucepan, and I told her the rest while she stirred, the stoop and the coat and the table for ten, then the eggs and the note on the coffee machine with the towel somebody had hung over it. I told it in order and without adjectives, because adjectives were how my sister talked.

“Did Declan know?” Odalys said, to the soup.

“He knew she was being me at his table.”

“And he just let her do it.”

“He poured the wine.”

She put the spoon down. “What does that even mean?”

“It means Joan Teague called my sister by my name, and my sister looked at him, and he opened a bottle.”

“Oh, hell, Alder.”

“It took three seconds, he says.”

“Are you leaving him?”

Nobody had asked me that yet, including me. "I'm living in a glove factory."
"That's not an answer, Alder."

"It's an address."

She ladled soup into my mug, squeezed a lime over it, and stood over me while I ate the first spoonful left-handed. Then she worked a brass key off her own ring, a dab of pink nail polish on its head, and set it on the bench.

"My shower, in Fishtown, eight minutes on the El. Don't argue, you smell like a frame shop."

"I always smell like a frame shop."

"You smell like one that's been sleeping in its coat." She sat on the cot and pulled her knees up. "Frances called me in October."

I set the mug on the bench.

"She wanted to know if you'd said anything to me about quitting. I said you'd told me you were done. She said 'Hm,' and hung up, and she's sent me to voicemail ever since. Frances Tilley taught me to lay a facing, and now she sends me to voicemail."

"What did I say to her?"

"I don't know. She wouldn't tell me." Odalys looked at me over her knees. "Alder, what else did you say?"

I told her about Walter and the deposit, and the maintenance man with his tin of paint, and the three days that message had sat in my sister's pocket. The heater ticked four times before Odalys got up off the cot.

"They want to paint over your window."

"Their maintenance man wants to."

"Listen to me and call him." She put my phone into my left hand. "Right now, Alder, before somebody hands that man a brush."

• • •

Walter Wozniak answered on the fourth ring, with a football crowd behind him making the sound a crowd makes when it has decided not to hope.

"Wozniak."

"Mr. Wozniak, it's Maud Alder."

"Ms. Alder." The crowd dropped away. "Good afternoon. You sound well. I trust you'll forgive the second message, since I'm aware I said I wouldn't."

"Please don't let anyone paint the corner."

"No, ma'am, of course not, if you'd rather. We'll leave it be."

"Thank you." Odalys stood at the window with her arms folded, watching Frankford Avenue. "Mr. Wozniak, the email you got on October 8, withdrawing from the contract."

"Yes, ma'am, I have it here."

"I didn't write it."

There was no sound on the line then, not even the crowd. The second hand of the clock over the sink went once around, and I stood with my right hand closed in

its brace against my stomach and waited, because he had spent forty years in pipe and would not answer until he knew what he was holding.

“Ms. Alder,” he said, “then who did?”

Chapter 6 — Maud

Somebody had taped the Tyvek down over my painting with blue painter's tape, which was the wrong tape, and written DO NOT TOUCH across it in black marker, which was the right instinct.

"That was me," Walter Wozniak said. "The tape, I mean. I'm told it's the wrong kind."

"It's the wrong tape, but the rest was right."

He inclined his head as if I had pinned a medal on him slightly crooked.

I had not answered his question on the telephone. At nine exactly his 1998 Buick had stopped outside the glove factory, and he drove me to Port Richmond at the speed limit, in a tie, without once asking about the email.

"How is the hand?" he said instead, at the light on Allegheny.

"Slow, and it shakes when it's tired."

"Mine went that way after a valve fell on it in 1988. Slow is still a hand." He looked at the light. "In 2011 we had a contractor on the church roof, from Delaware County. \$60,000 and two weeks of good weather, and he left us a tarp."

"Did you ever get the money back?"

"The tarp, we kept." He signaled, though there was nobody behind us. "I tell you so you know we've been here before, Ms. Alder. We're not easily surprised. We're easily disappointed."

He was saving his question, I thought, for when he could see my face.

The parish hall basement smelled of fifty years of fish fries and pierogi sales, and its cinderblock walls were painted a green that somebody in 1970 had chosen for being soothing. The bingo board's numbers were dark. My painting lay flat on four folding tables under its sheet, seventy-four inches by fifty, the size of a door, with two space heaters glowing orange beside it, close enough to warm your shins.

"Who put the heaters there?"

"Me," said a voice from the corner, and a very small woman in a purple knitted hat stood up off a folding chair beside a radio. "It's cold down here for the baby."

"Mrs. Bernadette Hajek," Walter said. "Mrs. Hajek, this is Ms. Alder."

"I know who it is." She came across the linoleum in rubber boots and looked up at me, at the brace, and longest at my eyebrow. She was eighty-two and came up to my collarbone. "You were here in July with the little stick."

"The swab, yes. Mrs. Hajek, those heaters dry the canvas on one side and not the other, and the paint doesn't like it."

"The baby doesn't like it?"

"The paint doesn't like it."

"So move them," she said, when she had considered it. "But not far."

Walter moved them while I watched where the cords went. Her radio was tuned to WRTI and playing a cello, turned down low enough for church.

A man came down the stairs two at a time in clerical trousers and a Phillies fleece, with a Wawa coffee in each hand.

"Ms. Alder, Tomasz Kowal. Walter said you'd be cold and Bernadette said you'd be thin, and I can only fix one of those." He saw the brace and moved the cup into my left hand without breaking stride. "We were very sorry to lose you in October, and then very confused to get you back on a Sunday afternoon. Walter came to the rectory after the football and stood in my kitchen holding his hat in both hands, which he does when it's serious. When it's not serious, he uses one hand."

"Father," Walter said.

"I'm making her comfortable. Go on, then, we've all been waiting to see if you still like it."

. . .

I had Walter take the far corners and lift on my count, and he walked the sheet back toward the stairs the way I imagine he once lowered a valve into place, with total attention to the end he couldn't see.

The Adoration of the Shepherds was painted in a Munich workshop in 1886 for a church full of coal-pier men and railroad men and their wives, and under fluorescent tubes the whole surface had the color of tea left too long in the cup, the old resin varnish gone amber and then brown, so that the shepherds kneeling on the left had gone the brown of their own great-grandfathers' photographs. I held my flashlight low against the edge of the canvas, almost flat, and the raking light ran across the lower third and showed what the tubes were hiding: paint lifting in small cupped plates along the bottom, each one waiting for a thumb or a draft.

"What's that doing at the bottom?" Father Tomasz said. "It looks like fish scales."

"It's lifting. The canvas moves and the paint doesn't, and eventually it lets go."

"Is that bad?"

"Those two are worse." I pointed the flashlight at two flakes near the edge that had come away entirely and lay loose on the surface, curled at the rims. "They weren't loose in July."

"That's the heaters," Walter said quietly.

"That's a hundred and forty years," I said. "The heaters helped."

At the center, under the brown, the Virgin looked down at the Child with a face I did not believe.

"That's Leon's," Mrs. Hajek said at my elbow.

"Who was Leon?"

"Leon Wrobel, he painted signs. In 1957 the face was all cracks, falling off, and Father Mazur asks him to fix it, and he fixes it." She sniffed and went on. "Easter Sunday they take the sheet off. My mother sees it, she says, that's Helen Wrobel, that's his wife. My mother never forgave him."

It was Helen Wrobel. Once you had been told, there was no getting back out of it, the high smooth pink cheeks, the eyebrows plucked into two thin perfect arches over a lipsticked mouth, a nice-looking woman from 1957 receiving the shepherds as if she were being photographed for the bulletin, and my jaw set at it, at a careful man's careful job laid over the damage so that nobody would have to look at the damage.

"Half the parish thinks that's the Virgin," Father Tomasz said, "and the other half thinks it's Helen Wrobel, and the overlap is bigger than you'd expect."

"Father," said Walter.

I let the flashlight drop to the lower right corner.

My window was where I had left it in July, two inches by three at the hem of the Virgin's mantle, and it was blue, a cold, clear, deep blue, nothing like the brown that passed for blue everywhere around it, the blue of the sky over the Schuylkill on the one January morning a year when the wind has scoured it clean.

"Oh, look at that," Father Tomasz said. "I'd forgotten it was so blue."

"It's all like that under there?" Walter said.

"Some of it is, and some of it is gone. That's what I find out."

"And the face, Leon's face?" Mrs. Hajek said.

"Leon's face comes off."

She looked at it for a while with her mouth pressed small. "Good," she said. "Underneath, maybe she's ugly, maybe old. That's okay."

I unrolled my tools at the head of the table, because I needed to know, and took out a scalpel with a number-ten blade and held it as I have held one since I was twenty-four, over the bare wooden edge of the stretcher, where it could do no harm. The tip moved a millimeter one way and a millimeter back, steady as a metronome. Against the canvas it looked like nothing, and under a loupe it would have been a canyon.

I put it back in the roll.

Mrs. Hajek opened her handbag, took out something twisted in waxed paper, and folded it into my right palm around the edge of the brace with her small cold fingers.

"Lemon," she said. "Suck it, don't chew, kochanie. It's for the hands."

Walter waited until I had unwrapped it left-handed.

"Ms. Alder, yesterday you told me you didn't write the email."

"I didn't write it."

"Then I have to ask you again, and I apologize for it. Who did?"

The candy was very sour. The parish already had one lie on the table between us, a sign painter's wife where the Mother of God should be, and I was not going to hand them my sister to hang beside it.

"Someone who had my phone and my passwords while I was in the hospital," I said. "It's been dealt with, and it won't happen again."

He looked at me for a long time, his hat in one hand, while behind him Father Tomasz studied the bingo board.

"If I may, Ms. Alder," Walter said. "This parish has been lied to by professionals before. I would rather be lied to by someone I've met."

I did not correct him. That was an answer, and he took it as one.

"So," Father Tomasz said brightly, "the bad news, because Walter will go around it for twenty minutes like a truck backing into an alley. Do you want to sit?"

"No, thank you."

"Nobody sits for me, it's the collar. After your email, the one that wasn't yours, I had to report the withdrawal to the Archdiocese, because we re-dedicate at the Midnight Mass on Christmas Eve for the hundred and fortieth anniversary of the founding, and the Archbishop may come. When the Archbishop may come, anything on a wall goes through Monsignor Pellegrino first, at the Commission for Sacred Art and Architecture. You'll adore him." He paused and thought better of it. "You won't. He's very dry."

"The Commission approved my plan in May."

"And then the conservator withdrew, by email, for her health. So now he wants an independent senior conservator to certify the plan before anybody touches it, and to sign off at the end, on paper."

"You named one in your proposal," Walter said. He took a manila folder from under his arm and opened it on the bingo table, well away from the canvas. "As your consulting reviewer, Ms. Frances Tilley. I wrote to her at the end of October."

He gave me a sheet of cream paper folded in thirds. I knew the paper before I knew the hand, the same heavy laid stock from the same shop in Media for forty years, and the fountain pen she won't have serviced, so that every downstroke blots.

"What does she say?" Mrs. Hajek said from her chair. "Read it out, my eyes are no good."

"Dear Mr. Wozniak. I regret I cannot certify a treatment plan whose conservator has withdrawn from it and from the field. Please do not write to me again on this matter. F. Tilley."

"Not a nice lady," said Mrs. Hajek.

"She's the best there is."

"So she's both," said Mrs. Hajek. "It happens."

From the field. I folded the letter back along its own creases and handed it to Walter, and my left hand did that perfectly well.

"So, no certification, no treatment," Father Tomasz said. "The Monsignor's view is that we hang it as it is. Gus, our maintenance man, who is a saint, has offered to give it a good wipe first with his wife's furniture polish."

"Absolutely not."

"I said he was a saint, I didn't say he was a conservator. Without you, the parish gets Helen Wrobel for its birthday, slightly shinier, with your blue corner showing like a hole in her skirt, and Bernadette's mother would be thrilled."

"She'd be furious," Mrs. Hajek said, without looking up. "She was always furious."

I looked down at my window. Five weeks and three days, for work I had given eight months in May. Eight months had a lining in it and a full campaign of retouching. Five weeks could hold only what had to happen before she went back on a wall: the lifting paint laid down, the dirt and the brown varnish off, Wrobel off her face. The rest could come back to my studio in the summer. My right hand was going in its brace, very fine, a moth against a window.

"Ms. Alder," Walter said, "with respect, can you do it?"

"Not with this hand."

"Then how?"

"I'll do it with someone else's."

"Whose hands?"

"I'll tell you when I know. I'll get Frances Tilley in a room with this painting before the twenty-fourth, and she'll sign or she won't, and if she won't, Gus can have his polish. Until then nobody touches it except me. And it can't stay down here, so it comes to my studio tomorrow."

"Before she's certified anything?" Father Tomasz said.

"The bottom edge won't wait for her. Those flakes have to go down this week or they go in a vacuum cleaner."

"And if she never signs?"

"Then you've lost nothing but my time, and you get your painting back flatter than you gave it to me."

"And you?" Walter said. "What do you lose?"

"Mr. Wozniak," I said, "I'll tell you that when I know, too."

Walter looked at Father Tomasz. Father Tomasz looked at the blue corner, and then up at me, and for once didn't make a joke.

"Walter," he said, "you've got a pen."

He uncapped his pen over a sheet of parish letterhead and looked up at me.

"The May plan, first phase," I said. "Consolidation, cleaning, the overpaint off the face. Lining and retouching next summer, on a separate letter."

"First phase," Walter said, writing, and read it back.

"The fee for that phase, as it stood in May."

"\$38,000."

"And no deposit."

He stopped writing. "Ms. Alder, the committee would be glad to—"

"No deposit, payment on completion, conditional on certification by an independent senior conservator acceptable to the Commission."

"Acceptable to the Commission," he wrote. "And the location?"

"Alder Conservation, Frankford Avenue, the painting returned and hung by the morning of December 24."

Walter signed for the committee and Father Tomasz for the parish, and then they gave me the pen.

I signed left-handed, and what came out was my name in somebody else's handwriting, slow and rounded with a wobble in the d, like a forgery by someone

who had only seen the original from across a room, and Walter blotted it with the side of his hand and said nothing.

I called Ike Sobczak from the bottom of the stairs, where there was one bar. He and his son have moved every painting I have treated since 2017.

"Tomorrow?" he said. "Maud, I've got a sideboard in Chestnut Hill tomorrow."

"Eleven o'clock, Port Richmond to Kensington. Seventy-four by fifty, flat, face up, and the paint's lifting along the bottom. It doesn't tilt, it doesn't touch anything, and nobody puts a hand on the front."

I could hear him looking at a calendar he had already decided to change.

"I heard you quit," he said.

"You heard wrong."

"So who's carrying your end at the studio?"

"Eleven o'clock, Ike."

"Eleven, flat, face up," he said.

When I came back up, Mrs. Hajek had moved her chair beside the painting and sat with her handbag on her knees and her boots together, a woman at a bus stop who means to be first on.

"Somebody has to watch him till tomorrow," she said.

"Bernadette," Walter said, "you can't sit down here all night."

"I sat up nine nights with my husband, so this is one."

I put the Tyvek back myself, left-handed, a corner at a time, all but the last fold. Walter took that one from me without being asked and laid it down so gently it did not move the air.

I did not have a hand. I had five weeks and a painting.

Chapter 7 — Maud

It took Ike Sobczak, his son Lukasz, eleven minutes and one word from Lukasz that I will not repeat to get *The Adoration of the Shepherds* out of the freight elevator and across my studio without once letting it tip past level.

“Sorry,” Lukasz said to the painting, when it was down.

“It’s heard worse,” said Ike. “It lived in a church basement with the bingo.”

My easel table is a nine-foot glove-cutting table Mr. Pappas sold me for a dollar, with a hinged steel top that tilts on a ratchet to forty-five degrees, and today it stayed flat. The two of them lowered the painting onto the clean Tyvek I had laid out at seven as if they were setting down a sleeping child they did not want to have to settle twice.

“Your end’s dipping,” Ike said.

“My end is not dipping.”

“It’s dipping, Lukasz, look at the lady’s face.”

Lukasz looked at my face and brought his end up an inch.

“Where’s your guy, the tall kid, Teo?” Ike said, coiling a strap around his forearm.

“Teo’s been in Boston since September.”

“So who’s doing your heavy?”

“Nobody yet.”

Lukasz pulled out one earbud. “I could do it for you. I got steady hands, I build model trains, HO scale, and I do all the wiring with tweezers.”

“Do you have five weeks of evenings?”

He gave it real thought. “I got a girlfriend, though.”

“Then no.”

“Fair enough,” said Lukasz, and put the earbud back.

“He’d have been good,” Ike said. “He’s slow, and slow’s what you want with these, right?”

“Slow, and exactly where I tell him.”

“Yeah, well, that’s not him.” Ike folded the blankets over his arm and held out his clipboard. “Sign for it, your left’s fine.”

I signed, and looked at what I had written. “It doesn’t look like my signature.”

“Nobody’s looks like theirs on a clipboard.” At the gate he looked back at the sheet, and at my brace. “Maud, that thing I heard about you quitting, I didn’t believe it.”

“You told me yesterday that you heard it.”

“I heard it, and I didn’t believe it.” He hauled the gate across. “Different thing.”

For two hours I did what can be done with one hand, which is look, and numbered the losses along the bottom edge in left-handed capitals that leaned downhill: ninety-one areas of lifting paint, each needing a tacking iron held a hair off the surface for exactly as long as it took.

At twenty past one I took down the test canvas I keep on the back of the door, a thrift-store seascape painted in about 1974 by someone who had never seen a lighthouse, and rolled a swab across its sky with my right hand. For forty seconds it was almost my hand. At forty-one the tremor came up from the thumb, and at forty-five the swab skated and left a smear the width of a pencil. On the lighthouse it was a smear, and on the Virgin's mantle it would have been a loss I would have to number and explain.

I put the swab in the bin and got out my phone.

Teo picked up on the second ring, out of breath, in a corridor in Boston. "Maud? Oh my God, Maud, are you okay? I heard you quit, I heard you weren't talking to anyone."

"Can you come back for five weeks?"

"You mean right now, this month?" A door banged on his end. "Is it the hand, is it bad?"

"It shakes when I ask it for anything fine."

"How bad is bad, Maud?"

"Bad enough that I'm calling you."

"Oh, Maud." I heard him lean on a wall. "I just started here, and they gave me a treatment on Monday, a whole Copley portrait. After New Year's I'd come in a heartbeat, I'd sleep on your cot."

"After New Year's is too late."

"Maud, I'm so sorry about this."

"Do the Copley well."

"Who else have you got?"

"You were the first call."

"What about Declan, who rebuilt your bench that time?"

"He has a job, Teo."

"Everybody has a job, Maud."

Kofi Mensah, who had interned beside me in Baltimore, was kind for a full minute before he got to it.

"I'd have to square it with Frances first, you know how she is about her people, and Maud, the thing is, she told me you'd left the field. She said if I heard from you, I should stop asking her about you."

"She said that to you. Did she say why?"

"Only that you'd written to her, and she wouldn't say what." There was a pause on the line. "She was upset, Maud, and I've never heard her upset. Let me call her for you."

"Please don't call her, Kofi."

The third, Ruth Akers, a paper conservator in Wilmington, said yes before I had finished. “Tuesdays and Thursdays and every other Saturday, and I’ll bring my own loupe. Oh, Maud, I’m so glad you’re back.” Forty minutes later she called again.

“I’m so sorry, I looked at my calendar properly, and it’s just not going to be possible after all.”

“Who did you talk to?”

“I’m sorry?”

“Who did you talk to, in the forty minutes?”

“Maud, please don’t make me say.”

“You don’t have to say.”

The pause was long enough to be its own answer. “I really am sorry, Maud.”

I sat down on the end of the cot and looked at my right hand, lying on my knee in its black brace like something I had been asked to hold for somebody else, until it stopped being my hand and became a problem, and then I went looking for the other half of the problem: a pair of hands in Philadelphia that would stay where I put them four hours a night and would not shake.

He washed glasses by hand because I had asked him to once, and he had never asked why, thirty at a time, a soft cloth over two fingers inside each bowl. I had told him it was like watching a bear thread a needle. His hands had not shaken then, and they had not shaken on the eleventh of September, either, opening a bottle of wine.

It would not be a favor. I had stopped asking him for favors in the spring, around the time he stopped noticing I had stopped, and I was not going to start again in a glove factory with my hair unwashed.

At 2:47 I called him.

“Maud,” he said, picking up before it had properly rung, and behind him a room full of people were being quiet on purpose. “Hold on, let me get out of here.” A door shut behind him. “Are you okay, are you warm enough? Pappas turns the boiler down on—”

“Come to the studio at six.”

“Okay.”

“Today, at six, not tomorrow.”

“Is it the hand, did something happen?”

“Six, Declan.”

I could hear him already working it, the bridge, the exit. “I’m in Conshohocken, so if I leave at five-twenty I can be there at six.”

“Then leave at five-twenty.”

“Do you want me to bring anything, like dinner? Your winter boots are in the hall closet, or I could bring the rest of your—”

“Nothing.”

“I’ll be there at six,” he said.

At 5:51 the freight elevator ground up to the third floor, and then there was nothing for nine minutes while he waited in the corridor for the clock. At six exactly he knocked twice.

"It's open."

He came in wearing the gray overcoat, collar undone and no tie. He looked once around the room, the way he looks around a building he has been sent to fix, and his eyes stopped on the white shape under its sheet.

Then, before I had said a word, he took his phone out of his coat and laid it glass-down in the stoneware bowl on the shelf by the door.

The rule is as old as the bowl, because a phone buzzing against a bench at the wrong second has cost more than one painting its eyelashes. I had told him once, in 2019, and I had not known he kept it.

"It hasn't changed," he said. "I've been up here four times."

"Five times. You're forgetting the frame you carried up in 2021."

"Five times, then," he said.

The one chair stayed where it was. I stood behind the bench and rested my left palm on the wood, and the bench was between us, where I wanted it.

"You owe me nine weeks," I said.

"Yes."

"You can pay it in evenings."

He waited for the rest of the sentence, and when there wasn't any, he said what he says on the phone to people who talk around a problem.

"What's the ask?"

"That's the ask."

He looked at me, and at the sheet, and nodded once, slowly. "Okay."

"Six to ten, Monday to Friday, and eight to six on Saturdays, until the twenty-fourth of December, and Sundays I work alone."

He had nothing to write it on, with his phone in the bowl, so he was memorizing it.

"You do exactly what I tell you and nothing else. You don't fix anything and you don't decide anything, and if you think something should be done, you ask me, and if I say no, it's no."

"Yes."

"Your phone goes in the bowl by the door."

"It's already in the bowl."

"I can see that it is." I had meant to say that one, and he had taken it off me before I got there, and I found that I minded. "There are no apologies in here, not one. If you need to apologize, do it somewhere else, to someone else."

"Okay."

"We talk at the end of the night if I ask you to, and if I don't ask, you go home. I can end this any day I like, and you can't."

He waited, in case there was more.

"This isn't forgiveness."

"I know it isn't."

"Say it back to me."

He did not have to think. "Six to ten weeknights, eight to six Saturdays, through the twenty-fourth. Phone in the bowl, no apologies in here. I do what you say and nothing else, I don't fix, I don't decide, I ask. We talk if you ask. You can end it and I can't."

"Yes."

"Have you eaten anything today?"

"That's a question about me."

"Yes, it's a question about you."

"It isn't one of yours, so ask your questions."

"What will I be doing?"

"Whatever I tell you to do."

"And if I get it wrong?"

"You will get it wrong, and then you'll do it again."

"And what happens on the twenty-fourth?"

"The painting goes back to the church."

"And what happens after that?"

"I didn't say anything about after that."

He took that standing still, as he had taken the rest, and then he said, "Okay. So," and the questions came out in order, numbered in his head. "What do I wear for this?"

"Nothing that sheds, no wool or fleece, only old cotton."

"What about lunch on Saturdays?"

"You bring your own and you eat it in the corridor. Food doesn't come in here."

"In the corridor," he said, filing it. "Thanksgiving's the twenty-sixth, and that's a Thursday."

"It is a Thursday."

"My mother expects me in Scranton."

"Then that's a decision you'll make."

"You said I don't decide anything."

"I said in here, and Scranton isn't in here."

"Saturdays at eight, then, and there's a place on Girard that opens at six-thirty, and I could stop and get you a coffee."

"No. You're doing it again."

"Doing what again?"

"Deciding things for me again."

He shut his mouth, and the El went over and the windows hummed, and when it had passed he spoke lower.

"About the house, I found a place in Manayunk, month to month, furnished, and I can be out by Friday so you can go home. You shouldn't be sleeping on a cot in a building with no weekend heat."

"I don't want the house."

"Then a hotel near here, or an apartment, whatever you want."

"I have a cot, a heater, a sink, Odalys's shower and a painting, and I don't want the house."

He looked at the floor and then back up. "I'm telling Ray on Monday, and Joan, in person. I told the Dunns on Sunday. Cora's in Havertown, and she asked me to tell you that she—"

"Don't."

"Okay."

"Tell whoever you like, since it was your table. And next you were going to say you could pay for someone, a real conservator, the best one, flown in."

He did not deny it, and I gave him that.

"There isn't anyone," I said. "I called three people today. One is in Boston, and two have talked to Frances."

"Frances Tilley?"

"She thinks I quit, in writing."

The corner of his mouth went flat, and I watched him put that one behind his eyes, where he had put Mr. Abruzzo on Saturday.

"Why me?"

"You owe me."

"That's why I'd come, but it's not why you'd want—"

"Your hands don't shake."

He looked down at them. Big hands, the backs scarred white from the docks, a burn on the side of the left one from a manifold near Allentown, and they hung open at his sides.

"No," he said, "they don't." He turned them over once and let them fall. "You could have called Odalys."

"Odalys has a job, and two hands she needs for it."

"I have a job as well, Maud."

"Then you'll have to decide which one you're bad at."

"I already know which one I'm bad at."

"Don't."

"That wasn't an apology."

"It was the front half of one."

I came around the bench, nearer to him than I had been since the hall on Saturday, and folded back the corner of the dust sheet left-handed until the lower right of the painting lay bare under the lamp, the brown mantle with its cupped paint and, in the corner, two inches by three, the blue.

He came two steps closer and stopped, because I hadn't told him he could come closer than that.

"What's that, in the corner?"

"That's what the original looks like."

"All of it's under there, that color?"

"Some of it is, and some of it is gone. That's what I find out."

"Who did that square, the clean one?"

"I did, in July."

"You did that with that hand."

"With the one I had then."

He looked at the blue a long time. He put his hands in his coat pockets. I have seen him do that twice in eight years, both times at funerals.

"Maud, before I start, I need to say something."

"Is it an apology?"

"Yes," he said, after a moment.

"Then don't."

"Can I say it outside, on the street?"

"You can say it to the elevator."

"Okay."

I laid the sheet back over the corner.

"Tomorrow," I said, "at six."

"Six o'clock," he said, and lifted his phone from the bowl and held it a moment without turning it over. "Do you want me to—"

I looked at him.

"Okay," he said. "No."

I heard the rattle of the gate, which he did not slam. Years ago I had mentioned, once, that I hated it.

"Declan," I said, from the bench.

Through the open door I saw him turn inside the cage.

"Cotton."

The gate came across, then the outer door, and the last thing to go down the shaft was his voice, saying, "Okay."

Chapter 8 — Declan

Be early. Do what she says. Fix nothing.

He was early, so that was one.

He had worked from the study all day with the door open, which made no difference to the work and some difference to him. At 5:31 he parked across Frankford Avenue under the same streetlight, in the same space as Saturday, because it was the space he knew, twenty-nine minutes early when he had told himself fifteen.

Ray and Joan were in Charlotte at their daughter's until Sunday, and Ray's assistant had given him Monday at eight. Joan had texted every day, each message shorter than the last. *Dec, is everything ok? Ray says you sound weird.* He'd sent the same answer three times: *Monday, in person, I promise.* It wasn't done, but it was scheduled.

The Dunns he had done on Sunday, on their step. Mrs. Dunn had put a hand flat over her mouth and kept it there while he talked. Behind her in the hall their older boy had said, "I talked to her on Friday, under the tree. I asked her if she still liked the flowers."

His phone buzzed in the cup holder.

Cora: Is she eating?? Sorry. You don't have to answer. Is she though

He typed *Yes*, and then looked at it, because he didn't know if it was true. He deleted it, put the phone in his coat and got out of the car.

. . .

Mr. Pappas was in the vestibule of the glove factory, salting the step from a coffee can, a small man in a cardigan and a wool cap who looked at Declan the way Mrs. Kessler looked at recycling put out on the wrong night.

"Who are you, please?"

"I'm Declan Hale, Maud's husband."

"Husband." Pappas put the scoop back in the can. "Saturday, the gray car across the street, that's you. Hamid says two hours."

"It was an hour and a half."

"Hamid says two."

Declan let Hamid have it.

"She sleeps here," Pappas said. "Boiler is off on weekends, there is no shower, there is a cot like in the army. You know all this?"

"I know."

"And you are in a big house."

"Yes, I'm in the house."

"Big house, small car?"

"It's a Subaru."

“So, small car.” Pappas looked at him a while longer, then jerked his head at the freight elevator, an old cage behind a sliding steel door, with a brass lever instead of buttons. “The gate, you pull it till it clicks. Lever forward is up, center is stop, and don’t slam it, because she hates when it slams. You fix things?”

“Dock doors, trucks, a dishwasher once.”

“The tap on three drips. Don’t fix it.” He picked up the coffee can. “She likes it. She says it keeps time.”

“Okay,” Declan said.

“Okay,” said Pappas, in a voice that reserved judgment, and went back out to his salt.

The cage went up past a second floor where red neon leaked under a door, and he did not slam the gate.

• • •

Her door was open a few inches, and nobody answered his knock.

She was asleep at the bench with her head down on her left arm and the arm on an open notebook, and her braid was looser than she wore it, done with one hand. Her right hand lay beside her head in its black brace, palm down, set aside. Beside her elbow a white plastic kitchen timer was ticking.

He stood in the doorway and did not go in.

Step one was complete, but step two needed instructions, and the person who gave them was asleep, and there was no step for this.

The room did what every building did to him and showed him what was going to fail, in order of risk. The sink tap dripped once every four seconds, nine hundred an hour. A power strip under the bench fed a second strip that fed a third, with the lamp and a kettle on the end of it. One window had a cracked pane taped over with tape gone yellow. In the jaws of the vise at the end of the bench, for no reason he could see, stood a jar of instant coffee, clamped upright, with its lid off.

He could have fixed the power strips in two minutes, and the tap he had been told about. He kept both hands on the coat over his arm. After a while he crossed as far as the end of the bench, quietly, and stopped there.

At the bottom of the notebook page, under her arm, slow capitals slanted the wrong way, written by the hand that wasn’t hers for writing. *NOV 18. LOWER EDGE, LOSSES 1–91*. He did not read any further than that.

He checked his watch at 5:41 and again at 5:44. He had never been good at waiting, and his mother used to say he’d been born three weeks early because he couldn’t stand a line.

At 5:55 the timer went off with a rattle, and she sat up.

She came up out of sleep already looking at something, and the something was him, at the end of the bench in an old gray T-shirt and jeans, holding his coat.

“You’re early,” she said.

“I was twenty-five minutes early.”

She turned the timer away from him, as if it had told on her. "Did you park under the light?"

"Same place as Saturday."

"Hamid will tell Pappas."

"He already did."

She looked at his shirt. "You're wearing cotton."

"You said cotton."

He went to the bowl by the door and put his phone in it. Then he unbuckled his watch, a steel Seiko his mother had ordered from a catalog the year he made shift supervisor, and laid it in the bowl beside the phone, and there was a pale band of skin where it had been.

"Where do I stand?" he said, turning around.

She looked at the watch in the bowl, and then at the pale band.

"Here," she said, and pointed to a place at the corner of the big table where the boards dipped. "Wash your hands first, warm water, no soap after the first rinse."

• • •

The first hour was cotton.

She gave him a canvas apron cut for somebody smaller, a box of nitrile gloves in large, which on him were not large, a jar of bamboo skewers and a hank of cotton wool.

"Swabs," she said. "Watch me do one."

She did one left-handed, a pinch of cotton thinner than he'd have guessed and a twist of the skewer against her thigh, and the cotton wound itself on tight and came to a soft blunt point.

"Tight enough that it doesn't shed, loose enough that it rolls. Make fifty."

"Fifty," he said, and pulled the cotton toward him.

The cotton liked to clump on his fingers, and the first ones came out in knots. She went through them as he made them, holding each one up to the lamp and turning it.

"That one's loose, it'll shed," she said, dropping it into a coffee can. "That one's lumpy." Into the can. "And that one has a tail."

"What's a tail?"

"A wisp at the end. It leaves a fiber on the paint, and then I'm picking a fiber out of a crack with a needle at midnight." She held it up between two fingers. "Make it again."

Eleven of the fifty went in the can. He made eleven more, and she threw out two of those, and he made two more, and she kept them.

When it was time for the solution she reached across the bench with her right hand for a brown glass bottle labeled in the same slanted capitals, closed her fingers on the cap, and turned. The hand began to shake, low in the thumb first and then up into the fingers, a quick fine tremor, and the cap did not move, and she kept trying anyway.

“Let me take that—”

He stopped.

She looked at him over the bottle. He couldn’t have said what was in her face, except that it was watchful.

He put his hands in the apron pocket.

She loosened the vise left-handed, swapped the coffee jar for the bottle, closed the jaws until the bottle sat tight, and unscrewed the cap in three neat turns, then poured a little into a glass dish.

So that was what the jar was for. He’d thought somebody was being funny.

“I have a system,” she said.

“I see that.”

“Come here,” she said.

She folded the sheet back from the lower right corner. From eighteen inches the brown was not one color: there was a gray on top, bus-shelter grime, and under the gray a yellow, and under the yellow a darker shape that turned out to be a fold of cloth. In the corner was the blue, two inches by three, and beside it she had laid a square of tape, one inch by one inch.

“What you’re taking off is surface dirt,” she said. “A century of candles and coal smoke and people breathing. It sits on top of the varnish, and it comes off first, or everything after drags it around.”

She dipped one of his swabs in the dish and touched it to a folded tissue. “Blot it. You want damp, not wet, because wet goes down the cracks, and then it’s under the paint, and then it’s my problem for a year. Then roll it. Don’t rub. Roll it toward you, across, once, and lift.”

“Toward me, once, and lift.”

She did it in the air above the tape, not touching, and held out the swab. He took it in his left hand, the one that knew what it was doing.

“Inside the tape,” she said, “and nowhere else. If your hand gets tired, you say so and you stop, because a tired hand is how paintings get hurt.”

“Tired, I stop.”

He blotted, rolled and lifted, and the cotton came up a dull gray-brown, like mop water at the end of a night shift.

“Like that?”

“Lighter on the stick. Now turn it to a clean face and do it again.”

He turned it and did it again.

She put on the old headband magnifier, the one with the taped hinge, and pulled the kitchen chair up to his elbow, close enough that he could feel the air move when she breathed, and watched the tape through the lenses.

“Drier,” she said, and later, “Lighter,” and once, “Lift there. Good.”

“And if it ever comes up a different color?”

“If it ever comes up yellow, you stop and you tell me.” She did not look up from the lenses. “Yellow is varnish. Yellow means you’re into the next layer, and we are nowhere near the next layer.”

“Yellow, I stop,” he said.

Once, when he went to roll twice on the same line, she put two fingers of her left hand on the back of his wrist, not pressing, and he stopped, and she took them away.

At seven she tore a page out of the notebook and pushed it across to him with a pencil.

"Write this down for me, because I can't write fast enough. The date, then six-forty p.m. Surface cleaning, area one, lower right, adjacent to the July test window. Buffered aqueous solution, rolled cotton swab."

He wrote it in the small square capitals he used on dock forms.

"Operator," she said, "D. Hale, under direct supervision of M. Alder, conservator, present throughout."

He wrote it, and then he looked at it on the page. *Operator.*

"Every shift, every time," she said. "Frances will want to see it."

"Do I sign it?"

"Initial every entry, D.H., in the margin."

At some point he looked at his right wrist, and there was only the pale band, and he went back to the tape.

Around eight she took the headband off, held it out to him and said, "Look. Not at the dirt, at the paint."

It pinched behind his ears, and the square inch jumped up at him and became a field. Every millimeter of it was covered in fine dark lines that branched and joined and branched again, small irregular plates of paint fitted together. Some of the lines were hairlines, and some had opened wide enough that he could see down into them, to something pale.

"That's craquelure," she said. "The paint shrinks as it ages and the canvas keeps moving, so it cracks. Every old painting has its own pattern."

It looked like the network map in the corridor outside his office, every lane and spur of fourteen buildings, except that nobody had planned this one. It had happened to the paint over a hundred and forty years, one winter at a time, and you could follow any one crack from where it started to where it met three others and stopped.

"Can you fix them?" he said. "The cracks?"

"You don't fix them. They're how old it is. You clean around them and you leave them alone."

The taped hinge pressed against his temple. At home, on the table in the hall, there was a box in brown delivery paper with thick, badly folded corners, and two sets of lenses inside it. He took the headband off and handed it back to her by the band.

"Okay," he said.

• • •

At 8:40 his left hand cramped, a hard knot in the web of the thumb that went up into the forearm, and he kept rolling until the swab wavered.

“Is that normal?” he said.

“For the first month it’s normal. Shake it out, then do it again.”

He shook it out and went on. His back went at nine.

His eyes went at about half past, a fine grain over everything. He thought about saying so and didn’t, because they would talk at the end if she asked, and he had agreed to that.

Without looking up from the tape a while later, she said, “You can go at ten. You don’t have to pretend to find it interesting.”

He rolled, turned the swab, looked at it, dropped it in the can and took a clean one.

“Okay,” he said.

What he didn’t say, because she hadn’t asked, was that nothing had held him like this in a year. He had stopped hearing the radiators an hour ago, and the tap that kept time. A fold of cloth was coming up out of the brown a quarter inch from the tape’s edge, and he wanted to get there before ten.

At 9:58 by the clock above the sink, the inside of the tape was clean.

The varnish was still yellow-brown, the same as everything around it, but the gray was gone, and against the dull tape the square looked like a window somebody had wiped with a sleeve. You could see the fold, and you could see the cracks.

She bent over it in the headband for a long time, so close that her braid swung down and she caught it with her left hand. He stood with his ruined hand open at his side and waited, not knowing what she was looking for, or what it would mean if she found it.

She sat back and peeled the tape up by one corner, slowly, all four sides. Then she tore a fresh strip and laid down a new square, one inch by one inch, right beside the first, and held out a clean swab.

“Again.”

Chapter 9 — Maud

By Saturday morning the ninety-one losses along the bottom edge were down to thirty-eight, and each of the fifty-three we had laid flat on Thursday and Friday nights had its own line in my notebook, ending in the initials D.H. in capitals so square they could have been stenciled on a crate.

Mr. Pappas turns the boiler down at six on Friday nights, and at 7:50 the thermometer over the sink said forty-nine degrees. When I bent over the lower edge with the raking lamp my breath crossed the cupped paint before the light did.

He had taken to waiting in the corridor until the hour came, and at eight he knocked twice. The phone and the watch went into the bowl, and he had stopped making anything of it, and so had I.

He went to his place at the corner where the boards dip and did not reach for the skewers. He stood with his hands open and studied my July window from the distance I had allowed him, long enough that I put the lamp down.

“What does it look like when it’s right?”

For three nights I had taken his quiet for a man serving out a sentence. I had watched him roll cotton without a word from six to ten and decided he was counting ceiling tiles until somebody let him up, and I had been as sure of it as I am of a varnish. Seen from where I stood now, with the cold north light flat on his face and the question still in the room, his quiet had been the other thing all along, the thing I do for a living, which from across a bench sounds exactly like nobody being there.

“When it’s right,” I said, “you can’t tell anybody was there.”

“The window’s not like that. You can tell somebody was there.”

“The window is a question. It’s supposed to show.”

He thought about that and said, “What’s the answer?”

“Ask me on the twenty-fourth.”

He pointed, not touching, at the drapery beside area one, where the brown broke into its little plates. “The cracks around the cloth are wider than the ones by the tape. There’s something white down in them. I saw it Thursday.”

“That’s the ground. The white layer the painter laid over the canvas before he put down any color.”

“So that’s the bottom.”

“That’s the bottom of the paint. The canvas is under it.”

“How thick is it?”

“Thinner than a fingernail. If you get through to it with a swab, you’ve gone too far, and you stop.”

“And you tell me.”

“And you tell me before you stop, if you can manage both.”

He washed his hands at the dripping tap and did not ask me how long any of it would take.

• • •

At ten past nine there was a knock that was not his, and Hamid from the second floor came in sideways with a heater in his arms.

I had known him for six years as a red sign and a pair of boots on the stairs. In person he was younger than his sign, a neon bender in a Flyers knit cap with a scorch on one cuff, and he set down a boxy quartz heater with a strip of masking tape across its top that said HAMID, RETURN in marker.

"Mr. Pappas says the lady freezes," he said. "My shop, I'm at a thousand degrees all day. Glass doesn't bend for you at room temperature, it bends at a thousand, and it only forgives you for about four seconds. I don't need it." He looked across the room. "You're the car."

"I'm the car," Declan said.

"Pappas tells you I said two hours. I said ninety minutes. Pappas makes everything bigger."

"That's what I told him."

"So we agree." Hamid turned to me and pointed at my mouth, and then at the July window. "Lady, your lips are the same color as that."

"That blue is the Virgin's mantle. My lips are a different blue."

"Same thing, from the door." He laughed and crouched under the bench before I could stop him and plugged the heater into the last of the power strips chained under there. "Copper in these is like hair. Cheap strip, cheap copper, it gets warm, it gets warmer, one day it's a smell." It came on orange and roaring. "You want, I make you a sign for the door. COLD LADY, KNOCK FIRST. Twenty percent off for the building."

"I don't need a sign, Hamid."

"Everybody needs a sign." He nodded at Declan on his way out. "Car man, she says she doesn't need things. Don't believe it."

He went back down to his glass.

• • •

By half past ten we were at loss sixty-one, a flake the size of a fingernail clipping at the edge of the shepherd's boot. I had laid the adhesive under it left-handed with a fine brush, the heel of my hand resting on a padded bridge across the table, and he held the tacking iron a hair above a square of silicone paper and waited for my count.

"Down," I said, "two, three, and lift."

He lifted, and the flake lay flat.

"Was that long enough?"

"Look at it from the side and tell me."

He bent until his eye was level with the boot. "It's down. It doesn't catch the light anymore."

"Then it was long enough."

He had the next square of silicone paper in his right hand before I asked for it. "Down," I said, at sixty-two, and the lamp went out.

The heater wound down with a sigh and the iron's red light went dark, and the room went the flat, stalled gray of a house with the power cut.

"Is it ruined?" he said, without moving.

"It's half set. It'll take the iron again when the iron's hot. Straight up, don't slide it, and put it on the stand."

He lifted it straight up and set it on the stand.

"The panel's by the elevator, the third switch."

The lamp came back, and Hamid's heater began to roar again as if nothing had happened. When he came back he did not go to his place. He crouched at the bench and studied the chain of strips underneath it, everything in the room drinking from one outlet in the wall.

"I saw those on Wednesday," he said.

"And you didn't touch them."

"You said don't fix anything." He stayed crouched under the bench. "I've got an orange extension cord in the trunk, a heavy one, rated for a space heater. Do you want me to run the heater off the outlet by the window?"

He had built the whole thing as a question, with my name on the end of it. I knelt on my heels at the end of the table with the cold coming up through my knees.

"Yes. Tape it down at the door, so nobody trips over it carrying a painting."

He was back in four minutes with the cord over his shoulder and ran it along the wall under the windows and taped it flat at the doorway, and he left the strips under the bench exactly as they were. We laid sixty-two at 10:52, and it took the iron the second time without complaint.

• • •

He ate his lunch in the corridor, as agreed, on the floorboards with his back to the wall and a sandwich in waxed paper, and the studio door open a crack between us.

I sat on the cot and opened a new message with my left thumb. Behind it my inbox waited with a number in red, and I kept my thumb over the number, because a blank message has nothing in it to read and my rule held. My sister had been writing in my name since August.

"Declan."

The chewing stopped in the corridor, and he said, "Yes."

"Who have you told?"

"The Dunns, on Sunday. Mrs. Kessler, the Saturday before. Ray and Joan Monday at eight, when they're back. Nadine after Ray."

"Nobody else?" I said, to the door.

"Lou Varga and the others at the Monday call. Pat Varga after that, probably, from Lou."

"Then they'll hear it twice."

"Hear what twice?"

"The truth. Once from you and once from her."

He was quiet out there long enough for an El train to go over. "From Cora?"

"From Cora, in her own voice."

The waxed paper rustled as he folded it. "Joan cried at that table, Maud. The first night. She held Cora's hand."

"Then Joan will want to hear it from the hand."

"And Frances? Is Frances on it?"

"Frances most of all."

"Will she believe Cora?"

"Frances doesn't believe anybody who cries in front of her, and my sister cries when she orders lunch."

He didn't say anything to that. I typed with one thumb, slowly, and the letters came out in the right order, which is more than my signature does.

Joan Teague, Ray Teague, Walter Wozniak, Frances Tilley, Odalys Fuentes, Mr. Abruzzo, Ellen Szabo, the Tsangs on Delancey Street, Mrs. Kessler, the Dunns, Nadine Okoro.

Every one of these people was told something by you, in my name. You will tell each of them yourself, in your own voice, what you did, not through Declan or Mother and not in one text to all of them, by December 8. Walter Wozniak will keep it from the parish, so don't ask him to. Don't reply to me.

I read it back once, every name, and pressed send at 12:41.

At 12:44 a banner slid down across the top of the screen.

Cora: Okay.

My sister has never in thirty-five years used one word where nine would do. She signs a birthday card with a paragraph. My right hand had closed in the brace without my asking it to, and I opened it on my knee one finger at a time and slid the phone under a fold of the blanket.

"Was that her?" he said from the corridor.

"That's not one of your questions."

"No," he said, and balled up the waxed paper.

• • •

At two the light was a hard even gray off the roofs of Frankford Avenue, and I taped a second square beside my July window, one inch by one inch, and mixed the gel.

"This is a different job," I said. "Surface dirt is done in this corner. This is the varnish."

He studied the dish and said, "It looks like hair gel."

"It holds the solvent where I put it, for as long as I say, and then it comes off. Nothing runs. Nothing goes down the cracks." I gave him a soft flat brush. "A thin coat inside the tape. Thin enough that you can see the brown through it."

"How long does it sit?"

"Sixty seconds. I count, and the timer counts behind me, in case."

“In case of what?”

“In case I lose count, which I don’t. Lay it on.”

He laid it on left-handed with the brush flat and the strokes all one way. I twisted the white kitchen timer to sixty as a second clock and began to count out loud.

At sixty he cleared it, rolling a damp swab once across the square, and the cotton came up a deep greasy amber like the bottom of a jar of honey.

He stopped dead. “It’s yellow, Maud.”

“Yellow is what we want today. And I say when.”

“You say when,” he said, and turned the swab to a clean face, and cleared again, and then the rinse, and laid on the next coat.

On the third clearing his swab stood up on its end. He was pushing with the tip instead of rolling with the side, and the tip was heading for the edge of the tape, and I put my left hand over the back of his and tipped the stick down flat under both of us.

The room was forty-nine degrees and his hand was warm, warm all the way through the nitrile, and under my fingers the long bones on the back of it moved once when he rolled, then went still. Inside the black brace on my other wrist my pulse had come up hard against the plastic, and I counted that instead of the gel. I had reached forty-one out loud, and the next number did not come, and the kitchen timer rang on its own at sixty, much too loud in a silent room.

I had stopped at forty-one. The timer had not.

I took my hand back. “Lighter, and clear it now.”

He cleared it without looking at me, and I was grateful for that.

On the fourth coat the brown under the tape went olive.

“Why is it going green on me?”

“Because a yellow varnish over a blue makes green. Keep going.”

“Is green bad?”

“Green is the varnish getting thin. It means the blue’s right underneath you.”

On the fifth it went the green of a pond in August, and I have watched that happen two hundred times and it has never failed to make the back of my neck go cold. On the sixth he rolled the swab across, once, toward himself, and lifted, and the green gave way under it to the same cold blue as mine, an inch square, a finger’s width from my window.

He stood back without being told.

I put on the headband magnifier and bent over his inch until my neck ached. The craquelure ran on unbroken from my window into his, and under the lenses the blue was sound to its edges, with nothing taken that should have stayed.

“Is that right?” he said.

“That’s what it looks like.”

I sat back and dictated the entry, the time and the area and the six applications of sixty seconds and the operator line, and then the only line I cared about. “Result: varnish fully reduced. Original paint layer intact.”

He wrote it in his dock capitals and stopped with the pencil over the margin until I told him to initial it, and he did, D.H.

• • •

At six he took his watch and his phone out of the bowl and stood in the doorway with his coat over his arm, waiting to be asked or not asked.

“Why did you ask me that this morning?”

He took a moment over it. “Because at work everybody asks me how long. Every call, every building, how long till the door’s fixed, how long till the trucks move. Nobody ever asks what it looks like when it’s done.”

“And what does it look like, when it’s done?”

“Usually like nothing happened.” He put the watch on. “That’s the job.”

“It’s the job here too.”

“I see Ray on Monday at eight in the morning,” he said. “I’ll be here at six.”

“You’ll be here at six because it’s Monday, and Ray has nothing to do with it.”

“Okay,” he said, and went.

I turned off the lamp. In the last of the north light, the painting had two blue windows in its corner, side by side.

Chapter 10 — Declan

First Ray, at eight, before Ray had his second coffee and an opinion. Then Joan, wherever she wanted, for as long as it took. Then the floor at the eleven o'clock, all fourteen buildings on the screen, and two sentences with no questions.

He was in the lot in Conshohocken at 7:38, with the river beyond the fence the color of a filing cabinet. He sat for four minutes with the engine off and said the two sentences out loud to the windshield, and they came out the same both times, as he had meant them to.

Tern's sixth floor smelled of the new carpet they had put down in October. The network map ran the length of the corridor outside his office, every building and lane in the Mid-Atlantic in red and blue, and he walked past it without looking, the way he had walked past it for six years. Ray's door was open, and Ray was standing at the window in shirtsleeves with a coffee, tanned from four days in Charlotte, in November, against all reason.

"Dec." Ray turned around with his whole body, the way he did everything. "Sit, sit, you look like death. Joan says you've been weird on the phone, and I said Dec is always weird on the phone, it's a medium for people with feelings."

On the desk between them sat a short jar of jelly with a gingham bow on the lid, and a card in Joan's round hand. *For Maud, from a farm stand outside Charlotte. Muscadine! J.*

"Joan picked it out," Ray said. "She stood in that farm stand twenty minutes deciding. Take it home to the patient."

Declan did not sit.

"Ray, the woman at my table since September was Cora, Maud's twin sister. Maud was in Italy the whole time, until the thirteenth, and I let you believe otherwise."

Ray laughed, a real laugh from the chest, and put the coffee down on the sill to do it properly.

"A twin, okay, and I'm the Archbishop of Philadelphia." He pointed a finger across the desk. "You're not good at bits, Dec. Don't start bits before nine in the morning."

Declan waited.

The laugh went out of Ray in stages, first from the shoulders and then from the mouth, and the hand with the pointing finger came down onto the desk beside the jelly and stayed there.

"Say it again."

"Cora, Maud's sister, since September eleventh. Joan called her Maud at the door the first night and I didn't correct it, and after that I didn't correct it nine Fridays in a row."

"Joan called her," Ray said slowly. "Joan."

"Yes."

"She held her hand at your table. She told her about her mother's hip replacement, the whole thing, the infection, she told her things she hasn't told our daughter." Ray's voice had not got louder, and in six years that was new. "She cried in the car after the first night because Maud looked so brave. She lit a candle every Sunday at St. Monica's. Every Sunday, Dec, since September."

"I know."

"You know." Ray sat down heavily in his own chair. "You let my wife cry over a woman who wasn't there."

There was nothing to route that through, so Declan didn't try. He stood on the carpet and took it.

"Where's Maud now?"

"Kensington, at her studio."

"Is she okay? Really okay, not dinner-party okay."

"She has a plate and nine screws in her right wrist and a scar through her eyebrow she didn't want anyone to see. She's working."

Ray put both hands over his face and rubbed it, up and down, as if he were washing without water. When the hands came down his face was red.

"Here's what happens," he said. "Joan's mine. You don't call her and you don't text her. I tell her at lunch, at the place she likes, and she gets to have whatever face she has without you watching it."

That was step two gone.

"Okay," Declan said.

"Don't you okay me, Dec. I'm not one of your buildings." Ray looked at the jelly until it was awkward, and then picked it up and put it in his desk drawer and shut the drawer. "Sit down. I mean it this time."

Declan sat.

"I had a speech." Ray took a folder out of the other drawer, a blue one, and put it squarely in front of him. "I'm going to give it anyway, because the board approved it Thursday and I don't waste a board. Mitch is retiring in January. SVP, Network Operations, in Atlanta. You'd run the whole map, not just the part outside your office. Start date January fourth."

Declan kept his hands off the folder. Eleven years ago he had been twenty-seven, running nights in Allentown, when he first drew that job on the back of a shift schedule, an org chart with a box at the top and a city in it.

"I need an answer by the eighteenth of December," Ray said. "And I'll tell you the rest straight, because you just told me something straight and I respect it, even if I'd like to throw this stapler at you. I need a man who doesn't have scenes at home."

"I know you do."

"So go home and don't have one." Ray stood up. "The eighteenth. Take the folder with you."

Declan took the folder.

In the corridor he stopped at the network map. He had not stopped at it since the week they hung it. Fourteen buildings with the lanes between them in red, and a

blue pushpin somebody had added for the Hagerstown cross-dock. Above it, framed, the whole country, with Atlanta in the middle of it like a drain. He could have drawn every lane on the Mid-Atlantic sheet from memory. He could not have said, if somebody had asked him at that moment, what color Maud's studio walls were.

White, he thought, probably. He went to his office and set the folder on the corner of the desk without opening it.

• • •

At eleven, fourteen squares came up on the screen in the conference room, fourteen building leads with fourteen bad coffees, and Nadine sat at the foot of the table with her reading glasses pushed up into her hair. It was Thanksgiving week, and that meant peak. Allentown was running at a hundred and twelve percent of its slots, and Carlisle had a dock door that wouldn't seal, again.

"Before the numbers," he said. "Some of you came to my house this fall and met a woman you thought was my wife. She's my wife's sister. I let it stand, and that was mine."

Fourteen faces did nothing, and somebody in Harrisburg unmuted and muted again.

In the Allentown square Lou Varga took off his glasses.

"Pat sent her putty," Lou said. "The physical therapy putty, the green kind. For the hand."

"I know. I'll get it back to her."

"She doesn't want it back, Dec. She wants to know who she was talking to."

"Her name is Cora," Declan said. "She'll be getting in touch with Pat herself."

Lou put his glasses back on and found something on his desk to read, and that was all. In the Hagerstown square Tanya Brill, who had come to the October dinner with a bottle of wine she had made herself, unmuted.

"Is the real one okay, Dec?"

"She's working," he said.

"Good," Tanya said, and muted, and did not look at her camera again.

Declan said, "Carlisle. Door fourteen," and fourteen squares went back to doors.

• • •

Nadine came into his office at 12:15 and shut the door, which she did about twice a year.

She had been at three of the Fridays. She sat down across from him and crossed her legs and watched the network map through his glass wall instead of him.

"She asked me how my kids were," she said. "In October, by the coat rack."

"Cora did?"

"I don't have kids, Declan." She took her glasses out of her hair and folded them. "I thought it was the concussion. I thought, poor woman, she's mixing me up with somebody. I told her they were fine."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be sorry at me. I'm not the one you owe." She put the glasses on the desk. "Your five o'clocks are gone through the end of the year. I moved them Friday."

He turned from the screen.

"You've left at five-twenty since last Tuesday," she said. "Nobody leaves at five-twenty in peak. People notice."

"What do they say?"

"Nothing. I've been standing near them." She got up and smoothed her skirt over her knees with both hands. "Allentown wants you on the two-thirty. I said you'd take it from here, and you will, because you're leaving at five-twenty."

"Nadine."

"What?"

He did not know what came after her name. She waited a second longer than she needed to and went out and left the door open.

• • •

At 2:12 his phone lit up on the desk.

Joan: Ray told me. I held her hand at your table and told her about Mother's hip. I bought her a jelly. I lit a candle for her every Sunday. Whose hand was it, Declan?

He read it once and typed *Joan, it was Cora, and I am* and stopped, because the end of that sentence was something he wanted from her, and deleted it. There was no answer that was his to send, and Ray had told him not to, and both of those were true, and neither was why. He slid the phone under the edge of the blotter and left it there.

At 4:31 an email came in from HR with a lock icon on it. *Offer: SVP Network Operations (CONFIDENTIAL)*. He opened it, because he opened everything. A start date and a relocation package, and a number with \$140,000 more in it than the number he made now, above a signature line with his name typed under it.

He closed it and did not file it.

He would not tell Maud. She had not asked, and the rule was that they talked at the end of the night if she asked, and the rule was hers. He could feel, sitting there with his hand on the mouse, exactly how convenient that was. He had built nine weeks out of things nobody had asked him.

The blue folder sat on the corner of the desk. Atlanta had north light, presumably, and probably glove factories with freight elevators. What Atlanta did not have was a nine-foot table in Kensington with a painting on it that had to be back on a church wall by the morning of the twenty-fourth, and two blue squares in its corner, one of which he had made.

At 5:14 Carlisle called.

“Door fourteen,” said Russ Kopp, who had run Carlisle for nine years and did not call unless it was bad. “Seal’s gone again, and it’s not the seal this time, it’s the leveler, and I’ve got nine trucks stacked in the yard and two more on the 81 ramp. I need a call on whether I move them to Harrisburg or hold.”

Declan pulled the yard view up on the second screen and there they were, nine trucks nose to tail in the floodlights, while Harrisburg had three open doors and a crew that went home at six. It was a twenty-minute problem. He could see all twenty minutes of it, in order.

“Okay. So,” he said. “Russ, hold on.”

Through the glass wall the floor was half empty, but the half that was left had turned in their chairs. Somebody at the coordinators’ desks was standing with a coffee and not drinking it. It was 5:19.

Nadine was in his doorway with her coat already on. She did not say anything about the time. She came across the room and held out her hand for the phone, and he stared at it, her open palm with a pen mark across it, for one full second, which was a long time on a dock.

He gave her the phone.

“Russ, it’s Nadine. Move six to Harrisburg, hold three.” She put her hand over the speaker and lifted her eyebrows at him over it.

“Go.”

Chapter 11 — Maud

At 7:04 on Thanksgiving morning my husband told his mother he was not coming to Scranton, on the stair landing outside my door, in a voice he must have thought the stairwell would keep.

The building was empty for the holiday, and empty it carries every sound up the stairwell. I was on the cot under the moving blanket with the brown heater ticking beside me, and the freight elevator came up and stopped, and then there was his step on the landing, and then the small hard tap of a phone being unlocked by a thumb that had done it ten thousand times.

“Ma. It’s me. No, I’m fine. I’m fine. Listen.”

Greta Hale cleaned office buildings at night for twenty-two years, and she speaks in the voice you learn over a floor buffer at three in the morning. Her voice came out of his phone small and flat and perfectly clear.

“You’re on the road already? I said nine, Declan, the bird’s not even in.”

“I’m not on the road. I’m not coming up today.”

There was a pause long enough for the El to go over two blocks away.

“What do you mean you’re not coming. I got the breast, the big one. I did the stuffing last night. It’s in the refrigerator.”

“I know you did,” he said.

“Is it work? It’s work.”

“It’s not work, Ma. I’m in Kensington, at Maud’s studio.”

“Maud’s,” she said, and then nothing, and I lay very still under the blanket and watched the heater’s little orange light, because there are things you hear through a door that you have no right to, and I was hearing one, and I did not get up to shut it.

“I’m sorry, Ma,” he said, out on the landing, where he was allowed to be sorry.

“No,” said Greta, “no, okay. Okay, honey. Is she all right?”

“I don’t know yet,” he said.

“Okay,” she said, and her voice had gone up half a tone and stayed there, bright as a waxed floor. “Okay. It freezes. Stuffing freezes fine. I’ll freeze it.”

“Ma,” he said, and that was all he got.

“I’ll freeze it, Declan. You call me Sunday.”

The phone went dark, and then there was nothing on the landing for most of a minute, not a step, not a breath I could hear. My own mother has never raised her voice to me, and I know exactly what it costs a woman to make hers that even.

At 7:30 he knocked twice.

• • •

He was in the old gray T-shirt under his overcoat, and he held two sandwiches in plastic wedges with orange stickers on them that said HAPPY THANKSGIVING in a typeface meant for a child’s birthday.

"It's Thursday," I said, with the door half open.

"It's Thanksgiving," he said.

"Your hours are six to ten."

"I know," he said, keeping the sandwiches at his side, out of the room. "Can I work today?"

It was a question, built on the same plan as the one about the extension cord, with the answer left on my side of the door. I thought about Greta's stuffing going into a freezer bag in Scranton, and the bright half tone, and kept all of it to myself.

"Eight to six," I said, "like a Saturday."

He nodded once.

"Those don't come in," I said.

"I know. They're for the corridor," he said, and looked down at them with some suspicion, because he had paid for them and could no longer remember why. "They're from the Sunoco on Aramingo. It was the only thing open. One's yours."

"Your mother has a carrying voice."

"Twenty-two years of floor buffers," he said, and set the sandwiches down on the floorboards outside my door, side by side, very square, and came in and put his phone in the bowl, and then the watch.

• • •

"How far up does it go?" he said at nine, when the first square came clean.

"All the way up, if it's there. Her knee, her lap, the Child's foot."

"And if it's not there?"

"Then I'll know where it isn't."

We worked the lower mantle all morning, a square inch at a time, the gel and the count and the clearing and the rinse, and the green going blue under his swab in a slow stain that crept upward out of the corner toward the Virgin's knee. By noon there were five blue squares where on Saturday there had been two, and the brown around them looked like what it was, a dirty window somebody had stopped bothering to wipe in 1957.

At noon we ate the Sunoco turkey in the corridor, on the floor, on opposite sides of the doorway. It tasted of the plastic it had come in. A banner came down across my phone while I ate, Odalys from her mother's table in Juniata: *Alder. Mami says tomorrow, pernil, 2pm. Don't argue.* I didn't argue.

At ten past three he put the swab down on the edge of the dish, quite carefully, and held his left hand up a little off the table.

"My hand's tired."

"Then stop."

He stopped and sat on the floor against the leg of the bench and opened and closed the hand, slowly, twenty times, and because he was resting I wrote the entry in my notebook myself, slowly, in my own leaning capitals: *3:10 p.m. Operator rest, fatigue reported. Area nine incomplete.* A tired hand is how paintings get

hurt, and he had said so out loud without being asked, and I sat with the pen over the page and did not write that down.

At 3:25 he got up and washed his hands and went back to area nine.

• • •

At ten to six the north windows had gone the color of slate, and I put the dust sheet back over the painting myself, left-handed, a corner at a time, and he stood where he stood and did not help, because I had not asked.

"I'll be back," he said, and took his coat, and did not take his phone.

The cage went down, and the street door banged, and four minutes later the street door and the cage again. He came in with his coat over his arm and a steel thermos in his hand, an old dented one, army green, the paint worn off the shoulders down to bare metal, with a cup that screwed onto the top.

"It's tea," he said, and stayed inside the door holding it.

Food doesn't come in, and neither, as a rule, does drink, because tea goes into paint as easily as anything. The painting was under its sheet for the night, and the far end of the room by the cot was twenty feet from it, and it was my rule.

"The sheet's on," I said, "it can come in."

He came to the cot end of the room and unscrewed the cup and poured, and the steam came up in the cold, and it was the color of a manila folder. He held it out, and I took it left-handed.

It was milkier than anyone makes tea, stewed dark first and then drowned, with a spoon of sugar in it that I have not taken since I was nineteen. My father made it like that in a thermos for Sundays and we drank it on the museum steps before the doors opened, with the cup going back and forth, because there was only the one cup.

"Who told you milky?"

"Cora. The night before you came home," he said, without looking away. "She said, milky milky. I didn't know."

"She knew because of our father."

"I didn't know that either."

"It's past four," I said. "I don't have coffee after four. I haven't since 2019."

"I know. That's why it's tea."

I had stopped coffee after four in the spring of 2019, when a doctor at Jefferson held my right hand out flat under a sheet of paper and showed me what four cups after dinner were doing to it. He had been there that night, in the kitchen, when I poured the fifth one down the sink, and I had not thought he was watching.

He sat down on the floor with his back to the radiator, which was cold, and the brown heater between us, ticking.

"Where did you get the thermos?"

"It was my mother's." He turned it in his hands. "She took it to work every night for twenty-two years. Coffee, black, two sugars. She gave it to me the week I started on the docks and told me to keep it out of the rain."

“Did you?”

“Mostly.”

I drank half the cup. There was only the one cup, and he left it with me.

• • •

“What happened on the scaffold?”

He said it to the heater, not to me, in the level voice he uses for the next line of a form he has been handed and cannot skip. Then he lifted his eyes and waited.

In sixteen weeks nobody had asked me that and waited to hear the answer. My mother had asked whether the hospital was clean. Cora had asked whether they let me wash my hair, and then told me about a man in Delaware who had fallen off a roof and been fine. Odalys had asked, from four thousand miles away, but the question had gone to my phone, and my phone had been in my sister’s pocket.

I set the cup down on the floor beside the cot.

The chapel belonged to a family who had grown peaches for two hundred years in the flat country outside Ravenna, at the end of a road lined with poplars so straight they looked ruled. The roof had let the spring rain in over the altar. Above the altar there was a lunette, a half-moon of painted plaster, two angels holding up a scroll against a sky that somebody in the sixteenth century had made out of a blue that must have cost the family a year of peaches, and the water had got behind the plaster, and the paint was lifting off it in blisters the size of coins. I had been asked to go up and face the blisters with Japanese paper and a little adhesive, so the paint would hold to the wall while the roofers worked overhead. Six weeks, so that the angels would last long enough for someone else to treat them properly.

I landed in Bologna at nine in the morning on August 4, and a nephew of the family drove me out in a small hot car, and I was up the scaffold by three that afternoon, because the plaster was coming down, and because I wanted to be.

The scaffold was a rented aluminum tower, two levels of planks, and the roofers had been working off it in the morning. One of them had moved a crossbar to get a ladder through. Nobody told me, because nobody thought to, and I did not check, because I had checked it the evening before, in photographs, from Philadelphia.

I worked for an hour. The light came in through the door below me and up off the brick floor, warm and low and the color of the peaches, and the angels were very close, and the brushwork in the sky was right there in front of me, a man’s quick sure strokes from four hundred years ago, and the blisters, and the places where the blue had already let go and fallen and been swept up by someone and thrown away.

At a little after four I stepped back to see the whole lunette at once. You do that. You work an inch at a time for an hour and then you step back to see if the inch belongs to anything. I stepped back onto the end of a plank that had nothing under it anymore, and the plank tipped down at that end, and I went with it.

"It was nine feet," I said. "I've measured it since against the ceiling of this room."

He glanced up at the ceiling and back again before he asked, "Were you alone?"

"The family was resting through the heat. The roofers had gone for the afternoon. It was me and the angels."

I put out my right hand. You can't not. The hand took it first, and then the shoulder, and I heard the wrist go before I felt it, a sound like a green branch, and then the plank came down after me and its edge opened my eyebrow from the middle to the hairline. That part didn't hurt at all. The only sign of it was that the left side of the lunette went red, both angels, the whole sky, as if somebody had laid a sheet of red glass over half the world.

The floor was brick laid in a herringbone, cool against my cheek, and that was the first thing I thought, that it was cool. The second was my hand, and I tried to get up on my elbow to see it.

An old man held my head.

I don't know where he came from. The family said afterward that he was a neighbor who came in some afternoons to light a candle for his wife, and when I asked which neighbor, nobody could say. He was on his knees on the brick beside me before I had finished falling, or so it is in my memory, and he put one big dry palm on each side of my head and held it, not hard, the way you would hold a bowl full to the brim. He smelled of tobacco and of the peaches. When I tried to sit up he did not let me. He talked the whole time in a dialect I could not follow, low and steady, and every so often, so that I would understand at least one word, he said "Ferma. Ferma." Stay still. His knees must have hurt on that brick. He held my head for twenty-six minutes, until the ambulance came out along the poplars from Ravenna, and when they lifted me onto the stretcher he stood up and wiped his hands on his trousers and went to the altar and lit his candle, and I never saw him again.

Declan had not moved, and he had both hands around the thermos and his eyes on it, and I thought he was waiting for the end of the story so that he could do something with it. If I stayed on his hands, they were only holding the thermos very still, the way the old man had held my head.

"They did the first surgery in Bologna the next morning," I said. "Nine screws and a plate. The second was on the nineteenth, for the shoulder."

There was a nurse on the ward called Chiara. She was small and fast and had a gold cross on a chain she tucked inside her collar when she bent over the beds. For the first three weeks I did not know what day it was, and I kept asking her, in English and then in bad Italian, so she began to write it on the whiteboard at the foot of my bed each time she came, the day and the date in square block letters, and the time of the last dose, and beside the night doses she drew a small moon. When I woke in the night, the board was the only thing in the room I was sure of. *Martedì 11 agosto. 3:00. Moon.*

On the fourth night she found me trying to pour water left-handed from the jug on the tray, in the dark, and I had soaked the sheet. She did not scold me. She put the call button into my left hand and closed my fingers around it with her own and said in English, "For asking," and went to get a clean sheet. She told me later I was the only patient on the ward that month who never pressed it.

My mother and Cora came on the sixth. I don't remember much of that week. I remember saying to Cora, "Take my phone, tell everyone I'm okay," and I remember the relief of handing it to her. I remember that very clearly.

The first Sunday, the ninth, Cora held the loan phone up over the bed to show me to him, and I had my hair forward over the stitches. He was in our kitchen. Behind his shoulder stood the coffee machine, and my note was still on it, the one that said *Back in 6 weeks. Call me.*

"You said, 'What do you need?'"

He closed his eyes for a second and opened them.

"And I said, 'Nothing. Mother and Cora are here.' And you said, 'Do you want me to fly over?'" and I said no. And you said, 'Okay. So. Call me if that changes.'"

"Yes," he said, "I said that."

"It didn't change. I didn't call."

The heater ticked, and down on Frankford Avenue a car went by slowly with its radio on, a parade of brass, somebody's holiday going home.

I had not said the next part to anyone, not to Odalys, not to the whiteboard with its moons. I said it to the heater, as he had asked his question.

"When the email came in July about the chapel, I said yes before I'd finished reading it. I told you it was the money. It was six weeks somewhere you weren't asking me what I needed and taking nothing for an answer. I was glad to go. And after I fell, every Sunday when the call ended, part of me was relieved it was over, that I could put the phone down and go back to the whiteboard and the moon. That's not a thing that happened to me. That's a thing I did."

He did not say anything. I watched him not say it. His mouth opened once on a question with a fix inside it, and he put it back. His left hand, the one that had been tired at ten past three, lay open on his knee.

"What was his name?" he said, at last. "The man."

"I don't know," I said. "Nobody knew."

"Okay," he said, and nothing after it.

We sat on while my half cup of tea grew a skin, and the thermos stood between his feet with the rest still inside. Outside, the El went over, and the windows hummed with it, and stopped humming.

The brown heater ticked, and ticked, and neither of us got up to turn it off.

Chapter 12 — Declan

The lipstick on the mug was a dark berry red that Maud had never worn in her life, a perfect half-moon on the rim, and by Friday morning it had been sitting on the windowsill of the back room for thirteen days.

He found it at 9:20, the first time he had been into the back room since Cora left.

It was the first Black Friday in eleven years he had not spent on a dock floor. Peak was the busiest day of the network's year. Every year he had stood in a building with a radio on his belt from four in the morning. This year Nadine had said, in the tone she used for weather, that she would take Allentown and that he would be unreachable, and then she had made him unreachable by moving his name off the schedule. So the house was his, all three floors of it, and it was very quiet.

The back room on the second floor had been Maud's before it was anything else. Her drafting table still stood under the window with a gooseneck lamp clamped to its edge, and the stool in front of it had a cracked vinyl seat. In the spring she had stopped working at home, and he had not asked why, and by September the room had become Cora's closet. A rolling rack of Cora's dresses stood across the drafting table. Three boxes were taped shut and labeled in Cora's round marker, and a fourth stood open on the floor.

In the open box, on top of a pile of scarves, sat a shallow blue glazed bowl full of hair clips and loose change.

He picked it up and knew it as well as he knew the sound of his own front lock. It was the bowl from the hall table, the one Maud dropped her keys into every evening for six years. It had been missing since September, and he had not known when it went or where.

He sat down on her stool with it on his knees.

• • •

His phone rang at 9:31. He let it ring twice, because it would be his mother and she would know if he answered on the first one.

"Did she eat?" said Greta, before he had said hello.

"We had sandwiches," he said, which was true.

"From where?"

"A Sunoco," he said, and waited for it.

"Declan Hale," she said, and he heard her chair scrape, the kitchen chair by the radiator in Scranton, the one with the cushion tied on. "On Thanksgiving. From a gas station."

"It was the only thing open."

"It was the only thing you thought of," she said, and let that sit. "Was she glad you came?"

"I don't know. She let me in."

"Well, that's something. Is she still sleeping in that factory with no heat?"

"There's a heater."

"One heater, in November."

"Two. The man downstairs brought her one."

"Good for the man downstairs." The radio was on behind her, the AM station she had listened to through twenty-two years of nights. "Did she talk to you?"

"She told me about the fall."

His mother did not say anything for a while.

"Good," she said, "that's good, Deckie. And what did you tell her?"

"Nothing," he said, and heard how it sounded.

"She told you about falling off a church and you told her nothing."

"It was a chapel," he said, because it was.

"Don't you correct me," she said, but her voice had gone soft at the edges. "You know what I used to think, when you were eleven and I'd come in at six and hear you in the kitchen doing the eggs? I used to lie there in my coat and think, that boy's never going to let anybody carry a thing. And it was nice. I was too tired to say so, but it was nice. It wasn't always nice."

"What wasn't?"

"Never getting to carry anything back," she said, and cleared her throat. "The stuffing's in the freezer. You bring her at Christmas, if she'll come. If she won't, you come anyway."

"Okay, Ma."

"And tell her something," Greta said, and hung up first. She always had, as if every call still cost by the minute.

• • •

He put the hair clips and the coins in a sandwich bag and the bag in Cora's open box. He taped the box shut with the packing tape from the hall closet and wrote nothing on it. He took the mug down to the kitchen, washed it and put it in the cabinet with the others, because it was a mug.

Then he washed the bowl by hand, as he washed the glasses, a soft cloth over two fingers.

Standing at the sink with his hands in the water, he let himself have the rest of it, all the way through, which he had not done.

September eleventh he had been through so many times, in bed, with the box fan going on the floor above him, that the three seconds with the corkscrew had worn smooth. The rest was a Thursday in October: the Turnpike at twenty to seven, the Valley Forge exit, and his own hand reaching over to turn up the radio.

He dried the blue bowl and carried it to the front hall. He set it on the table beside the box in brown paper with the thick corners, and moved it half an inch to

the left, onto the paler ring in the finish where it had sat for six years. Then he picked up her brass key and dropped it in.

• • •

Mrs. Kessler was on her step at noon in the quilted housecoat, holding a foil pan with both hands, and she did not wait for him to say anything.

"The sister wrote me," she said. "A letter. By hand, four pages, both sides. Nice handwriting." She lifted her chin, ready for an argument. "I don't forgive her. I kept it."

He waited, because she was not finished.

"This is a ziti," she said, holding the pan out over the railing between the two steps. "For the real one. Is she eating?"

"I'll find out tonight."

"Find out," she said, and held on to the pan a moment after he had it. "All these years she's next door, your real one, and she never once said gracious to me. She fixed my mother's picture, the frame with the gold, and she wouldn't take a dollar for it, and she waved at me every morning like I was a bus she wasn't getting on. The sister said gracious all the time. I should have known."

"Nobody knew, Mrs. Kessler."

"You knew," she said, and went back inside and bolted the door, as she had on the Saturday two weeks ago, but this time he had the ziti.

• • •

The Friday shift was six to ten. At 6:02, with the gel still in its jar, she spoke without turning from the table.

"Did you call your mother back?"

"She called me. She froze the stuffing."

"She said she would," Maud said, and tipped the first of the gel out onto the knife.

"She asked if you ate. I told her the Sunoco."

"She'll hold that against you."

"She already does." He waited, and when nothing came, he said, "Mrs. Kessler sent a ziti. For you, she said. For the real one. It's in the car."

"Food doesn't come in," she said.

"I know. It's in the car."

She was quiet long enough for him to roll a swab. "Bring it Monday, to the corridor."

After that it was an ordinary shift. She said "Down" and "Lift" and "Clear," and he did, and the lower mantle went blue another square inch toward the Virgin's knee. Neither of them said a word about Thursday.

At 9:58, without looking up, she said, "Ten."

He waited at the door with his coat and his phone and his watch. She wiped the dish, and he went down in the cage with the whole thing still in his mouth.

That was the rule, and he had said it back to her word for word ten days ago and meant it, and it let him carry the thing home a second night and lie awake with it.

• • •

On Saturday he knocked at 7:58, when he had always waited for the hour before.

"It's open," she called from the sink.

She was at the bench with the kettle, her back to him, filling it left-handed at the dripping tap. He stayed on the threshold with his phone still in his hand.

"Before I come in," he said. "Can I say something? It isn't an apology."

She turned the tap off without turning around. "Then say it in the doorway."

"I stopped waiting for you around the first week of October."

The kettle stayed where it was, in her left hand, over the sink.

"It was a Thursday. The first. I was coming back from Carlisle, and at the Valley Forge exit it hit me that I hadn't thought about you in six days, and I'd slept every night, and I felt rested, better than rested. And I knew why. Nobody in the house needed me to do anything I couldn't see coming." He kept his eyes on her back, on the braid, done one-handed and coming loose at the bottom. "After that, every Sunday, I asked you what you needed so you'd say nothing. And you said nothing. And I was glad."

She set the kettle down on the bench very slowly, the way she set down a swab.

"What did you do," she said, "at the exit?"

"I turned the radio up."

"Why are you telling me now?"

"Because you told me on Thursday," he said. "And I sat there and told you nothing."

Nothing moved in the room except the tap, keeping its four seconds.

He waited, and the waiting did what waiting always did to him, which was look for the next step. The sentence was out before he heard it coming, in the level, helpful voice he used on Monday calls with fourteen buildings.

"Okay. So. What's the ask?"

He heard it land.

Eleven years of that sentence. Every call, every person who came to him with something heavy, and his answer always the same underneath: tell me the task, give me the piece I can carry, so I can carry it and be done. He had just handed her the worst true thing he knew about himself, and then he had asked her for a work order.

He did not take it back. There was no way to take it back that wasn't the same move.

She turned around. Her face was very still, the scar pale through the eyebrow. She looked at him across the room through three drips of the tap, the bench between them where she had put it.

“Thank you,” she said.

He waited for the rest of it.

She picked up the jar of skewers and held it out to him. “Go back to the cotton.”

Chapter 13 — Maud

“You said not at the table,” Odalys said from the doorway. “This isn’t a table, it’s a cot.”

It was twenty past six on Saturday, and Declan’s cage had gone down at six. She had come up the stairs with a bottle of Rioja under one arm and a blue plastic folder with a snap closure under the other, and she put the folder on the cot and the bottle on the floor, a good yard apart, like two solvents that should not share a shelf.

“Yesterday at Mami’s I had it halfway out between the pernil and the flan,” she said, “and you said not at the table, and my mother took your side. My mother takes nobody’s side. She said you’re too thin and your husband should sleep in the yard, and then she wrapped him a plate.”

“I gave the plate to Hamid.”

“Of course you did. Screw top,” she said, holding up the bottle. “I thought about your hand in the liquor store. You’re welcome.”

“The sheet’s on,” I said, “it can come in.”

“I know the rules, Alder. Same woman taught us both.” She poured into my one mug and a jam jar out of her tote and gave me the mug. “Drink half before you open it.”

“Wine doesn’t change what a text says.”

“No. It makes you sit still while you read it.”

My rule, made at three in the morning on this cot, was that I would read my sister’s version of me later, sitting down, in order, under a good light. Odalys had put them in order, since she has cataloged four thousand potsherds and can tell you where each one sleeps. That left the light, so I unclipped the raking lamp from the end of the bench and dragged it on its cord to the cot and set it low, as I would to find lifting paint.

“It’s paper,” Odalys said, watching me angle the head. “It’s not going to flake on you.”

“Paper has a surface,” I said, and tipped the lamp another few degrees, until the beam lay almost flat across the first page.

There were forty-four pages, four screenshots to a page, with the dates written in each corner in her green felt-tip, from August 27 to November 13.

Good morning! Still in Bologna, still text only, still kicking. How’s the museum?

I have never written good morning to anyone. Odalys and I pass texts as tools go across a bench, handle first, no greeting.

“Read the next one,” Odalys said, and then, “No, I’ll read it,” and she took the page out of my hand and did a voice, high and bright, a flight attendant’s voice. “‘What’s on your bench today?? Send me a picture, I’m going crazy here with

nothing to look at!’ Two question marks, Alder. You don’t use one. You ask questions with a period, like a cop.” She handed the page back.

• • •

The exclamation marks stood up off the paper like burrs. I have never in my life ended a text with one, and here they came, at the end of nearly every line, through September and into October, a woman who was always pleased.

I read the first one again out loud, in my own voice, to hear it. “Good morning. Still in Bologna. Still text only. Still kicking.”

“Oh, God, don’t,” Odalys said. “You sound like a hostage reading a statement.”

“That’s what it sounds like in my mouth. She wrote it for hers.”

For four pages she was a stranger with my name on her, cheerful as a florist’s van. Then on the fifth, under a photograph of a cracked pot, I came to a line that stopped me, and I read that one out loud as well.

“Paraloid, not the epoxy. You’ll thank me in forty years.”

“I almost bought that one,” Odalys said.

“That one’s mine. I sent it to you in March of last year, about the dog from Nayarit.”

“The dog. Damn, Alder, I’d forgotten the dog.”

My sister had gone back through two years of our thread and found the sentences of mine that would still work, and lifted them out and used them again, the way you save a flake of original paint off a ruined panel because it is the only real thing left on it.

“She read our whole thread.”

“She read everything, Alder. She had your phone for three months. She’d have read your dentist,” she said, and drank. “September twenty-second is when I started the folder. I sent you a Teotihuacan bowl with a hairline crack right through the shoulder, and you wrote back, ‘Gorgeous, two exclamation points, is that hard to fix.’ You have never asked anybody whether a thing is hard to fix. You’d have asked what I was using and then told me it was wrong.”

“Were you using the wrong thing?”

“I was using the right thing.”

“Then I’d have asked whether you’d tested it.”

“See?” she said, and tapped the page. “That’s you. This is a nice lady at a craft fair.”

October sixth was a Tuesday. At 9:47 that night, under a message from Odalys asking how the hand was, there was a long one, and I read it out loud too.

“I think I’m done, O. Like done done. The paintings, the scaffolds, all of it. Please don’t make it a thing, you know?”

“O,” Odalys said, holding the page away from her. “Nobody on God’s earth calls me O.”

“My sister does. She called you O at my wedding.”

"Did she," Odalys said, not as a question, and held the page a long time before she gave it back. "I called you. Twice. You texted, *Can't talk, pills. xx.*"

"I have never typed an x that wasn't a measurement."

That got a laugh out of her, a short ugly one, and she put the jam jar down.

"I had a ticket open on my laptop," she said. "Twice. The second time I didn't call your mother first. Philadelphia to Bologna, \$900, and my finger on the button. And then you sent me a picture." She leaned over and turned two pages and put her finger on it. "View from my window. A road with all those skinny trees. And I thought, fine, she's alive, she's being weird, she hit her head, leave her alone."

It was a road lined with poplars so straight they looked ruled, shot through the windshield of a small hot car, with the nephew's hand on the wheel at the edge of the frame.

"'View from my window,'" I said. "It's the road to the chapel. I took it from the car at two o'clock on August fourth, an hour before I went up. It's the last picture on my phone before the hospital."

Odalys put her finger back on the photograph, and then took it off, and closed her mouth.

"October sixteenth," Odalys read, without the voice this time. "'Please don't talk to Frances about me. I can't deal with her right now.' Two exclamation points. That's the week Frances called me. I told her you'd said you were done, and she said hm, and she hasn't picked up for me since. October twenty-fifth. 'Mom says hi! She thinks I need a real break from all of it, and she's right for once.'"

"My mother has never said hi in her life," I said. "She sends her regards."

"Alder. Read the rest of it."

"She thinks I need a break."

"Who's she?"

"Mother," I said, to the page.

"And who thinks your mother's right for once? On your phone?" Odalys sat forward with her elbows on her knees and said, "Your mother knew."

"She knew Cora was staying in the house."

"Alder," she said, in the voice she keeps for when I have labeled something wrong.

I looked at the page in the raking light, where the printer had laid its toner down in tiny ridges and the light caught every one, so that the words stood up off the white in relief. *She's right for once.* My sister had not in thirty-five years told anyone our mother was wrong. She had always been the one standing next to her.

• • •

"She called me," Odalys said. "Wednesday night. From her own phone. In her own voice."

I turned the page over on the blanket so the words were underneath.

"She said sorry eleven times. I counted on my fingers and had to start over. She said it was her, every good morning, all of it, and that she was doing a list."

"It's my list," I said.

"I figured it was," Odalys said, turning the jam jar on her knee. "Then I said, Cora, don't call me again until Alder says you can. And she said, okay."

"Just that?"

"One word. Your sister. Who is that, Alder?"

"I don't know yet," I said.

A train came over on the El, and the wired glass hummed in its frames, and Odalys waited until it had passed.

"Can I say a thing about him?"

"You're going to," I said, and pulled the moving blanket up over my knees.

"Alder, he stands by the elevator at ten waiting to be told he can go. Every night."

"He can go at ten. He knows that."

"I came at ten on Tuesday to take you for your shower. You were still inside wiping your dish. He was out by the cage with his coat on and his hand on that lever, and he didn't pull it. Four minutes, I stood on the stairs and watched him. Hamid says it's every night. Hamid says he thought he was waiting for a delivery."

"The rule is we talk at the end if I ask."

"And do you ask?"

"Twice. The first Saturday, and Thanksgiving."

"Out of how many?"

"Ten nights," I said, and it sounded like more out loud than it had in my head.

"So eight nights he stands out there with his hand on the lever in case you change your mind." She said it flatly, without any opinion in it, which is how she says things she has an opinion about. "Are you going to forgive him, or are you going to use him until the twenty-fourth?"

Nobody else had asked me that. My mother would not have, and Cora would have asked it and then answered it for me before I could open my mouth.

"I'm using his hands," I said.

"That's not what I asked."

I reached over and turned off the raking lamp. The pages went flat and white and ordinary on the blanket, and the room fell back to the one low light over the bench and the orange coil of Hamid's heater.

"I'm going to Havertown tomorrow," I said.

Odalys put down the jar and said, "To do what?"

"To ask my mother what she knew, to her face. She hangs up first on the phone. She can't hang up on a face."

"You don't have a car."

I took out my phone and called Declan, and he answered on the first ring, as he answers a building at four in the morning.

"Maud," he said, and nothing else, and waited.

"Tomorrow at one-fifteen you're driving me to my mother's in Havertown."

"Okay," he said, with no pause in front of it.

"You'll wait in the car."

“In the car.”

“It’s Sunday. It isn’t in the terms.”

“I know it isn’t,” he said. “One-fifteen.”

When I hung up, Odalys was looking at me over the rim of her jar.

“And Frances?”

“Monday,” I said, and Odalys was already shaking her head.

“Monday’s no good,” she said, standing up and pulling on her coat. “She called me last night, first time since October. Ruth Akers told her you’re treating the Wenceslaus altarpiece with an amateur and no reviewer, and she wanted to know if it was true. I said it was true, and the amateur was your husband.”

“What did she say?”

“Hm,” Odalys said, and she did it exactly, the flat little closed sound of a drawer shutting. “Then she said she’s phoning the Monsignor’s office first thing Monday, to put on the record that she has nothing to do with it.” She had her bag on her shoulder, and she stopped at the door with her hand on the frame.

“Call Frances before she calls the diocese,” Odalys said, and left the folder on my blanket, open at October.

Chapter 14 — Maud

“Engine off,” I said, “and if she comes out to ask you in, you say no.”

“Okay.”

“She’ll come out,” I said.

“Then I’ll say no.”

“If she sends my sister, you say no to my sister.”

“No to your sister.”

“If she sends a plate.”

“No to the plate,” he said.

He had picked me up at one-fifteen in a clean shirt and driven out without the radio or a question, and now the Outback sat ticking at the curb on a street off Eagle Road. My mother’s house is a stone-front twin with an aluminum awning and a holly bush my father planted the year we were born. The concrete goose on the top step wore a Pilgrim bonnet. She changes its clothes more often than she has ever changed her mind.

“Two hours,” I said, “perhaps less.”

“I’ll be here,” he said, with both hands still on the wheel.

I got out without his help, which took a while, and went up the walk.

• • •

She opened the door before I knocked, because she had been at the front window behind the sheers, where she always stands.

“Maudie,” she said, as if I had been gone a weekend.

She was in the navy cardigan with the pearl buttons and her good slacks, her hair set, smelling of Jergens and pot roast, and her eyes went straight to my eyebrow and stayed there.

“Oh, your poor face,” she said. “We were all so worried.”

“Who’s we?”

“Your sister and I, Maudie. And the whole prayer list at St. Denis.” She looked past me to the curb. “Isn’t Declan coming in? We don’t leave people sitting in cars.”

“He’s where I asked him to be.”

“In the cold.”

“He has a coat,” I said.

“They do wonderful things now with lasers, you know. Mrs. Haney’s daughter had a scar from a dog, right here, and you’d never know.”

“It’s staying.”

“Well, you don’t have to decide today.”

“I decided in August,” I said. “It’s staying where it is.”

She stepped back to let me in. “Wipe your feet, Maudie. The runner’s new.”

"The runner's from 1994," I said.

"It's new to the hall."

My father squinted from the piano nobody plays, in a bucket hat, the summer before he died. I took my coat off left-handed, the right arm in stages, and my mother took it from me and held it up to hang it, and stopped.

"That's Corabelle's scent," she said.

"It's my coat," I said.

She hung it on the hall tree without another word, two pegs over from a short black coat with a fake-fur collar.

Cora was at the dining table already, on the side by the window, in a gray sweater with the sleeves pulled down over her hands, and her face was thinner than mine. When I came in she started up out of the chair.

"Do you want, I can get you—"

"Sit, Corabelle," my mother said, "I'll do it."

Cora sat and put her hands in her lap, and she did not look up from her plate again for the rest of the afternoon.

• • •

The dining room has been papered in the same ivy trellis since 1998, and beside the radiator under the window, where the heat has worked at it for twenty-eight winters, one seam has lifted a quarter of an inch to show an older paper underneath, cabbage roses on cream. I found the roses when I was nine, and as far as I know nobody else has looked.

She brought in the roast on the Lenox platter and carved it thin, as my father liked it, and set the gravy boat down with its chip turned to the wall.

"Corabelle, say grace," my mother said, unfolding her napkin.

Cora said it to her folded hands, fast and small, in the voice we used for it at nine. "Bless us, O Lord, and these thy gifts, which we are about to receive from thy bounty, through Christ our Lord. Amen."

"Amen," said my mother, and picked up the serving spoon.

She put a plate in front of me with the beef on it in three thick slices.

"Corabelle, cut your sister's meat."

Cora's hands came up out of her lap.

"No," I said.

Cora's hands went back down.

I laid the side of my fork across the first slice and sawed, left-handed. It was slow and it went sideways and a carrot went over the rim onto the cloth.

"You'll ruin the cloth," my mother said pleasantly.

"Then it's ruined."

"Let me at least get you a knife with an edge on it."

"The knife isn't the problem."

"We were only trying to help, Maudie."

"I know what you were trying to do."

She passed the gravy, and when I didn't take it she set it down by my plate, turned so the chip faced the wall. "Corabelle's been such a help to me since she came home. She did the gutters. Mr. Haney couldn't believe it, a girl on a ladder in November."

"She's good at ladders."

"She's good at everything she puts her hand to. You always said so."

"I never said so."

"Well," said my mother, "you thought it."

I ate a piece of the beef, and it was very good, as it always is.

"Did you know she was answering my phone as me?"

My mother took a sip of water and set the glass down on its coaster. "Somebody had to answer it, Maudie. You were in no state. You called me by your father's name."

"Did you know she was me at Declan's table? On Fridays? In front of his whole office?"

"I knew Corabelle was helping at the house."

"That isn't what I asked."

"We don't interrogate people at the table."

"Then I'll ask in the kitchen. You can stand at the sink. You like the sink."

Across from me Cora's fork stopped halfway to her mouth and went back down.

My mother kept her eyes on me, a look like a hand on a doorknob that hasn't decided yet. When she spoke, it was the front-desk voice, soft and level.

"You were never here, Maudie. Someone had to be."

"She was here. In my coat."

"Cora needed something to do. She'd lost the shop. She'd lost the apartment. She was sitting in my spare room crying into the bedspread. And there was that house, with nobody in it but a man and a microwave."

"She had something to do," I said. "It was mine."

"He was eating, Maudie. For the first time in years that man sat down to a proper dinner. Corabelle told me. A man needs someone in the house. You can't keep a husband by telephone."

"I wasn't trying to keep a husband. I was trying to keep an arm."

"There's no need to be crude."

"It's an arm. It has nine screws in it."

"I always liked Declan," my mother said. "He's a sensible man. He came home to a house that was running, and he let it run."

"Yes," I said, "that's what he did."

"Every Friday night Corabelle would call me and tell me who came and what she'd made. The lamb with the rosemary. The salmon with the dill sauce. Your husband's boss's wife sent a thank-you card, Maudie, a real card, on paper, in the mail. When did anybody ever send you a card for a dinner?"

"Joan Teague sent a card to Maud."

My mother stopped with the gravy boat lifted an inch off the cloth.

"You knew whose name was on it," I said.

"I knew my daughter was being appreciated for once," she said, and set the gravy boat down, "in a house where she was needed."

"In my house. Under my name."

"When your father was alive, I was home every night, Maudie. Every night for twenty-three years. Dinner at six, his shirts done, you two in the bath. He went off to his pictures on Sundays and he came home to a house that was running. That's not fair, I'm not saying it's fair. It's what keeps a man. Nobody keeps anything by being somewhere else. You went off to Italy, and somebody had to keep your place warm."

"My place."

"Yes."

"With my name on it."

"Names," said my mother, setting her fork down. "You always did care more about the name on a thing than the people in the room."

"It's the only one I have," I said.

The radiator knocked twice under the window, and the old roses lay under the ivy where nobody could see them.

"I'm not going to quarrel with you on a Sunday," my mother said. "We don't do this. We never have."

"Odalys has a text from me. October twenty-fifth." I did not take out my phone. I had it by heart. "'Mom says hi. She thinks I need a real break from all of it, and she's right for once.'"

"I don't know what that is."

"I was in Bologna. On October twenty-fifth, did you tell Cora I needed a real break?"

"I tell both my girls they need their rest. A mother does."

"From all of it?"

"From that dusty work, yes, if you like. Is that a crime now?" She smoothed the cloth beside her plate. "You know, your father took you both to that museum every single Sunday. Corabelle came home and helped me get the roast on. You came home and stood at that radiator with your hands behind your back staring at the wallpaper. Every week. And your father, God rest him, never once asked me what I'd done all day."

It was the most she had said about my father in sixteen years, and she said it to the gravy boat. It was true and it was hers, and it answered nothing I had asked.

"Cora," I said, "what did you write to Frances?"

Cora's hands closed in her lap. Her face did not move, and she read her plate as if there were writing on it.

"Not at the table, Maudie," my mother said.

My mother's face did not do what a face does when someone says a name it doesn't know. It did not turn to Cora with a question in it. It went smooth and settled, the face of a woman at a front desk who already has the folder in her drawer

and is waiting to see if you will ask for it by name. Then it was only my mother again, passing the potatoes.

"You read it," I said.

"Read what, Maudie?"

"Whatever she sent."

"I don't read other people's letters."

"It was an email," I said.

"I don't read those either. I can never find the button."

"Frances Tilley," I said, "the woman who trained me. Somebody wrote to her in October in my name."

"I'm sure I wouldn't know anything about your Frances," my mother said. "That woman had you working weekends at twenty-four for a stipend I wouldn't pay a babysitter, and she never once sent a Christmas card. Have some more potatoes. Corabelle, honey, take Declan a plate. He's been sitting out there an hour."

Cora pushed her chair back and stood.

"You said you wouldn't know anything about her."

"I know she never sent a card." She held the potato dish out across the cloth. "Corabelle, did you hear me? A plate for Declan."

"Sit down, Cora," I said.

She stopped, with her hands on the back of the chair, half turned toward the kitchen and half toward me. For a second she stood exactly between us, the way she has stood between us since we were six.

"We don't leave a guest out in the cold," my mother said.

"He isn't a guest. He's waiting."

Cora sat down again, slowly, feeling behind her for the chair.

"And where are you living now?" my mother said, in the tone she uses for the weather. "Corabelle says you've left the house."

"I'm at the studio," I said.

"In a factory. With your hand."

"With a heater. Two."

"And Declan lets you."

"Declan doesn't let me anything."

"No," my mother said, "I can see that."

• • •

My mother cleared and came back with the coffee on a tray, and poured three cups, and I left mine.

"I don't have coffee after four," I said.

"It's ten to four," she said, with a glance at the mantel clock.

"It will be after four by the time I've finished saying this." I turned to my sister, who had her eyes on the tablecloth. "The fourteen hundred goes into your account on the first of every month. It won't, on Tuesday. It won't again."

Cora's shoulders came up and went down.

"All right," she said, to the cloth.

"Maudie," my mother said, "she has nothing. The shop is gone. The apartment's gone. She has no income at all."

"She has a room here, and gutters."

"She's your sister. She sat in that hospital in Italy holding your phone while you slept."

"She held it after I woke up, too."

"\$1,400. You'd do that to your own sister over a coat."

"Not over a coat."

"Then over what?"

"Over an email to a parish in Port Richmond, canceling a painting I'd signed for, in my name. Over \$11,400 sent back out of my account with my name on the transfer."

"Corabelle was looking after your health," my mother said. "Somebody had to."

"I didn't say what the email said."

"You said a painting. What else would it be about, Maudie, your health or your painting? It's always one or the other with you."

Cora's shoulders came up again, and stayed up.

"And the loans? She was going to pay you back, weren't you, Corabelle?"

"There won't be any more loans," I said. "What's lent stays lent. I'm not asking for it back. I'm not lending any more of it."

My mother set the coffee pot down on its trivet very gently, so that it made no sound.

"Is this what you came for," she said. "To do this in front of your sister. In my dining room."

"I came to ask what you knew. You told me the answer in the hall."

"I don't recall saying anything in the hall."

"You smelled the coat," I said.

"Everybody knows Corabelle's scent, Maudie. She's worn it since she was sixteen."

"Then everybody knew."

She did not raise her voice, because she has never once raised it, and she folded her napkin into a square and laid it beside her saucer with the edges lined up.

"We'll talk about Christmas when everyone has calmed down," she said.

"I won't be here at Christmas."

"We always do Christmas Eve."

"I'll be in Port Richmond on Christmas Eve, at St. Wenceslaus. There's an altarpiece going back up on the wall at the Midnight Mass, and I'm the one restoring it. I'll be working on it until the night before."

"A painting," my mother said.

"Yes."

"On Christmas Eve. Instead of your family."

“Yes.”

“And will Declan be in Port Richmond too, on his knees in front of your painting?”

“He’ll be where he is,” I said.

Cora said nothing at all, and her coffee sat in front of her with a skin coming up on it. Under the table her foot in its sock was pressed flat against the leg of the chair. At six she used to brace it there when she was trying not to cry in front of company.

I stood up in the two moves it takes me now, the left hand on the table and then the rest.

“I’m doing the list,” Cora said. She said it to her coffee, very low and very fast, the first thing she had offered on her own all afternoon. “I’ve done four. Mrs. Kessler, and Odalys, and the Dunns, and Mr. Abruzzo, I went to his house, he wouldn’t—”

“Don’t tell me,” I said. “Tell them.”

Her mouth closed, and she nodded at the cup.

“Thank you for dinner, Mother. The beef was very good.”

“You’ll take some home,” she said, already half out of her chair.

“No.”

She held my coat open for me in the hall, and I let her, because the right arm goes in more easily when someone holds the sleeve. She smelled the gardenia again and decided not to mention it.

“Corabelle cried for a week after you put her out of that house,” she said.

“She left it on a Saturday at noon. I left it at seven in the morning.”

“You were always the hard one.”

“I was the one at the wall,” I said.

She stood on the top step beside the goose and raised her voice exactly enough to carry, which is not the same as raising it.

“Declan, dear! Won’t you come in for coffee? There’s pie.”

The driver’s window came down three inches.

“No, thank you, Pauline,” he said, and the window went back up.

I went down the steps one at a time.

He was out of the car before I reached the holly, and he opened my door and held it, and asked me nothing.

Chapter 15 — Maud

Frances Tilley's front walk is forty-one flagstones long, and she watched me take every one of them from her front window, with a basset hound's chin on the sill beside her elbow.

I had come out on the 9:42 from Suburban Station with my notebook in my bag. On Saturday night, after Odalys left, I had dialed the number I have known by heart since I was twenty-four, and Frances had picked up and said nothing at all, and I had asked her not to telephone the Monsignor until she had seen me.

"Monday," she had said, "eleven," and then, "I don't do this on the telephone," and the line had gone dead.

It was a fieldstone house three streets up from the station, with a green door that opened while I was still on flagstone thirty-eight.

"You came by train," Frances said.

"I don't have a car."

"You have a husband with a car."

"He's at work," I said.

"Hm."

She was in a man's gray cardigan with leather elbows, her white hair cut short as a boy's, her weight on a blackthorn stick and off the right hip. She looked at the eyebrow exactly as long as she would give a loss on a panel before deciding what had caused it.

"Board?" she said, with a nod at it.

"Plank."

"Hm," Frances said, standing aside. "Mind the dog. Bartholomew, move."

Bartholomew, a long low animal with ears like two dropped gloves, did not move, except to lean his whole weight against my shins and sigh.

"He likes you," Frances said. "He has no judgment. Kitchen."

• • •

Every flat surface in the kitchen had something on it, journals in towers and panels drying in clamps, and on the sill an orchid she said she kept alive out of spite. By the wall telephone with its curling cord lay a pad, and on it in her square fountain-pen capitals: PELLEGRINO, ARCHDIOCESE, and a number, underlined twice.

She saw me read it and did not move it.

"You were going to call him."

"At nine this morning. You telephoned at ten past eight on Saturday, so I gave you till noon."

"It's eleven," I said, with a look at the clock over her stove.

"Then you have an hour." She turned to the stove. "Coffee. It's not four."

"No," I said, and she made it in a dented aluminum pot, standing, and I kept my hands in my lap, because she would have hit me with the stick. Then she sat across from me with the hip held out straight.

"Say it," she said, when she had drunk half of hers.

"I didn't write to you in October."

"Hm," she said, without blinking. "You didn't write to me. Somebody with your phone and your passwords and your grammar wrote to me."

"Not my grammar," I said.

"Don't correct me in my kitchen, Alder."

Bartholomew settled under the table across both our feet.

"Do you want to hear it?" she said.

"Yes," I said, and she didn't move.

"I don't keep it down here." She looked toward the hall and said, "It's upstairs."

The back stair went up from the corner of the kitchen, steep and boxed in, a ship's stair with a rope through iron rings for a handrail, on the right going up. I stood at the bottom of it and studied the rope and put my right hand on it in its brace, and the fingers closed on it the way they close on everything now, halfway, with the tremor waiting at the base of the thumb.

"Can you?" said Frances from the table, not getting up.

"No."

"Neither can I," she said. "I go up once a day, and this is it. Don't make a habit of being worth it. Wait there."

She hooked the blackthorn over her forearm and took the rope in both hands and went up. Fourteen steps, each one two sounds, the good foot and then the bad one brought up to meet it, and a breath between. Bartholomew sat on my foot at the bottom and listened with me. Halfway up she stopped, and neither of us said anything, and then she went on.

She came down backward, as you come down a ladder, with a manila folder inside her cardigan against her ribs.

• • •

She sat, and put on the glasses, and opened the folder flat on the table between the cups.

There was more in it than one sheet, and I can read upside down, because she taught me that as well: my first condition report for her, from 2015, a small Dutch panel with her red pencil all down the margin, and a postcard I had sent her from Madrid, a Velázquez dwarf. On top lay a single printed page.

She had kept a folder on me for eleven years.

"I print everything that matters," she said, without looking up. "Screens lie about weight."

She held the page out and read it to me flat and level, every word given its full value and nothing more, as she used to read a condition report back to a student so the student could hear what she had actually written.

"From Maud Alder. To Frances Tilley. Tuesday, October sixth, 11:52 p.m.
Subject: Re: thought of you."

She glanced at me over the glasses.

"That's a reply. I had sent you a paper on the fourth. Rigid gels on water-sensitive paint. I thought of you." She returned to the page. "Frances. I'm done with restoration. I've had a lot of time to think, lying here, and honestly I don't want it anymore. I don't think I ever wanted it the way you wanted it for me. I'm not going back up under anybody's ceiling for a few thousand dollars and a pat on the head. Stop sending me articles and stop managing me. I'm not your project. I know you mean well. Don't write back. Maud."

She laid the page down on the folder and lined it up with two fingers.

It was my voice, and that was the first thing, and it went in under the brace and stayed there. My sister doing me was the bright one from Odalys's screenshots, with an exclamation mark on every line. This was sharper, filed down, the voice I use on a bad day to a client who wants a painting to look new. Someone had sat with my phone at midnight and taken my sister's soft run-on sentences and cut them short until they cut. *I'm done with restoration*. Four words, in Frances Tilley's kitchen, read back to me by the woman who taught me to hold a scalpel, and I sat there and heard myself quit my own life.

My right hand had started. I put it under the table, on Bartholomew's back, and he let me.

"Well," Frances said, "that's the whole of it."

I raised my eyes from the page to her face, and it was the face she had sent to Walter Wozniak on her good stationery, the one she had sent Ruth Akers away with, and Kofi. If you stayed on it, though, she was looking at the page and not at me, and her mouth had gone small and tight at the corners, and her eyes behind the reading glasses were very bright and perfectly dry. It was the face of someone at a graveside who has decided in advance not to make a spectacle of herself and is holding to it by the fingernails. She had put that page in a folder with my first condition report and a postcard of a Velázquez dwarf.

"I noticed," she said, "before you say it. I'm not a fool."

"Noticed what?"

"Honestly," she said, and tapped the word with one fingernail. "You have never written honestly in your life. You think it's a word people use when they've been lying the rest of the time. You told me that, at twenty-five, about a dealer in New York." The fingernail moved down to the next line. "Ceiling. You told me yourself in July, on the telephone, a lunette over an altar, and you would sooner be dead than call a lunette a ceiling. And you sign everything to me M. Alder, like a condition report, because I made you, and in eleven years you've never once signed Maud."

"Then you knew."

"I noticed at midnight on the sixth of October, sitting in that chair, and I believed it anyway."

"You could have written back."

"It said don't."

"You've never in eleven years done what I asked you."

"I did it once," Frances said. "Look where it got us."

Bartholomew shifted under my hand.

"Why did you believe it?"

"Because of this," she said, and put her finger on one line. "Stop sending me articles and stop managing me. That one's true. I sent you an article a week for eleven years. I wrote your references and I told you which jobs to take and which to turn down, and when you married I sent you a paper on the conservation of wedding photographs, which was a joke, and you didn't laugh. I managed you. Whoever wrote that knew exactly where to put the knife, and when a knife goes in exactly there, Alder, you don't stand around examining the handle."

I had nothing to say to that, because it was true, and because I had thought it myself, in 2021, with a PDF open on my laptop, and had never said it to her.

"You did send a great many articles," I said.

"I did," she said, without a flicker.

She took the glasses off and let them drop on their cord.

"I thought you'd finally got out," she said. "Fifty-one years I've had my face in other people's paintings. I have a hip like a bag of gravel and a dog, and a pension, and a house full of journals nobody else will ever read. When that came, I sat in that chair and thought, she got out at thirty-five, before it took her hand and her eyes. Good for her." She looked at the orchid on the sill and turned her cup a quarter turn on its saucer, her hand stiff. "I was jealous of you. For a week. Then I was angry for two weeks, and then that man from the parish wrote to me, and I was glad to have someone to say no to."

"I didn't get out," I said.

"So I gather. Ruth Akers tells me you're treating the St. Wenceslaus altarpiece in a glove factory with an amateur and no reviewer."

"That's accurate."

"Hm," she said, and folded her hands on the folder. "I'll certify the plan when I see the work. Not before. I don't certify on an argument, and I won't certify on a sad story, and I'm too old to be lied to twice in one autumn by the same face."

• • •

I could have argued, since I had been arguing in my head from the moment the train left Suburban Station, all the way out past Lansdowne and Primos, and I had it ready, every point in order.

I had thought, until that kitchen, that what my sister took was a house, a coat on a hook and a chair at a husband's table. What she had taken was the name, and she had signed it to the end of me and sent it to the one person who would keep the printout.

You don't argue a name back. I took out the notebook instead and opened it on the table and turned it around to face her.

"I'm not going to argue it," I said. "Read the log."

She put the glasses back on and read the first page, and the second, turning them slowly, her finger moving down the margin where the initials were.

"Six-forty p.m.," she read. "Surface cleaning, area one, lower right, adjacent to the July test window. Operator D. Hale, under direct supervision of M. Alder, conservator, present throughout." She went on through the pages without reading any more of it aloud, her finger stopping at each set of initials, and at the end of the gel tests she stopped altogether. "Who taught you to keep a log like this?"

"You did," I said, and she made a small sound in her nose.

"These aren't your capitals," she said.

"No."

"Hands?"

"My husband's."

Frances Tilley kept her eyes on me over the glasses for a long moment, and then she laughed, out loud, one short bark that made Bartholomew lift his head off my foot.

"God help the canvas," she said, and then, "Show me the hand."

I laid it by my saucer, out of the brace. It lay still for four seconds, and then the tremor came up out of the thumb, fine and fast, and small rings went out across the coffee in my cup.

"Nerve?" she said, peering at it over the glasses.

"Irritation. The surgeon in Bologna says it may settle by spring."

"May."

"May."

"And if it doesn't?"

"Then I'll learn to do it with the other one," I said, and put the brace back on.

"Hm. And him?"

"He stops when I say stop. When his hand's tired he says so, and he stops. On the first Saturday he asked me what it looks like when it's right."

"And what did you tell him?"

"That you can't tell anybody was there."

"Hm," she said, turning another page of the log. "And the husband knew? About the sister?"

"He knew she was being me at his table. Nine Fridays. He didn't know about you, or the parish."

"He let it stand," she said.

"He poured the wine," I said.

"And you've put him on a swab."

"Four hours a night, ten on Saturdays, until the twenty-fourth."

"That's a sentence, not a marriage."

"It's a schedule."

"Hm," said Frances, and I told her the rest while she read on, because she was not looking at me, which is the only way Frances Tilley has ever been able to hear anything. The stoop, the toast, the eleven names, the blue corner. I left out my

mother. I didn't have my mother yet, only her face over a dish of potatoes, and that face would not have gone into a condition report.

When I finished, she closed the notebook and slid it back across to me.

"Your sister," she said, "the florist."

"Yes."

"She hasn't written to me."

"She will. By the eighth."

"I don't believe people who cry. You know that."

"I know. She cries when she orders lunch."

"And if she writes, and she cries on paper?"

"Then you'll have it in writing that she cries," I said.

The corner of Frances's mouth went down, which is what it does instead of going up.

"Terms," she said, and counted them off on the oilcloth with one finger. "You're in the room for every stroke. Not on the cot, not across the room, in arm's reach of the canvas, and awake. Every shift documented, the way you've been doing it. Photographs before and after every area, under the same light. If a swab comes up a color you don't expect, he stops and you write it down. If I find one entry in that book you weren't present for, I'll know, and there will be no certification and no Christmas, and I'll tell the Monsignor why."

"Yes," I said, before she had quite finished.

"Is that yes to all of it?"

"Yes to all of it."

She reached behind her without getting up, tore the top sheet off the pad by the telephone, and laid it on the table in front of me, face up. PELLEGRINO, ARCHDIOCESE, and the number underlined twice.

"You keep that," she said. "If the photographs on Friday aren't what's in that book, you call him yourself and tell him you've withdrawn. It'll be true, this time."

I folded it once and put it in the notebook, at the page with the July window.

She got as far as the hall and let Bartholomew see me the rest of the way. I was on the third flagstone when the green door opened again behind me.

"Photograph that window by Friday, Alder," Frances called down the walk. "Raking light and UV. Or don't come back."

Chapter 16 — Declan

Okay. So. One: out of Conshohocken at three, Nadine on the four o'clock. Two: the house by 3:40, Cora's boxes stacked in the hall before she arrived. Three: Cora at four, her car loaded by five, the studio by six.

At 3:38 he turned onto Brown Street, and she was already on the step.

She was sitting on the top step in the short black coat with the fake-fur collar, beside the Dunns' chrysanthemums, gone brown in the frost. Her knees were together and her hands were pulled up inside her sleeves. Pauline's white Corolla stood at the hydrant with its hazards going.

He parked behind it, and next door Mrs. Kessler's curtain moved an inch and stayed moved.

"How long have you been out here?"

"Since three. Sorry. Sorry, I didn't want to be late, I've got Mom's car and she needs it back by seven, it's her bridge night." Cora stood up too fast and steadied herself on the railing. "I'm early. I know. I'm always early now. I don't know when that started."

"You have a key," he said.

"I know I do," she said, looking at the door, at the old brass lock. "It didn't seem like I should, you know? Use it. It's not—it didn't seem right."

"You could have waited in the car."

"It smells like Mom's hand cream. I couldn't."

Forty minutes on a stone step in December. He did the arithmetic without wanting to and put it away.

He gave the lock its lift and opened the door, and she came in past him into the hall, and her hand went up to the third hook with her coat half off her shoulder.

It stopped there.

There were three hooks, his overcoat on the first and the second always empty. The third was Maud's, and the camel coat was in Kensington on a nail by a cot, and the hook was bare brass. Cora stood with her hand under it for about a second, then shrugged the coat back up onto her shoulders and kept it on.

"I'll be quick," she said.

. . .

The plan had the boxes in the hall. They were not in the hall. He had meant to bring them down at lunch and had worked through lunch, and so the four boxes and the rolling rack were still in the back room on the second floor, where he had taped the fourth one shut on Black Friday.

"I'll bring them down," he said.

"Oh, please," she said, already on the stairs. "Let me. I want to. Please, Declan, let me carry my own stuff."

So he let her, and it took forty minutes. She carried them one at a time with her chin on top of each box, and the fourth stair from the bottom creaked every time, and every time she said “Sorry” to it. He held the door, and he was bad at it. Twelve minutes with two people, eight with one who didn’t stop, and his hands kept coming up off his sides and he kept putting them back.

On the third trip she stopped at the bottom of the stairs with the box on her hip and looked at the hall table.

The blue bowl sat where it had always sat, with Maud’s brass key in it, beside the box in brown paper with the thick taped corners.

“You found it,” Cora said.

“It was in your box, full of hair clips.”

“Oh, God,” she said, and shut her eyes. “I put my clips in it. In September. I didn’t even think, I needed something for the clips and it was just there, it was just a bowl, honestly, I didn’t think about whose.”

“I know.”

“Do you, though?” she said, opening her eyes. “Because I keep finding out how many things I didn’t think about whose.”

She took the box out to the car.

• • •

The rack would not fit in the Corolla. He had known it wouldn’t from the doorway. Cora stood at the open trunk with the rack’s wheels in the air and the dresses already laid across the back seat like people asleep.

“Do you want me to take it apart?” he said. “There’s an Allen key in the hall closet. Four bolts.”

She turned, and he could see her hear the question, the shape of it, someone else’s sentence in his mouth.

“Yes,” she said. “Please. Thank you.”

He knelt on the sidewalk and took out the four bolts and put them in his coat pocket, and slid the two uprights in along the floor of the trunk, and gave her the bolts in a sandwich bag. Mrs. Kessler’s curtain had not moved back.

“She stopped the money,” Cora said, to the trunk. “On Sunday. In front of Mom.”

“I know, I was in the car.”

“You said no to the pie.” Something close to a laugh came out of her. “Mom couldn’t get over it. She said, he’s gone strange. She said it three times at the sink.”

“Probably,” he said, and did not argue.

“\$1,400.” She pushed the trunk down, and it didn’t latch, and she pushed it again. “I’ve been living on her for six years. Did you know that? She never said a word about it. Not one word, in six years. She’d just do it on the first and never mention it, and I’d text thank you and she’d send back a thumbs-up.” Cora wiped her nose on the back of her hand inside the sleeve. “I hated that thumbs-up. I don’t know why.”

He didn't say anything to that. He had his own version of the thumbs-up, eleven minutes on a Sunday.

"Is she still on that cot?"

"Yes."

"In December," she said, and looked up at the house.

"There are two heaters," he said.

"Is she eating?"

"Mrs. Kessler sent a ziti. She had it last night."

"Mrs. Kessler made her a ziti," Cora said, with one palm on the trunk lid. "She made me one in October. When she thought I was her."

"This one was for the real one," he said. "She said that. For the real one."

Cora took her hand off the trunk.

. . .

The last box was the one he had taped. She carried it down, and set it on the hall floor instead of taking it out, and stood up with her hand on the newel post, looking past him at the study door off the landing, which stood open.

"You don't lock it anymore."

"No."

"I used to hear it. Every night, from the stairs. You'd turn the key, and then the fan would go on upstairs, and that was the house going to bed." She held on to the post. "Declan, people are going to think things. Joan Teague's going to think things. Mrs. Kessler already does, I can see it in her curtain. I never touched you. You know that, honestly. I need you to know that I know it."

"I know it," he said. "You slept on the third floor with the fan going. I locked the study. Anybody who asks me gets that, the same way, every time."

"Good," she said, and let go of the post. "That's good. Thank you."

He had one more thing to put on the table, and he had been carrying it since ten o'clock the night before.

At ten on Monday Maud had said "Ten," and then, instead of wiping the dish, she had said "Stay," and they had eaten Mrs. Kessler's ziti cold out of the foil pan in the corridor, with two forks, her back against one wall and his against the other. She had told him about Swarthmore in four sentences, Frances's terms among them. The last one was the email. She had said it to him word for word, flat, in her log voice, and he had not known any of it.

"The email to Frances Tilley," he said, "October sixth."

Cora went very still, and it was not like her. He had seen her cry and apologize and fill silence for nine weeks, and he had never seen her stand still.

"Yes."

"You wrote that," he said.

"I sent it," she said, to the box on the floor. "It was me. From her phone. I sent it."

"Why?"

"Because that woman would not stop. Articles every week, every single week, PDFs, and Maud's in a bed in Italy with a plate in her arm and here's Frances sending her homework. I thought somebody should make it stop." Her voice was coming up into its usual speed, and she heard it and stopped. "I thought I was getting her some peace. You know?"

"Frances Tilley is the one person who can sign off on the painting."

"I didn't know there'd be a painting. In October there wasn't going to be a painting again, ever, that's what everybody—" She stopped. "That's what I thought."

"And two days later, the parish."

"Yes," she said, pulling her sleeves down. "Is Frances going to, did she say if she'd—"

"She wants photographs by Friday. Then she'll decide."

That was all of it, then, both of the things he had not known, and they had come into his house on the same phone that had sat on the table in the hall every night, charging, while he locked the study.

• • •

The key was on her ring with a rubber daisy pushed over the head, yellow, so she could find it in her bag. He had had it cut for her at the hardware store on Fairmount Avenue the first week of September. She worked it off the ring with her thumbnail, and it took a while, and he did not offer.

"Could you talk to her for me?" she said. She was looking at the key, not at him. "Not the list. I'm doing the list, I've done four. Mrs. Kessler and Odalys and the Dunns and Mr. Abruzzo. Joan's going to let me come Thursday. I'm doing all of it, myself, like she said. I just mean, could you tell her one thing. Just that I'm trying. One sentence. You see her every night."

"No."

"Just the one," she said.

"She said not through me. She told me she'd put it in writing."

"She put you in it?"

"She put me in it."

Cora kept her eyes on him for a long moment with Maud's face, the clean unbroken brow, the hair in its clip.

"You never asked me for anything," she said. "Not once in nine weeks. Not to cook, not to go, not to stop. Nothing. Do you know what that is?"

"Yes."

She waited for the rest. He did not have a rest that was hers to hear. He knew what it was the way he knew the Valley Forge exit at twenty to seven: he had done it to her sister for six years, and every Sunday since August, and called it rest.

"Yeah," Cora said, to the key.

She held the key over the blue bowl for a second, and then she let it go. It landed with a small ceramic tick beside Maud's square brass head.

Joan's text was still on his phone, unanswered, eight days old, and he thought of it then without meaning to. *Whose hand was it, Declan?* This one. The one with the bitten nails pulling back into its sleeve. He had watched it hand him a corkscrew in September.

"Drive safe," he said, "your mother needs the car by seven."

"I know. Bridge." She picked up the last box. At the door she turned around with it in her arms. "Will you text me if she—sorry. Sorry. Never mind."

She went down the steps carefully, feeling for each one. Mrs. Kessler's curtain dropped back into place.

• • •

At 5:14 the Corolla's hazards went off and it pulled out from the hydrant, and he stood in the open door until it turned at the corner, out of habit, the way he watched trucks off a dock.

Then he went through the house once, without a plan. The back room: the drafting table bare, nothing on the windowsill. Third floor: the guest room stripped, a square of cleaner floor where the box fan had stood. Four in the afternoon in this house used to be the quietest hour of his week, and he had liked it, and he had told himself it was because the work was done.

He stood at the top of the stairs and listened to the whole empty building.

At 5:20 his phone went with an email from HR. *Reminder: response to offer requested by 12/18.* He did not open it. He had not told Maud. She had not asked, and he had decided that was a reason.

He put on his coat and came down, and the fourth stair creaked under him.

In the blue bowl, two keys: Maud's square brass head, Cora's rubber daisy. He left them both and went to work.

Chapter 17 — Maud

The fourth solvent moved the 1957 cheek and nothing under it, and for the width of a grain of rice there was a woman on my table that nobody in Port Richmond had seen since before Easter of that year.

“Stop,” I said, and then, “Lift.”

He lifted, and the swab in his left hand was half the size of the ones he had been rolling for two weeks, a match head of cotton on a skewer, with its tip come up pink. Leon Wrobel’s pink, the sign painter’s pink, all lead white and good intentions.

“Is that bad?”

“That’s him coming off. Turn it to the light.”

He turned the swab under the lamp, and then, because I had not told him to, he did not look at the painting. He looked at me, waiting for the next thing.

We had tilted the table to forty degrees at six, its first tilt since the handlers set it down, and the Virgin’s face hung at the height of my chest. When I penciled four dots along her jaw he had asked one question: “Why there?”

“Because nobody looks there. You test where a mistake would hide.”

“Under the veil,” he said.

“In the shadow of it. Three millimeters each. One is the mildest, four is the strongest I’ll let near her face.”

One had done nothing, and neither had two.

“Three’s greasy,” he had said.

“That’s the varnish going. It stops at the paint. It’s polite.”

Four had gone into the 1957 skin and softened it, and he had rolled once, toward himself, and lifted, as he does now without being told.

I put on the headband and leaned in.

Under the pink dot was a gray. Under the gray, if you gave it a second, was a warmth, a flesh tone glazed so thin that the cool layer beneath came through it, the faint green that painters of that century laid under skin so the skin would have blood in it. Wrobel had painted Helen’s cheek pink straight through, like a peach on a seed packet. Under it a Munich workshop had painted a living face in 1886, and the living face had waited seventy years for somebody to roll a match head of cotton across her jaw.

I laughed.

I hadn’t decided to, but it came up out of me loud, the laugh I had at twenty-four over a cleaning test, before I knew anything about ceilings or hands, and it went up into the iron trusses and an El train came over and took the end of it.

He had not moved, and the swab was still in the air.

“What’s funny?” he said, without lowering it.

“She’s green,” I said, from under the headband.

“Green’s good?”

"Green is a cheek. A real cheek has green under it. Put that in the can and give me the notebook."

He put the swab in the can and gave me the notebook, and his hand, giving it to me, was not quite steady, and his hands are always steady.

"Seven fifty-two p.m.," I dictated. "Solvent tests, overpaint, Virgin's left jaw at the edge of the veil. Four sites, three millimeters each. Site four, 1957 overpaint reduced. Original flesh tone present beneath. No loss." Then the operator line, which he could have written by now without me.

He wrote it in his dock capitals and initialed the margin and then sat with the pencil.

"How much of her is under there?"

"Ask me when we get to her."

"Okay," he said, and laid the pencil down along the gutter of the notebook. "That was a good laugh."

"It was a laugh," I said.

"It was a good one," he said, and went to wash his hands.

• • •

"Frances wants the window by Friday," I said. "Raking light and UV. Friday is tomorrow."

"What do I do?" he said.

"Nothing. You sit on that stool by the door and you don't move."

"For how—" He shut his mouth on it.

"For as long as it takes. These boards carry. A hundred years of glove cutters wore valleys in them, and if you shift your weight by the door, the tripod by the window feels it."

He took the stool and went still on it.

I set up the camera left-handed on the copy stand, which took eleven minutes and two words I don't use in front of clients. Then the raking lamp, flat along the bottom of the painting so the light came across the surface instead of onto it, and under it the ninety-one losses we had laid down lay flat as pressed leaves, and the blue squares we had opened since November sat in their tape along the lower mantle like a strip of stamps on a brown envelope. I made three exposures of each, because Frances counts.

Then I turned off the room.

The UV lamp makes a hum you only hear in the dark. Under it an old natural-resin varnish glows a sick swamp green, and anything put on after the varnish sits on top of the glow and blocks it. My windows went black in it. Up in the face, and across the Child's blanket, the 1957 paint floated on the green in flat dark islands.

At twenty past eight the freight elevator came grinding up the shaft.

"Don't move," I said, to the door, without turning around.

The gate came across gently, drawn by somebody who had been told about the gate. When I looked around, Mrs. Hajek was just inside the door in her purple

knitted hat with a foil dish against her chest and a brown plastic radio under one arm, its antenna made of a coat hanger, and the UV had found every bit of white on her, her teeth, and the waxed papers of the lemon candies glowing through her coat pocket.

She looked very frail in that light, an old woman with a dish who came up to my collarbone. Give her another second, though, and you saw she had planted her rubber boots well apart on my boards and was not going to fall over for me or the Archdiocese.

“What’s the green?” she whispered.

“Old varnish,” I whispered back, because it seemed to be that kind of room.

“And the black? In her face, in the baby’s blanket?”

“Leon Wrobel,” I said, and it was a pleasure to say it.

“Ha,” said Mrs. Hajek, in the dark, with deep satisfaction.

She did not move after that. She watched the UV light, and she watched him, and somewhere behind me in the dark a man sat on a stool for forty minutes, all told, and did not shift once, and the tripod never moved.

I finished the lower edge, three of each, and turned on the room.

“Pierogi,” Mrs. Hajek said, blinking. “Potato and cheese. Also sauerkraut, for him, he’s big. Walter drives me, he sits in the car. That elevator he won’t ride, not for the Pope.”

“Food doesn’t come in here, Mrs. Hajek.”

“It’s not food. It’s pierogi.”

“It goes in the corridor.”

She took this with the patience of a woman who has argued with priests, set the dish on the corridor floor with the foil tucked, and came back in holding the radio out in front of her in both hands.

“For the baby. In the basement he had the radio every day, five months. Now he’s here with nothing. Too quiet for him.”

“There’s an outlet under the windows,” Declan said from the stool, without standing, because he was waiting to be told he could.

“You can get up,” I said.

He got up and took the radio and plugged it into the end of the orange cord he had taped along the wall twelve days ago, and found WRTI without being asked, a saxophone, low.

Mrs. Hajek unwrapped a lemon candy and put it in my left hand, and then, after consideration, one in his.

“Suck it. Don’t chew,” she told him. “For the hands. You’re the husband.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

“You don’t talk.”

“Not in here,” he said, around the candy.

“Good. Stanley talked.” She turned to the painting, and her face changed, and she came two steps nearer and stopped where the sheet would have been. “Oh. Look at the corner. Look at that blue, *kochanie*. Like the sky over the river in March.”

She stayed on it a long time. Then she pointed her chin back at the stool.

"I watched him. Twenty minutes, in the dark. He doesn't scratch, he doesn't sigh, he doesn't look at his watch."

"He doesn't have a watch in here."

"Your husband sits very still," she said to me, while he stood four feet away with a lemon candy in his cheek. "That's a good husband."

"He was told to," I said.

"Nobody is told that. Forty years I told Stanley." She patted my braced arm, once. "Sits still. Good."

I did not look at him, and I could feel him not looking at me.

• • •

There was one flake left in the face, at the edge of the veil above the left brow, a sliver lifting at one side, and I wanted it.

My left hand is good for ninety-one losses along a hem. This was a hair's breadth from her face, and I wanted the hand I had trained for fourteen years, for one stroke, even shaking.

"Put your arm here," I said.

"Here?"

"Lower. Across the bridge. Sleeve up."

He laid his left forearm across the padded bridge, his sleeve pushed back. I loaded the finest brush I own with adhesive, took my right hand out of the brace, and set the heel of it on his arm.

"Don't move it," I said.

"I won't."

His forearm was warm and absolutely still, the long muscle under the skin doing nothing at all, and the tremor came up out of my thumb as it always does and went down into him and stopped there, the way a vibration stops in a heavy table. I could feel his pulse under the heel of my hand, slow, and mine was not. I touched the brush to the lip of the lift and the adhesive ran in under it on its own.

"Iron," I said, without taking my eyes off the flake.

He held it in his right hand over the silicone paper, his left arm not moving under my wrist.

"Down, two, three, lift."

The flake lay down.

I kept my hand where it was one breath longer than I needed, and then I put it back in the brace, and he took his arm off the bridge slowly, waiting to be told he could have it back.

"That was the right one," he said, very low. "Your right hand."

"For one stroke," I said.

"It was steady."

"Your arm was steady."

Mrs. Hajek, at my elbow, said nothing at all, with her hands folded on her coat.

I brought the raking lamp up to check the flake, low across the brow, and leaned in under the headband.

The 1957 brow was a perfect arch. Wrobel had drawn it in one confident stroke, a sign painter's line, the brow you put on a woman on a billboard for cold cream. Under raking light it should have been smooth, and it was smooth, but it wasn't flat. At the outer end, where the brow ran in under the edge of the veil, the surface stepped down and up again over something, a small ragged break about six millimeters long, with the edge of older paint catching the light on either side. A knock from a candlestick, perhaps, or a flake that had come away in the first fifty years. Somebody had filled it, and Leon Wrobel had painted his perfect arch straight across the top as if it had never been there.

I wrote it down before I moved the lamp. *Left brow, outer end at veil: old loss beneath 1957 fill, approx. 6 mm.*

"What is it?" said Mrs. Hajek.

"An old damage, under the new paint."

"Good," she said, and nodded, satisfied. "Helen Wrobel never had a mark on her. My mother couldn't stand it."

• • •

At ten to nine my phone rang on the bench, and I went and got it, because it was my studio and my telephone.

"Ms. Alder," said Walter Wozniak. Behind him an engine idled and a heater fan roared. "Forgive the hour. I'm downstairs, in front of the building, and I'll stay here, if I may."

"Mrs. Hajek told me about the elevator."

"The elevator and I have reached an understanding." He cleared his throat, as he does before anything official. "Monsignor Pellegrino's office telephoned the rectory this afternoon. The Commission will visit your studio on Friday the eleventh, at two o'clock. The Monsignor, Father Tomasz, and myself. They'll want to see the work, and the documentation, and the assistant."

"The assistant is my husband."

"So Bernadette informs me, at length," he said, over the roar of the fan. "The Monsignor's secretary used the word irregular three times."

"It is irregular."

"So is a parish that keeps its altarpiece in a glove factory. I told her so." He paused, and the fan filled it. "They also asked whether Ms. Tilley would attend."

"Ms. Tilley is reviewing the photographs," I said.

"I'll tell them exactly that. Not one word more. Ms. Alder, I don't ask what isn't my business."

"I know you don't, Walter."

"And if you would tell Bernadette the car is warm."

Mrs. Hajek had heard her name across the room and was already buttoning her coat. Declan was looking at the camera on its stand.

“Do you want me to drive the card out to Swarthmore?” he said. “Tomorrow, before work.”

“Odalys is coming for it at ten. She’ll print it at the museum tonight and drive it out at seven.”

“Frances sends her to voicemail.”

“Frances can’t send a doorbell to voicemail.”

At the door Mrs. Hajek stopped, and went back, and turned the radio’s dial with two fingers, a station further down the band, and then back to the saxophone, to check that both were still there.

“Leave it on,” she said. “Next time I come with Walter, I put the polka.”

“I don’t work to polka, Mrs. Hajek.”

She went out to the cage, where Declan had the gate open for her, and turned around in it with her hand on the brass lever.

“Polka,” she said, “is good for glue.”

Chapter 18 — Declan

Plan: nothing.

That was the plan at 10:40 on Saturday night, and it was a good one: lock the bottom lock, pull the gate shut, drive home. He had the key in his hand to do it with, a brass Yale on a paper tag that said PAPPAS 3 in pencil, and she was asleep.

She had been up before six, and the tape and swabs were laid out when he knocked at seven, an hour early, because she had asked, with the Commission coming Friday. Frances had phoned on Friday night, ten minutes after his cage went down, and Maud gave him the whole of it at 7:02, flat, in her log-entry voice.

“Odalys says she opened the door. First time since October. She took the envelope and said Hm and shut it.”

“That’s good,” he’d said, meaning it.

“That’s Frances being warm,” Maud had said.

“She said, ‘They match the book. Go on. Same terms.’” Maud had pulled on her gloves. “Then she said, ‘One entry, Alder,’ and hung up.”

“One entry.”

“One entry I’m not in the room for. You heard her terms. I told you Monday.”

“Arm’s reach,” he’d said, “awake.”

“Not on the cot. Her words, not mine.”

“Not on the cot. And if she finds one?”

“Then there’s no Christmas, and she tells the Monsignor why.”

Fourteen hours after that she was on the cot under the camel coat, still in her apron, her braced arm laid along her ribs where she had been holding it since about four. She held the arm against herself and took two ibuprofen dry at the sink at six, and by nine her mouth had gone gray at the corners, and at 9:20 she had put the key in his hand.

“Is it the plate?” he had asked her.

“It’s the cold. It gets into the plate.”

“Do you want the heater closer?”

“I want you to lock it when you go. The bottom one. Bring it Monday.”

“The bottom one,” he’d said, and closed his fingers on the paper tag.

“Leave everything where it is.”

“I will. Go to sleep.”

“I’m lying down for ten minutes. Wake me at half past.”

“Okay,” he’d said, and moved the heater a foot closer anyway.

“Don’t let me sleep, Declan. I mean it.”

“Half past,” he’d said, and she was asleep before he finished saying it.

At half past he had stood over the cot with his hand out and not put it on her shoulder, because after fourteen hours she could have ten more minutes. That was an hour and ten minutes ago.

He did what was left that he'd been told to do, caps on the bottles and swabs in the can. He did not touch the lamp, because the lamp was hers, and it stayed on over the table, low and white across the corner.

The lower-left corner was half done.

He knew exactly how half. A square of tape two inches on a side, at the very bottom of the mantle, hard against the edge, and the left half of it clean and the right half under a crust of grime darker than anywhere else on the canvas. A century of candles had burned on that side.

"And the varnish is thin here," she'd said at four. "Somebody scrubbed this corner before Wrobel ever touched it. A sacristan with a bucket and soap, probably, every Easter. So we go one swab at a time, and I watch every one."

He had done the left half that way, one swab, then her voice, then the next. At five she had stopped him.

"I could finish the right half now," he'd said. "It's twenty minutes."

"It's twenty minutes if nothing goes wrong. Monday."

Then she had moved them both to the knee.

Monday was two days off, then four nights, then the Monsignor at two on Friday, with the face still under Wrobel's paint and Frances Tilley behind all of it with a loupe.

At 10:45 somebody knocked, soft, and the door opened a few inches on Hamid in his scorched jacket, a roll of tape pushed up his wrist.

"Car man," he said, and looked past Declan at the cot and dropped his voice. "She sleeps?"

"She's asleep," Declan said, as low as Hamid.

"Good. A month I see that light on till two." He nodded at the lamp. "Glass is the same. Keep the fire on it all night, it forgets its shape, and you pay for the gas anyway. You want coffee? I have the machine downstairs, Italian, steel, older than me. It makes mud, but hot mud."

"No, thanks."

"So, you go home now."

"I'm going. Five minutes."

"Good. Lock the bottom one, the top one sticks. Pappas puts olive oil in it. I told him, olive oil is for bread, for brass you want graphite, but he's the landlord, what can I do." The door closed, and his boots went down the stairs.

In the bowl his phone lit up, and he could read it from where he stood.

Ray: Mon 8am my office. Need an answer on ATL, Dec. Don't make me chase you.

The screen went dark, and the clock over the sink said 10:58, then eleven.

The cot was fourteen feet away. She was on her side facing the wall, the coat up to her ear, the braid gone loose on the pillow. Her breathing had the long drag in it she only got after a double. He had heard it on Sunday mornings for six years, from

the landing, with their bedroom door half shut, and stopped hearing it sometime in the spring.

The right half of the square sat there under the lamp, forty minutes of work, maybe fifty, and he had done eighty square inches of surface dirt since November.

"Let me take that off your plate," he said, quietly, to the back of her head.

He heard it, the line he used on Lou Varga and on Ray. It was what he had done with the corkscrew in September, without the words: taken it out of her sister's hand and poured.

She didn't move, and he washed his hands at the dripping tap, warm, no soap after the first rinse.

• • •

It was surface dirt, he told himself while he pulled on the gloves, and that had the advantage of being true: the same motion he had made a few thousand times under her eyes. Maud's rule was about decisions, and this was a motion. Frances's rule he noticed himself not thinking about.

He was being efficient.

He unscrewed the bottle by hand, and the cap gave with a click that sounded to him like a dropped wrench. On the cot nothing changed.

At 11:10 he started: blot, roll toward you once, lift.

The cotton came up the gray-brown of mop water. The crust was thicker than on the left half, a black skin over the brown, and it came away a swab's width at a time. He kept a count without meaning to, like pallets off a trailer: twelve swabs, twenty, thirty-one.

At midnight the web of his left thumb began to burn.

If your hand gets tired, you say so and you stop.

He shook it out, because she had said that too, the first night: for the first month it's normal, shake it out, do it again.

At 12:40 the swab came up gray, and along one edge of the cotton, where it had touched the bottom of the square, there was a faint stain, yellowish, the color of a smoker's ceiling.

He held it under the lamp.

The lamp was warm, and everything under it looked a little yellow, which was a fact about the lamp. He turned the swab and rolled again, and that face came up gray, only gray, and he put the first one in the can and did not look at it again.

At 1:30 his left hand cramped all the way up into the forearm and would not open.

He held it against his chest for a minute and looked at what was left. Three-quarters done: a strip along the bottom and one black nub of crust the size of a lentil, baked on hard, ten minutes' work.

He took the next swab in his right hand.

He had never done this with his right hand. The right hand signed things and carried things. It did not know how heavy to be. The first roll went fine, and the second, and then he was at the nub, and the nub would not lift.

He laid the swab on it and held it there to soften it. That was the gel, that was what she did with the gel, sixty seconds and clear. He counted under his breath, in her rhythm.

“Thirty-nine,” he said, to nobody. “Forty. Forty-one.”

The El came over and the windows hummed, and the next number didn’t come, and he started again at what he thought was forty. Hamid’s neon buzzed through the floor. Somewhere in there his right hand bore down, because it didn’t know not to.

At what he called sixty he lifted.

The nub was gone, and the cotton was gray, and in the middle of the gray was a smear of something else.

Blue. A dull, chalky blue-gray, the size of a fingernail paring.

2:04 by the clock over the sink.

“Okay,” he said to the corner. “So.”

Nothing came after it.

• • •

He put on her old headband with the taped hinge and bent over the corner.

The square was clean, all of it, and at the bottom edge, where the nub had been, there was a patch about the size of a shirt button that was not the same as the rest. The blue around it had depth, like looking down into water, and the patch had none. It was flat and pale and dry-looking, the matte gray-blue of a primed wall. Inside it the edges of the little plates looked raw.

He took the headband off.

“It’s wet,” he said out loud, to hear somebody say it. “Wet looks wrong. Give it ten minutes.”

He gave it ten minutes, then twenty. He turned the lamp off and stood in the dark with the El going over, and turned it on again and came at it low from the side, raking, and from the side it was worse.

Varnish, he thought: she had told him in November that varnish brings the color back. When the corner was varnished it would come up like the rest.

He held on to that for most of an hour.

Then, a little after three, he looked from the patch to her July window, four feet away across the bottom of the canvas, and back, and let go of it. Varnish would bring back the depth of what was there. It would not put back what was in the can, and he had walked enough dock floors to know a dirty slab from a cracked one.

At 3:34 he took the glove off his right hand and laid his bare hand on the table, beside the painting, not on it.

The notebook lay closed at the end of the bench with the pencil in its spine.

He opened it, and it fell open where it always did now, at the page with the July window. The folded sheet from Frances's pad was there in the gutter, the Monsignor's number showing through the paper backward. It had been there since Monday, and she had said nothing about it.

One entry, Alder.

He did not write in her book. He took a sheet of the graph paper she used for diagrams from beside the camera and wrote on that instead, in the dock capitals, slowly, everything, starting with the date. *11:10 P.M. SURFACE CLEANING, LOWER LEFT CORNER, RIGHT HALF OF SQUARE. OPERATOR D. HALE. CONSERVATOR NOT PRESENT. ASLEEP. NOT TOLD.* Midnight, left hand tired, continued. 12:40, swab yellow at the edge, continued. 1:30, left hand cramped, continued with the right. 2:03, swab held on the surface about ninety seconds, count lost. Then what was on the cotton, and what was under the lamp. Approximately half an inch.

He read it through once and initialed the margin, D.H., and laid the sheet on top of the closed notebook, edge to edge, and put the pencil on it.

Then he sat down on the stool by the door and did not shift his weight, as if the tripod were still standing by the window.

The first westbound train went over at 5:12. At 5:30 Hamid's neon clicked off downstairs, and the north windows went from black to gray.

At 5:40 he got up and crossed the fourteen feet, and crouched by the cot, and did not touch her.

"Maud," he said, once, not loud.

Her eyes opened at once, already looking at something, and the something was his face, close, at that hour.

"What time is it?"

"Twenty to six."

"Why are you still here?"

He watched her read his face twice and know, before he said a word, that it was not about a phone call.

"I did something," he said. "To the painting."

"How bad?"

"I don't know how to measure it. You do. That's why I woke you."

She sat up under the coat. She looked past him at the lamp still burning over the corner, and at the single sheet of graph paper lying on her notebook with the pencil across it.

"Show me."

Chapter 19 — Maud

Under the UV lamp the loss was a dark spot at the lower left of the mantle, a hole in the green glow where something had been and wasn't anymore, and I measured it with the steel rule twice, because the first time my hand shook the rule off its mark.

Thirteen millimeters.

I turned the room back on.

He was standing where I had put him without thinking, at the corner of the table where the boards dip, with his hands at his sides. I had said "Show me," and he had shown me, the lamp brought down low, the headband held out to me by the band, and then he had stepped back to his place and not said a word.

The sheet of graph paper was still lying on the notebook where he had left it, and I read it standing, in the gray from the north windows, with the coat on over my apron.

His capitals are very clear. They were made for dock forms, for men reading them at four in the morning under sodium lights, and there is no way to misread a single one. *CONSERVATOR NOT PRESENT. ASLEEP. NOT TOLD.* Then the times, all of them, down the left margin: midnight, 12:40, 1:30, 2:03.

"The yellow," I said, with the sheet still in my hand.

"Twelve-forty. On the edge of the swab."

"What did you do?"

"I said it was the lamp."

"The lamp."

"It's a warm lamp," he said, to the table. "Everything under it looks a little yellow."

"And your hand."

"At midnight I shook it out."

"It says one-thirty you went to the right."

"Yes."

"You've never held a swab in your right hand."

"No."

"Why?"

"It was eleven, you'd been up since before six, the Monsignor's Friday."

"That's when. I asked why."

He took a long time, and looked over at the bowl, where his phone lay dark, and back.

"Because I could see the whole week," he said, "in order. And you were in it on Monday doing one swab at a time on a corner, and I thought, I can take that."

"Take it."

"Off you."

"I said wake me at half past nine."

"You'd been up since before six."

"That was mine to decide."

"Yes."

"You wrote approximately half an inch."

"Yes," he said, to the sheet.

"Half an inch is twelve point seven millimeters. It's thirteen."

"Thirteen," he said, as if he were writing it down.

I put the sheet down where it had been. My right hand had begun in the brace, not the fine tremor, the other one, the coarse one I get when I've been cold too long and the plate aches, and I held it against my ribs with my left and sat down on the end of the cot because my knees had decided for me.

The loss was at the very bottom of the mantle, where the cloth folds over the step the Virgin sits on and runs off the edge of the canvas. From a pew it would be the darkest corner of the painting, and nobody in Port Richmond would ever look at it.

"Do you know," I said, "what was on top of that blue?"

"Varnish," he said, after a moment.

"Under the varnish."

He didn't answer, so I told him.

"Glaze. A man in Munich laid it on in 1886, one breath of color over the blue so it would look deep. One breath thick. I told you the varnish was thin there. I said one swab at a time."

"You said you'd watch every one."

"There's no more of it. Anywhere. You can't order it."

"I know," he said, and he did.

"This is what you do," I said. I did not raise my voice. I don't think I could have. "You make it easier, and it's gone."

"Yes," he said, without moving.

Nothing else followed, though I waited for the rest, because there is always a rest with him, a plan and the hours it will take, and none of it came. He stood at the corner of the table with his left hand around his right wrist, holding it hard enough to leave marks, and by the marks he had been holding it that way since before I woke up. I had taken him for calm. He had the face he puts on for a yard full of stacked trucks at three in the morning, and under it the hand was holding the other hand down.

Under the anger there was something older, and I had kept it off the bench since the stoop the way you keep a solvent away from a water-sensitive paint. I loved him. I had loved him in a chapel with my head on the bricks and a stranger's palms over my ears.

A train went over on the El, and the tap dripped.

"It's Sunday," I said, to the floor between us.

"I know."

"I work alone on Sundays."

"I know," he said, making no move toward the bowl.

"Sit down," I said, and tipped my head at the stool.

"Do you want me to go?"

"If I wanted you to go I'd have said go. I'm not my sister. I say the word."

He took the stool by the door.

• • •

There were two things to do, and the first was the book.

I opened the notebook at the July window, because it falls open there now, and Frances's torn sheet was in the gutter with the Monsignor's number showing through backward. I unfolded it and read the number. I know it by now. I folded it again along the same crease and put it back.

Then I took his sheet of graph paper and turned to the last page I had written on, the knee, Saturday, five o'clock, *Operator D. Hale, under direct supervision of M. Alder, conservator, present throughout*, initialed in his hand. I got down the Japanese tissue and the little jar of wheat-starch paste from the shelf over the sink, and tore a strip of the tissue along a wet line, left-handed, and pasted it, and hinged his sheet into the book along the inside edge so that it lay over the next blank page and turned with the others.

It took me a long time with one hand. He stayed on the stool, and I let it take as long as it took.

Underneath his last line, on the book's own paper, I wrote in my leaning capitals: 5:52 A.M. CONSERVATOR PRESENT. LOSS CONFIRMED UNDER UV. 13 MM. GLAZE REMOVED TO UNDERPAINT, LOWER LEFT OF MANTLE. M.A.

"She said one entry," he said, from the door.

"She did."

"That's the entry."

"That's the entry," I said, and blotted it.

"Then why are you putting it in?"

"Because it happened," I said.

"You could take it out. It's on a hinge."

"Everything I do is on a hinge," I said. "That's the point of a hinge. It isn't the point of a hinge to take things out when nobody's looking."

He looked at the book on the bench a long while.

"Call her," he said, "tell her it was me. Tell her it wasn't you."

"She'll know it was you. It's in your capitals."

"Then what happens?"

"Then she reads it, and she decides, and if she ends it she ends it on what happened. Not on what I tidied." I shut the book before I said, "That one's not a question for you."

"No," he said.

• • •

The second thing was the corner, and before the corner, the photographs.

Frances wants every area photographed before and after, under the same light, and she did not say except the areas you'd rather not. I set up the copy stand where it had stood on Thursday, and laid the gray card, and brought the raking lamp in flat along the hem. In raking light the loss was a small dull field with no shine on it, sunk the depth of a glaze below the blue around it, and the camera saw it exactly as it was. I made three exposures of each, then put the room out and took three more by UV, with the dark spot in the green.

He sat on the stool in the dark for all of it and did not shift.

"Frances will want a before," I said, when the lights were on.

"Before what I did," he said.

"Before what we're going to do about it."

He waited while I put the camera away, and I let him.

"There's a repair," I said, "and I'm going to tell you exactly what it is, once, so you don't make it into something it isn't."

"Okay," he said, and sat back on the stool.

"Nothing puts the glaze back. It's gone, it's in your can." My voice came out very level, the voice I use on clients who want a painting to look new. "What we do is lay a thin varnish over the loss first, a different resin, so whatever goes on top can come off again someday without touching what's left. Then a retouch, a reversible paint, inside the loss and not one hair outside it, close enough to the blue that from a pew nobody sees it."

"And under the light?"

"Under the UV it'll read dark. Every time anybody puts a lamp on it, for as long as there's a painting. That's what it's supposed to do. It says somebody was here and when."

"You could make it so it doesn't show."

"No. I couldn't. I won't pretend there's glaze where there isn't."

He nodded, as he had nodded at the terms.

"Who does it?"

I had not decided until he asked, or I had, on the cot, before I opened my eyes all the way, without telling myself.

"You do."

He looked up.

"Wash your hands," I said.

• • •

He laid the isolating varnish with the softest brush I own, a thin coat inside the loss, and I followed every stroke under the headband with my face eight inches from the canvas and my good hand braced on the table edge. Then it had to dry, two hours to be safe, and while it dried I taught him to mix.

Retouching colors come in little pans, like a child's watercolor box, pigment bound in a resin that will lift with a solvent fifty years from now. I put a white tile and the pans in front of him, with a brush that had perhaps forty hairs in it.

"Ultramarine," I said, "a breath of black. White. You want it lighter than you think. Retouch always goes darker as it dries."

His first was navy, a school uniform. His second was a swimming pool. His third was very close and wrong in a way I couldn't have explained to anyone but Frances, too cold, a blue with no history in it. He laid them in a row along the top of the tile and wiped the brush and did not say anything about any of them.

"Too cold," I said, of the third.

"It's the same as the window."

"It's the same color as the window. It isn't the same blue. That one has been under a varnish for a hundred and forty years. Warm it."

"With what?" he said, and held the brush over the pans.

"Umber. A grain of it. One grain."

He took up a grain of umber on the tip of the brush, so little I couldn't see it, and the fourth blue went muddy anyway.

At nine I turned on Mrs. Hajek's radio, because the two of us breathing was the loudest thing in the room, and out of it, at full Sunday volume, came an accordion and a man shouting in Polish about a girl from a village. Somebody's sleeve had brushed the dial since Thursday, and it had come to rest, as if Mrs. Hajek had arranged it, on the polka station.

Polka is good for glue. It was not good for this, and I turned it off.

The fifth was muddy, and the sixth was cold again. The seventh blue was nearly right. He knew it before I said so, because he stopped and looked at it and then at the July window and then back, as I had shown him in November, and waited for me to say it.

He wiped the brush, and I said, "Again. Less black."

The eighth was the blue.

• • •

At ten past eleven I brought the lamp in low and put the headband on him.

"Tell me where the edge is."

He bent to it, and it took him a while, and I let it.

"It starts at the crack that comes up from the hem," he said. "On the left it's the dark line between two of the little plates. On the right the edge isn't a crack. It's a step. You can see the old paint stand up a hair."

"Where at the bottom?"

"The edge of the canvas. It runs right off the bottom."

"And the top?"

"There's a plate sticking into it, at the top. That one's original. That one stays."

"Then that's where you stop."

He loaded the brush, and his hand was steady, and then at the canvas it wasn't, a small shake, the second I had seen in his hands in eight years and both of them that week, and he lifted it away without touching and held it in the air.

I put my left hand around his wrist.

My left hand can't steer anything that fine, and I didn't try. I closed my fingers around the wrist bone of his brush hand, the left, the one that never wears the watch, and held on, and his pulse came up under my thumb, hard and quick, and slowed.

"Tell me where the edge is," I said again.

"The crack on the left. The step on the right. The canvas edge. The plate at the top."

"Inside that."

He laid the first dot inside it. Then another beside it, not touching, the brush barely kissing the varnish. I had my head down by his hands and my hand on his wrist, and the room was so quiet the hairs of the brush made a sound.

It took him fifty minutes to fill half an inch.

When it was done I let go of him. From where I stood the corner was blue to its edges and the loss had gone into it.

I turned off the room and switched on the UV lamp.

The green came up all over the mantle. In the bottom corner, small and exact, his dots sat on the glow as dark as a bruise, every one of them.

I held the light on it long enough for both of us to see it properly. Then I turned the lights back on and wrote the entry, and he initialed it.

He did not tell me it was fine. I waited for it. It didn't come.

Chapter 20 — Declan

Okay. So. One: Ray at eight, and yes, Atlanta, for a year. Two: the painting goes back to the church on the twenty-fourth, and on the fourth he's gone, and she has the house and the studio and her name, and nobody underfoot to take anything off her plate. Three: in a year, if she wants

Three didn't finish. He was in the lot at 7:44 and it still hadn't.

He had slept from one to four. At four he had got up and stood in the kitchen with the light off and looked at the coffee machine with the steam wand he had never used, and he had built the plan there, one line at a time, the way he built a re-route when a building went down. It was a good plan.

He did not say it to the windshield. He had said the last two to the windshield and they'd come out the same both times.

. . .

Ray's door was open, and the jelly was gone from the desk. The blue folder lay on the blotter instead, waiting.

"Dec," Ray said, coming around the desk with his whole body. "Tell me you're here to make me happy. Tell me it's early because you're decisive, not because you're dying."

"I'm here about the folder."

"Good man. Sit," Ray said, and sat on the edge of the desk himself. He only did that when he was pleased. "First, the home front. Joan had your sister-in-law in our kitchen Thursday. Two hours. I went to the garage and pretended to fix the snowblower. When I came back in, Cora was gone and Joan was baking. Four dozen. She won't tell me one word of it, so it went fine."

"I didn't know," Declan said.

"Nobody tells anybody anything in this family, apparently," Ray said. For a second the party went out of his face. "I'm not over it, Dec. You let my wife cry over a woman who wasn't there. I'm going to be not over that for a while." Then he tapped the folder. "But she's baking. So as far as this office goes, clean slate. And something I didn't say two weeks ago, because you looked like hell. Atlanta's good for this. Fresh building, fresh people. Nobody down there knows a thing about any of it. Nobody's going to look at Maud across a table and wonder. You walk in on the fourth, it's like the fall never happened."

Declan held still in the chair.

Yesterday, a little after noon, she had turned off the room and switched on the UV lamp, and the whole mantle had come up that sick pond green, and in the bottom corner his dots had sat on the glow, dark, every one of them. She had held the light on it a long time. She had wanted him to see it properly. *Every time anybody puts a lamp on it, she'd said, for as long as there's a painting.*

He had driven home at one in the afternoon with the plan already starting: a place where nobody put a lamp on it.

"Bring her down," Ray was saying. "They've got museums. The High. We'll find her something."

"Ray," Declan said, before the High could get any bigger.

"I've got a guy on the board at the High, I think, or Joan does—"

"I'm not taking it."

Ray stopped with one hand still in the air.

"You're not what?"

"I'm not taking the job. Atlanta. I'm turning it down."

Ray stood up off the desk. He did not go around it. He stood there in his shirtsleeves with the river behind him in the window, flat and gray, and looked at Declan as if Declan had walked in speaking Portuguese.

"For what?"

"Evenings."

"Evenings," Ray said, slowly, tasting it. "You're turning down Senior Vice President of Network Operations for this company, which I took to my board, which my board approved, for evenings."

"Six to ten. Eight to six on Saturdays."

"Doing what?"

"Holding a swab."

"A swab," Ray said, and his face had started going red at the neck and climbed. "Eleven years, Dec. You drew this job on the back of a shift sheet in Allentown, you told me that yourself at the Christmas party, you were drunk, you drew a little box. I have been building you for that box since before you were married. Mitch walks out the door in January. Do you know what \$140,000 is?"

"Yes."

"Don't you do that. Don't give me one word." Ray leaned both palms on the desk. "Is this her? Did she ask you to stay?"

"She doesn't know."

"She doesn't know," Ray repeated.

"I haven't told her about the offer."

"You haven't told your wife you got the biggest job in the company," Ray said, straightening. "Why the hell not?"

"She didn't ask."

"So tell her! That's what people do, Dec, they come home and they say, honey, you won't believe it—"

"She stopped asking me for things in the spring," Declan said, and looked at the blue folder. "I'm not going to make her start with this."

Ray stared at him before he said, "That's the stupidest thing I've ever heard."

"Probably."

"Get out of my office." Ray sat down in his own chair, hard, and pulled the folder toward himself and didn't open it. "Go on. I need to call Mitch and tell him to buy a longer boat."

“And send HR something in writing,” Ray said to the folder, as Declan stood.
“Don’t make me do it.”

• • •

He walked past the network map without stopping. Nadine was at her desk outside his office with her glasses pushed up into her hair and a call on mute. Ray’s door was glass, and Ray’s voice had never in his life stopped at a door.

She did not look away from her screen.

“Your five-twenty’s still clear,” she said.

He went in and shut his door, and opened his email, and scrolled down past six days of building traffic to the one with the lock icon he had not opened. *Reminder: response to offer requested by 12/18.*

He opened it and hit reply.

I decline the offer, with thanks. D. Hale.

At 9:04 he read it twice, looking for a word that would make it a maybe, and there wasn’t one, and he sent it.

Joan’s text was still on his phone, two weeks old. *Whose hand was it, Declan?* He did not answer it. Ray had said not to, and that held. But he read it, and this time he did not turn the phone over afterward.

The rest of the day was doors. Carlisle got its new leveler on fourteen at 11:20 and Russ Kopp called to tell him, sounding ten years younger, and Declan said good, and meant it, and did not tell Russ anything else. He didn’t tell Lou, and he didn’t call his mother. At 5:20 he put on his coat and Nadine said nothing, and he walked out past the coordinators’ desks and nobody turned in their chairs.

• • •

He knocked at six, and she said, “It’s open.”

He put the phone in the bowl and the watch beside it, and then the key on its paper tag, PAPPAS 3, on the shelf next to the bowl.

“You said bring it Monday.”

She was at the bench with the headband up on her forehead. She glanced at the key and back at the notebook.

“Wash your hands,” she said, to the notebook.

They did the knee: gel, sixty seconds on her count with the white timer behind it in case, then clear, rinse, again. She did not talk except to count, and he did not talk at all. The hinged sheet of graph paper was in the book now, and when she turned the pages to dictate he could see its edge stand up a little proud of the others, the way a patch stands up on a road.

Twice he thought about saying it. Once at eight, when she had him stop to rest his hand and he sat on the floor against the bench leg and opened and closed his fingers. Once at ten to ten, wiping the brush.

Both times he looked at the key on the shelf and opened his mouth, and both times he closed it and reached for the next swab.

"Ten," she said, at ten.

He took his watch and phone out of the bowl. The key was still on the shelf where he'd put it.

She didn't look up from the book.

"You lock up," she said, still writing.

He picked up the key.

• • •

He got home at 10:41. The blue bowl in the hall had two keys in it, her square brass one and the yellow daisy, and he put the studio key in beside them, and then took it out again and put it on his own ring, because that was where it went.

He did not set two alarms. He set none, and lay down at eleven, and the radiator in the hall knocked twice and stopped.

He woke at 6:10, seven hours later, with the light already gray at the edge of the blind, and lay there for a minute, not trusting it.

• • •

At 7:15 on Tuesday Ray was standing in his office doorway with two coffees.

He held one out, and Declan took it.

"You look like you slept," Ray said. "I hate that."

"I did," Declan said, and took the lid off the coffee.

"Joan says I'm supposed to tell you I'm proud of you." Ray drank some of his coffee and made a face at it. "I'm not. I'm working on it. Mitch is buying the boat anyway."

"Take your time," Declan said, and drank.

Ray stayed where he was a while longer, considering him with his head on one side, as he considered a building whose numbers wouldn't come out.

"She better be worth it," he said.

"That's not how it works."

Chapter 21 — Maud

“Sorry,” somebody said to the freight elevator, and drew the gate across so slowly that I knew two things before I turned around: that someone downstairs had warned her about the gate, and that she had apologized to it anyway.

It was twenty past three on Wednesday, when the north windows go from white to the gray of a primed board and nobody comes up, and my sister was standing just inside the studio door in her own coat with a manila envelope held flat against her chest in both arms.

“Mr. Pappas let me in,” she said. “He said don’t slam it, so I didn’t, I was so careful, honestly, I think I closed it slower than anybody has ever closed anything, and then I said sorry to it, I heard myself do it. I’m not staying, is it a work day? It’s Wednesday, of course it’s a work day, I didn’t think, I’ll be ten minutes, Maudie, I promise, I won’t even take my coat off.”

“That’s the shop coat,” I said.

“The navy one, yes, I found it at Mom’s in the cedar closet. I bought it the first winter, when I still drove the van to the flower market at four in the morning, remember, you said I looked like a ferry captain.” She pulled at a cuff, where six years of florist’s wire had furred the wool. “It’s the only coat I have that’s really mine. I left the black one at Mom’s, it smells like her car.”

“You’ve got needles in your toggles.”

“Oh, God, balsam, it gets everywhere, I’m doing wreaths. There’s a garden center on West Chester Pike that takes people on for December, \$14 an hour, and you go home looking like you lost a fight with a cat.” She turned her hands over, and the backs were scratched in fine red lines across every knuckle. “I’m fast at it, the owner says I’ve got a florist’s wrist, which I do, I mean I did, I had a whole shop of—”

She caught the bright voice she uses on customers and stopped it in the middle.

“Where are you sleeping?”

“Mom’s spare room, the one with the chenille bedspread, you remember, it still has the bald patch where you spilled the nail polish remover in 2003.” Her eyes had gone to the camel coat, which I had on over my apron because the radiators knock all afternoon and never reach the window end of the room. “It’s gone out at the shoulders. I carry things in front, Mom always says I walk like I’m holding a tray. If you put it on a wide hanger for a week it’ll come back, wool comes back if you just let it—” She shut her mouth. “Sorry.”

“Why are you here, Cora?”

“Yesterday was the eighth.”

She held the envelope out across the bench, not too far and not too fast, as you hand a dish to someone in a hospital bed.

“You said by the eighth, and you said don’t reply to you, and this isn’t a reply, I didn’t put one word to you in it, I swear I didn’t. It’s only so you’d know it was

done. You said not through Declan, and I couldn't think how else you'd ever know."

• • •

I tipped it out on the bench left-handed: eleven sheets of lined paper in her round marker capitals, one to a name, and a sealed white envelope with mine on it.

"That one's a letter," she said. "Don't read it while I'm here. You don't have to read it ever, if you don't want to. It's six pages, it's fourteen hundred words, I counted, I don't know why I counted."

I put it to one side and read the top sheet out.

"Mrs. Kessler, November twenty-fourth, letter, four pages, both sides."

"She wrote back on an index card, it's clipped there, behind."

"I read it twice, and that's all you get."

"That's fair, that's more than fair, she made me a ziti in October."

"Mr. Abruzzo, at his house."

"He wouldn't open the screen door. I stood on his step and said all of it through the screen, and he listened all the way to the end, and then he said, 'The girl's joke was better when the girl told it,' and shut the inside door." She said it without the little laugh she puts after everything. "He's right, I told it too fast."

"The Dunns."

"Mrs. Dunn said, 'We liked you, that's the worst part,' and the boy wouldn't come down from upstairs. Odalys you know about. Ellen Szabo said she'd wondered all fall why you'd stopped arguing with her about the frame, and now she knew. Mrs. Tsang asked me whether you were still doing their grandfather's portrait in March, and I said I couldn't answer for you." Her hands had gone into her pockets. "That's the first thing I've said to anybody since September that I was sure was true."

"Joan Teague, December third, in her kitchen."

"Two hours, and she made coffee and didn't drink it. I told her everything, the first Friday, the wine, the brace, all of it, how I sat at that table in September and let her tell me about her mother's hip for an hour and nodded like I knew what a hip was. At the end she asked for my hand. My right one, the one I wore the brace on. She held it on the table and looked at it for a long time, and she said, 'So that's whose.' Then she got the flour out, and I let myself out."

"There's an email from Ray behind it. 'Got it, Joan's the one who cried, Ray Teague.'"

"He's right too."

"Walter Wozniak."

"I went to his house, in Port Richmond, by the river. He stood up when I came in, and he stood up again when I left, and he gave me tea in a cup with a saucer, and the whole time I was talking he kept his hat on his knee with his hand flat on the crown, like he might need it, and he didn't, it was his own front room. He didn't say a word. Two days later that came in the mail."

It was on his own notepaper, cream, blotted.

“Miss Alder. I thank you for coming to my house in person. It is more than the roofing man did in 2011. What you told me will stay in my front room. Walter Wozniak.”

“I don’t know who the roofing man is.”

“Somebody who didn’t come in person,” I said. “Nadine Okoro, by email: ‘Thank you for telling me, I don’t have children, Nadine Okoro.’”

“I asked her about her kids in October, by the coats, when she came to dinner, and she said they were fine. She said they were fine, Maud, to my face.”

“Frances Tilley,” I read. “December second, letter by mail, Swarthmore.” Under her paragraph the blue lines ran empty to the bottom of the page. “And nothing.”

“Nothing,” Cora said.

“What did you tell her?”

“That it was me, every word, from your phone, at midnight. That you’ve never written honestly in your life, because you think it’s a word liars use, I got that one from you years ago. She didn’t answer.”

“That’s ten out of eleven,” I said. “She hasn’t answered me either. I sent her the week’s pages yesterday.”

“And Pat Varga, who isn’t on your list, Declan told Mr. Varga at work that I’d tell her myself, so I did, and I mailed her the putty back. It was still in its box. She sent it to you for your hand, for the therapy, and I never even opened it.”

“Ten of mine, and one that wasn’t mine.”

“Yes. And Frances is the one that didn’t.”

• • •

She took her phone out of her coat. It was in a pink case cracked across one corner, almost exactly where mine is cracked, and she put in the code and held it out over the bench with the screen lit.

“Read it,” she said. “All of it. Mother’s too.”

“Mother,” I said, without taking it. “You’ve called her Mom since you could talk.”

“It’s your word. I’ve been using it in my head since Sunday, because I couldn’t stand to use mine.” She kept holding out the phone. “It’s under Mom, go back to September.”

I took it from her then. My left thumb is slow on glass, and she stood and let it be slow.

“September eleventh, eleven fifty-eight at night, you. ‘Mom are you up, a woman at Declan’s called me Maud tonight and I didn’t say anything and neither did he, I don’t know what I’m doing, call me tomorrow?’”

Cora didn’t move from the end of the bench.

“September twelfth, eight fourteen in the morning.” I read it slowly, in my own voice, every word given its weight, as Frances reads back a condition report so you

will hear exactly what you wrote. ““Good morning, dear. Did you get any sleep? Don’t make it into a scene. He needs someone easy while she’s laid up. Wives who are present are wives who are kept. Don’t let her take it back the minute she’s on her feet.”” I scrolled the last line up into the light. “And she signed it.”

A train crossed on the El, and the tap dripped into the sink.

“She signs all her texts like a letter,” Cora said. “She thinks it’s rude not to.”

“She told me in her own dining room that she can’t find the button.”

“She can find it,” Cora said.

“Did she ever ask how I was?”

“Once, in October, she asked if you were sleeping.” Cora’s eyes stayed on the phone in my hand. “Then she asked what Joan wore.”

“September eighteenth, the lamb with rosemary, Joan in green, and Mother says, ‘Lovely.’ October second, salmon with the dill sauce, ten at the table, and Mother says, ‘Good girl. Now sit down and eat something yourself.’ October ninth, ‘Did he eat?’”

“He always ate, I’d tell her what he had seconds of.”

“October sixth, a Tuesday, her bridge night, ten fifty-eight p.m., you again, a long one. ‘Frances, I think I need to stop for a while. I’m so tired, honestly, and I don’t think I want it anymore. Could you not send me articles for a bit? Sorry to be like this. Maud.’ And under it, ‘Mom does this sound ok?’”

“I sent it when she got home from cards.”

“Eleven twenty, Mother.” My voice stayed where I had put it. ““Make it sound like her. Sharper. Maudie has never said sorry to that woman in her life. Then go to bed, it’s late.’ Eleven thirty-one, you, a second version. Eleven forty, Mother, one word, ‘Better.’ And at eleven fifty-two it went to Swarthmore with my name on it.”

“Yes.”

“October twenty-fifth: ‘Tell her friends she needs a real break, dear, because she does.’”

Under that, at the bottom of the thread, I typed with my left thumb: *I’ve read all of it, back to September. Maud.* I signed it because she thinks it’s rude not to, and sent it, and Cora watched it go.

My right hand had started in the brace. When I turned it over to set the phone down, something at the far end of the plate gave a small dry click.

“Your hand,” Cora said. “It clicked, I heard it click.”

“It’s been clicking since Monday.”

“Have you told anyone?”

“I’ve told you,” I said, and laid the phone on the bench beside the envelope and sat down on the end of the cot, because the cot was there. “You can sit down.”

“No,” she said. “I’ll stand.”

One word, and a period after it, and nothing coming along behind to make it softer. My sister has said a great many things to me in thirty-five years, sorry ten thousand times, and honestly, and you know, and let me get you something, and she had never once said that word by itself and left it lying there.

She stood leaning on nothing, as still as she was at six with Mother's cut-glass dish in pieces on the linoleum, in the second before she went for the broom.

I said, "Who put in managing?"

"Me." Her voice had gone low and flat, all the music out of it. "Mom said sharper, so I took out tired and I took out sorry, and I put in managing. You told me about the articles two Christmases ago, in Mom's kitchen, drying the roasting pan. You said she still manages you like you're twenty-four and you'll never tell her. I knew where it would go. I put it there on purpose."

"And ceiling."

"That was me too, I didn't know it was wrong. I thought a ceiling was a ceiling."

"Why, Cora?"

She took a long time over it, long enough for the light to go off the windows and leave the work lamp the brightest thing in the room.

"Because I wanted to stay," she said. "That's the true thing, and you can ask me anything you want and that's the answer under all of it. It wasn't him. I never wanted him like that, not once, not for one minute, you could put me under oath in front of a judge. It was the house. I'd get up and make coffee in your machine and nobody needed it to be good. I'd cook on Fridays and they'd say, Maud, this is wonderful, and I'd say thank you, and nobody asked me what I did for a living, or why the shop closed, or when I was going to pay anybody back. One afternoon in October I was standing in your kitchen at four o'clock with the dishwasher going, and I thought, this is the happiest I've been since the shop, and I wasn't even ashamed of it. He said thank you the way you'd say it to the man who brings the mail, and I loved it, I loved that nobody looked at my face long enough to see anything. He'd come home and go up and lock his study, and I'd go up to the third floor and turn on my fan, and nobody in that whole house wanted one single thing from me. He never asked me for anything. I didn't know you could live in a house like that. I wanted to be that easy forever."

The lamp hummed over the painting.

"And the email was so I could," she said. "If you were done with paintings, you'd stay in Italy longer. Or you'd come home tired and quiet and need help, and I'd be the help, in your house, for as long as you needed it. That's what I thought, at eleven at night, with Mom texting me *Better*. There isn't a nicer reason underneath it. I looked for one on the train."

She had my face with nothing through the eyebrow, scratched across the knuckles by fir, and she had told it as if she were reading it off a wall.

"That's not being loved," I said. "That's being unused."

"I know," Cora said.

• • •

I stood up, in the two moves it takes me now, and she kept her hands at her sides.

"Then here it is," I said. "I'm only going to say it once, and you're going to stand there and hear all of it, because you've earned the whole thing and not a summary. The money stopped on the first, and it stays stopped, and you know that already. You don't call me. You don't text me or write to me, and you don't send anything through Mother, or Declan, or Odalys, or Mr. Pappas at the street door, and you don't come into the church on the twenty-fourth. Not until March. You took my name to every person who was fond of it, and some of them are going to give it back to me and some of them never will, and Frances may be one of the ones who never will, and there is nothing on that list that fixes it, and nothing I can do fixes it either. You sent \$11,400 back to a parish that kept my painting under Tyvek in a bingo hall, with my name on the transfer, and Walter Wozniak sat in his front room in October and read that I'd quit for my health. Frances printed my resignation and put it in a folder with my first condition report. Those are things that happened to other people, Cora, in my name, and they don't come undone because you went and stood on their steps. I'm not going to forgive you by Christmas because it's Christmas. I don't know if I'm going to forgive you at all, and I won't pretend I have so that the next three months are easier for anybody, including me."

Under the bench her foot found its leg and pressed flat against it. She has done that under Mother's table since we were six, to keep from crying in front of company.

"In March you can come here. Here, to this room, on a working day. You'll come up in that elevator and close the gate the way you closed it today, and sit on that stool by the door, and watch what I do for as long as I'm doing it, the slow part and the boring part, all of it, because you were me for nine weeks, Cora, and you have never once seen what that is. That's what you can have. Bring nothing. No flowers and no soup, and no list. Nothing in your hands."

She took it, every word, with her foot flat against the bench leg, and didn't look away from me once.

"All right," she said.

"Tell Mother whatever you like. She'll know from your face."

"She knows already, I showed her the list on Sunday, she said I was being dramatic." Cora took her hands out of her pockets. "I'm going to Frances tomorrow, in person, I looked up the train from Suburban."

"What will you say to her?"

"What I just said to you, all of it. The house part too, if she asks."

"She doesn't believe people who cry."

"Then I won't," my sister said.

"I'll read it when I read it," I said, of the letter.

"All right, that's all right, that's more than all right." She picked up her phone and put it away, and left the envelope and the letter with my name on it where they lay on the bench. At the door she stopped with her hand on the gate and turned around.

"I'm sorry," she said.

Nothing came after it, no *honestly* and no *I just thought*. Two words and a period, said to my face in a flat voice in a cold room, and then she waited, as I wait for a swab to come back, to see what it would show.

“I heard it,” I said.

She nodded once and drew the gate across, slowly, until it clicked, and the cage went down.

• • •

When the street door had gone I took the camel coat off and held it up by the collar. She was right about the shoulders: the wool had gone forward at the front of each one, where nine weeks of carrying things before her had pushed it, and three weeks on my back had not brought it home.

I hung it on its nail by the cot.

It hung there with its shoulders still rounded toward the room, holding a tray that wasn't mine.

Chapter 22 — Declan

Okay. So. One: stand where she puts him. Two: say nothing. Three: if anybody asks him anything, the answer is Maud.

At 1:41 the elevator motor kicked in two floors down, nineteen minutes early, and the plan had nothing in it for the Monsignor.

He had been there since one. Nadine had taken his afternoon without asking why, and he had sat in the car on Frankford Avenue from 12:52 until one because Maud had said one, not ten to. She said four sentences to him before he had his coat off.

“Cora came on Wednesday. She’s done ten of the eleven. Frances didn’t answer her. My mother told her to make the email sharper.”

He stood with one arm out of the coat.

“Your mother.”

“In a text, October sixth, eleven twenty at night. Cora showed me on her phone. She signed it Love, Mother.”

He hung the coat on the hook and put the phone in the bowl, the watch beside it. On the shelf over the bowl there was a sealed white envelope he had not seen before, with MAUD on it in a round marker hand he knew from the boxes on Brown Street.

“Does it change anything for today?”

“No. It’s Friday.”

“Do you want me to say anything to them? If they ask about the hours, or the corner—”

“I want you to stand by the sink. If they ask you anything, you send it to me, and I’ll answer it, all of it, the corner too.” She turned her right hand over on the bench to straighten the nine typed pages in their sleeve, and stopped halfway, and turned it back with her left. “Gloves on, hands empty. When I say wash your hands, you wash your hands. Nobody’s going to ask you anything they can ask me.”

“Is it the plate?”

“It’s the cold.”

She pulled the brace strap one hole tighter with her teeth.

• • •

Walter came out of the cage first, in a tie and his good overcoat, holding his hat in both hands. Father Tomasz came behind him in a Phillies fleece over his clerical shirt, with a cardboard tray of four Wawa coffees.

“The Monsignor is taking the stairs,” Walter said. “He was in an elevator in Rome in 1991. He didn’t elaborate, and I didn’t ask.”

“Four coffees,” Father Tomasz said. “One’s for the assistant.”

“Corridor,” said Maud.

"Nobody sits for me, and now nobody drinks with me." He set the tray down outside the door, on the boards, and straightened. "It's the collar."

The Monsignor arrived as a sound first: two flights, an even step, no pause on the landing. He came through the door unhurried and not out of breath, a narrow man in a black overcoat and a gray scarf, rimless glasses, his gloves held together in one hand. He looked at the north windows first and then at the tilted table with the painting on it. The phone bowl came next, a phone and a steel watch lying in it together, and then, briefly, Declan at the sink.

"Ms. Alder."

"Monsignor."

"Your elevator has a reputation."

"It's earned it," Maud said.

"Walter tells me he and it have come to terms."

"We have reached an understanding," Walter said. "I don't touch the lever, and it doesn't kill me."

The Monsignor looked at the bowl again. "Whose are those?"

"The assistant's, he leaves them at the door."

"The telephone as well?"

"Every shift."

"I should try that in the confessional," said Father Tomasz.

There were no chairs to offer, and she offered none. She brought the raking lamp down low along the hem without preamble, and the three of them stood where she put them, a yard back from the table, where he had stood on the eighteenth of November with a swab in his hand and no idea what he was looking at.

"The lower edge," she said. "Ninety-one areas of lifting paint, laid down and documented. The varnish is off the lower half, all but one strip. That's the original blue of the mantle. Those are the shepherds' boots. That one has a hole in the sole, and it's been there since 1886, and it stays."

Walter bent from the waist with his hat at his chest. Father Tomasz said something under his breath that might have been a prayer and might have been a word they don't teach in seminary.

The Monsignor took off his glasses and leaned in close to the blue. He touched nothing, and held his gloves behind his back in one hand, as people do in a museum after they have been told once.

"How do you know it's the original?"

"The cracks," Maud said. "A painting cracks as it ages, through every layer at once, top to bottom. Anything put on later sits over the cracks or fills them in. Bring your eye down. That blue cracks straight through to the ground, and nothing's in the cracks but dirt, and the dirt's gone."

He brought his eye down and stayed there a while.

"And the face?"

"The face is still his." She moved the lamp up. "That's Leon Wrobel's face from 1957. There's a test site here on the jaw, three millimeters, where you can see what's under it."

"Half my parishioners think that's the Virgin," Father Tomasz said.

"The other half think it's Helen Wrobel," said Walter.

"Underneath it's neither," Maud said. "Underneath it's what a workshop in Munich painted in 1886. It comes off last. It always comes off last."

The Monsignor straightened and put his glasses back on.

• • •

Declan stood by the sink with his gloved hands empty at his sides. The tap dripped into the basin every four seconds, and he had counted forty-one drips since the Monsignor came in.

All morning he had been totaling it out of habit, sixteen weeknights at four hours, two Saturdays at ten, Thanksgiving, a Sunday, and the Saturday that ran past midnight, and he had the number to the hour without meaning to.

Walter turned toward him, the hat held at his belt.

"Mr. Hale, if I may. How many hours has this taken, all told?"

Three heads turned to the sink.

He knew it to the hour.

"Ask Maud," Declan said.

Walter's eyebrows went up a quarter inch and came down, and he looked across the table.

"A hundred and nineteen," Maud said, "through last night. It's in the book."

"Thank you, Mr. Hale," said Walter, gravely, for nothing at all.

The Monsignor had not taken his eyes off the sink.

"And the assistant?" he said.

Maud did not look around from setting the lamp back on its arm.

"My husband," she said. "Under my supervision. Documented."

His chest went tight and stayed tight. He had put his hands in his coat pockets three times in eight years, twice at funerals and once in this room, and they wanted to go now, and he had no coat on and no pockets in the apron. He put his right hand on the edge of the sink instead and held it.

My husband, in this room, with these men in it, in the same voice she used for ninety-one areas of lifting paint, as if it were a fact she had checked under the lamp.

"Your husband," the Monsignor said.

"Yes."

He turned his head to the sink. "And what do you do, Mr. Hale, when you're not here?"

"Freight and warehousing."

"And when you're here?"

"What I'm told."

"Bernadette says he sits very still," said Father Tomasz.

“At length,” said Walter.

“Irregular,” the Monsignor said, to Maud.

“Your secretary’s said so, three times, I’m told.”

“She’s thorough.” He turned to the bench. “And the documentation.”

Maud laid the notebook on the bench under the lamp, closed.

It was fat now with paste and diagrams and three weeks of his capitals, and from the sink he could see the one sheet that stood a sixteenth of an inch proud along the fore-edge, where she had hinged it in on a Sunday morning. You had to know it was there.

The Monsignor laid his gloved hand on the cover and left it there.

Declan kept his eyes on the hand while the tap dripped, forty-six, forty-seven.

“I’m told this is everything,” the Monsignor said.

“Every shift, every area, every swab that came up a color I didn’t expect.”

“I won’t pretend to read it, Ms. Alder. I couldn’t tell a good page from a bad one. That’s what Ms. Tilley is for.” He lifted his hand off the book. “Walter, you’re welcome to it.”

“I’d only get my fingerprints on it,” Walter said.

The hand was off the cover. Declan let go of the sink.

• • •

“I’d like to see him work,” the Monsignor said.

“Wash your hands,” said Maud.

He stripped the gloves and washed, warm, and put on a fresh pair, and came to where she pointed: the last strip of the lower edge on the left, a band two inches long under the shepherd’s heel where the varnish was still brown.

She gave him the gel and the brush. He had stood up in front of boards and in front of forty union stewards in Allentown the night the power went, and nobody in any of those rooms had watched his hands.

“Thin,” she said, “and inside the tape.”

He laid it thin.

“Sixty seconds.” She started the white timer on the bench, and counted under it, out loud, as she always did, in the voice she used for nobody but the painting. “Ten, twenty.”

Father Tomasz said, very low, “I can’t watch. It’s like the eighth inning.”

“Father,” said the Monsignor.

“Forty, fifty. Clear.”

Declan cleared: one roll toward himself with the damp swab, and lift. The cotton came up amber, and he put it in the can without looking at anybody.

“Rinse.”

He rinsed, and the brown was gone, and under it the blue of the hem ran into the shepherd’s heel, and the heel had a crack across it the shape of a lightning bolt, and the crack stayed where it was.

“That’s the lower half,” Maud said.

Nobody said anything, and Walter had his hat against his chest again.

"Seven minutes past two," Maud said to Declan, and opened the book to a clean page, the other end from the hinge. "Varnish removal, final area, lower edge, left. Solvent gel, one application of sixty seconds, cleared, then rinsed. Operator D. Hale, under direct supervision of M. Alder, conservator, present throughout. Observed by Monsignor Aurelio Pellegrino, Father Tomasz Kowal, and Walter Wozniak."

He wrote it in the dock capitals, slowly, every name spelled the way she said it, and initialed the margin. The Monsignor stood at his shoulder and watched the pencil the whole way and did not turn a page.

• • •

They stood at the table while the Monsignor gave it to them, his gloves still in his hand.

"Here's where the Commission is," he said. "Ms. Tilley's certification, on paper, signed, after a final inspection in this room on the twenty-third. If I have that by midnight on the twenty-third, the painting goes up on the twenty-fourth as she is. If I don't, she goes up with Mr. Wrobel's face on her, and we'll talk about it again in the spring, when everyone's calmer."

"The twenty-third," Maud said.

"That's an extension, Ms. Alder. The Commission wanted a signature on Monday."

"The face is twelve days of work if nothing goes wrong."

"Then nothing had better go wrong."

"And if she signs at eleven o'clock at night on the twenty-third?"

"Then I'll be awake," the Monsignor said. "I'm always awake on the twenty-third. It's the busiest night of my year that nobody sees."

"The committee will come on the twenty-third, Ms. Alder," Walter said, "if you'll have us."

"Not in the room. Frances doesn't work with an audience."

"Then we'll wait on the stairs. We're a parish. We're good at waiting on stairs."

Walter came around the table while Father Tomasz was retrieving his coffees, and stopped beside Maud with his back to the room. He spoke low, and Declan heard it anyway.

"Your sister came to my house last week, Ms. Alder, and sat in my front room." He turned his hat once in his hands. "It stays there."

"Thank you, Walter."

"I don't ask what isn't my business. I'd take it as a kindness if you'd tell Bernadette nothing. She'll find out by Easter. She always does."

At the cage Father Tomasz handed Declan a coffee through the gate, warm in its paper cup. "For the assistant," he said. "Drink it in the corridor, I'm not getting you in trouble."

The Monsignor stood on the landing with one hand on the stair rail, declining the elevator again. He looked back through the open door at Maud by the table, and at the face that was still a sign painter's wife.

"I'll be frank with you," he said. "I've given you nine more days than I wanted to. Midnight Mass doesn't wait on anyone's feelings, Mrs. Hale."

"Alder," she said.

Chapter 23 — Maud

Frances Tilley telephoned at ten past eight on Sunday morning, from the wall phone with the curling cord, and did not say hello.

“Your sister came on Thursday.”

“I know. She told me she would.”

“She sat in my kitchen in a navy coat with pine needles in it and told me she wrote it. Every word, from your telephone, at midnight, ceiling and honestly and all of it.” The cord creaked at her end as she shifted the hip. “And then she cried, prettily, with her hands in her lap and her face perfectly still, and the tears just coming down it, like a window with the rain on it. Bartholomew sat on her feet. He has no judgment.”

“She told me she wouldn’t.”

“They always tell you that, Alder.”

I was on the end of the cot with my right arm held against my ribs, where it had been since three o’clock the afternoon before.

“I read your pages,” Frances said. “The ones the Fuentes girl brought out on Tuesday at seven in the morning, as if I were a dairy. All of them, including the one on the hinge.”

I had sent the week’s pages with Odalys on Tuesday, photocopied at the museum, the graph-paper sheet hinged among them in its place after the knee, with the photographs of the corner before and after, under raking light and under the UV lamp. Nobody had asked me to send them.

“You didn’t call,” I said.

“I’m calling now,” she said, and let that sit. “I’ve read a great many treatment logs in fifty-one years. I’ve caught people in them. I’ve caught a man in Baltimore who rewrote a whole week in a different pen and thought I wouldn’t see the pressure change. A liar doesn’t hinge a page like that into the book. A liar takes it out, or never writes it in the first place. In his capitals, *conservator not present, asleep, not told*, and your entry underneath.”

“Yes.”

“That’s the only reason I’m coming. Don’t mistake it for anything else.”

“I won’t.”

“I can’t tell which of you is lying to me about October. Your sister cries and says it was her. You don’t cry and say it was her. Two women with one face telling me one story isn’t proof, Alder. It’s exactly what you’d both say if it was you at midnight and you wanted your job back. Your husband’s capitals say he took a glaze off a mantle while you slept. I’m seventy-two and I’m too old to decide it by the twenty-third, so I won’t decide it. I’ll look at paint. I’ll come at ten. Show me the face, or there is no re-dedication. That’s all I’m signing on.”

“Ten at night.”

"I don't drive at night anymore. The Fuentes girl will drive me, and the dog will come, and you'll have a chair for me that isn't a stool. How's the hand?"

"They took a picture of it last night. I'll know this morning."

"Hm," she said, and the pause after it was longer. "Then you'll know what I already know. It's his hands, either way."

She hung up, as she always has, without goodbye.

• • •

The hand surgeon at Jefferson phoned at 9:35 from what sounded like her car, with a child asking for something in the back seat and being told to wait.

"Ms. Alder, it's Esther Kaplan. I've looked at your films from last night."

"Yes."

"One of the distal screws has backed out. The one nearest the joint. About a millimeter and a half. The plate is still holding the bone, and the bone has healed well under it, so nobody panic." The child said something, and she said "In a minute, Noah," and came back. "But I don't want that screw going anywhere else, and the way it goes anywhere else is load and repetition. So, no fine work, nothing that loads the wrist, and nothing you'd describe to me as careful, until I see you on January sixth."

"Define fine work."

"Anything you'd use a loupe for."

"That's everything I do."

"Then do nothing until January sixth." Her voice was kind and entirely flat, the voice I use on people who want me to promise a painting will look new. "If it backs out further, I go back in, and then you lose eight weeks instead of three, and possibly more than weeks. Is that clear?"

"Yes."

"Somebody else's hands for a month, Ms. Alder. Does somebody else have hands?"

I looked down the room at the table, tilted, and the face on it with Leon Wrobel's pink still on her.

"Yes," I said.

"Good. Ice it, and keep the brace on, and I'll see you on January sixth."

• • •

Odalys rang at ten to ten, because she had sat with me in the emergency department until midnight and had been waiting since seven for me to tell her.

"Well?"

"A screw backed out. Nothing fine until the sixth."

"Damn," she said, and breathed out. "Right, so he does it. He's done the whole bottom half, Alder, you said he did the heel on Friday in front of a monsignor and

didn't shake. He does the face on your voice. You stand there and count and he does it. That's what the terms were for."

"I know what the terms were for."

"Then what's the problem?"

I didn't answer, and she waited me out.

"Alder."

"Frances called. She read the hinged page. She's coming on the twenty-third, at ten at night, and you're driving her and the dog."

"I know I'm driving her, she rang me at half past seven, in that voice, like I'd applied for it. That's not what I asked you. I asked you what the problem is."

"I'll call you tonight."

"You won't, you'll sit on that cot and decide something by yourself, and I'll hear about it on the twenty-second from Hamid. And don't do anything stupid with your good hand either."

"I don't have a good hand. I have a left one."

"That's what I meant," Odalys said, and hung up.

. . .

At eleven I took the lighthouse off the back of the door.

It is a thrift-store seascape, about 1974, a white tower on a brown rock with a sea painted in commas, and I keep it for exactly this, for testing a hand on something nobody will ever mourn. I clamped it to the end of the bench and rolled a swab left-handed and dipped it in plain water, nothing that could hurt it, and laid it on the sea and rolled it once toward me and lifted it, and did it again, and again, counting.

At twenty-two seconds the swab skated. It went sideways across a comma of gray-green water and left a clean streak a quarter of an inch long where I hadn't meant to go. The left hand doesn't shake. It simply doesn't know where it is, the way a word in a language you learned at school doesn't know where it is in a sentence.

The face needs six sections, ninety seconds each, gel and timer and clear and rinse, in a cycle that cannot stop in the middle of a section without leaving a tide line on her skin. Nine minutes of work, with the rest of it between, and every second of the ninety held at the same pressure on the same square of a woman's face. I couldn't do twenty-two seconds on a lighthouse.

I put the lighthouse back on its nail and went and stood in front of the table.

From a yard away the lower half was finished, the blue of the mantle running clean to the edge of the canvas and the heel with its lightning crack where he had cleared the last strip on Friday in front of three men without one tremor. Above the knee it was still Wrobel's pink, and her face was up there under it like someone behind frosted glass, with the perfect arch at the left brow and the old break hidden beneath.

His hands could do it. I had watched them do the heel. On my voice, with my count, he could do all six sections and lift at every stop and leave the brow where it was. For four weeks he has done exactly what I said, except for one night I hinged into the book, and since that night he has done it better.

And then the face would be clean, and Frances would sign, and I would never know.

I stood there and kept my eyes on it, as I keep a client's eyes on a loss under the lamp before I let them talk about the frame.

On the seventeenth of November I had stood at this bench and told him the terms. I had called it payment and I had called it a schedule, and both of those were true. Under them, if you stayed on it, there was a third thing, and it had been there since the first night, when he took off his watch without being told. He was easy. He stood where I put him and asked me for nothing, and I came to the bench every evening at six to a pair of hands that wanted nothing from me but the next instruction.

We would hang her on the twenty-fourth and go on like that, the conservator and her best tool, for as long as it was convenient to both of us.

That left me ten days. The face was one night's work if the night was planned to the minute, and I could plan it with one hand. What I couldn't do with one hand was the work, and I would not ask for his until I knew which I was asking for. If I didn't know by the twenty-third, I would telephone Frances that morning and tell her not to come, and the parish would hang Helen Wrobel for one more Christmas, and I would sign my name to that as well.

I went to the bowl and took out my phone.

• • •

He knocked at 1:22. Eighteen minutes on a Sunday, the same as always.

"It's open."

He came in with his coat still on and stopped inside the door, and his hand went into his coat pocket for the phone, and toward the bowl.

"Don't," I said.

The hand stopped over the bowl, and then he put the phone back in his pocket and stood beside the stool without sitting on it.

"A screw has backed out," I said, "in the wrist, the one nearest the joint. I went to Jefferson last night with Odalys."

"Last night," he said. The next question got as far as his mouth and stopped there. "Is it—"

"The plate's holding, but nothing fine until the sixth of January and nothing that loads it. The surgeon says if it moves again she goes back in."

He looked at the brace, and at the arm against my ribs, and nodded once.

"Frances called this morning. Cora went to her on Thursday and cried, and Frances read your page." I watched his face take that. "She read it on Tuesday, in the copies. She says a liar doesn't hinge a page like that into the book. She says it's

the only reason she's coming. Ten o'clock on the twenty-third. She wants the face or there's no re-dedication."

He was very still by the door, in the coat.

"The face needs hands," I said. "It needs six sections at ninety seconds and it can't stop in the middle of one. Mine can't do it, and yours could. You could do it on my count, every section, and it would very likely be perfect."

"I'd do it."

"I know you would." I had my right arm against my ribs, and I kept it there. "And that's the trouble. You'd do it exactly as I said, and she'd be clean, and Frances would sign, and I wouldn't know if I'd wanted you here or wanted your hands. I've had you in that bowl for four weeks. You've never once asked me for anything in this room. My sister stood where you're standing on Wednesday and told me that was the happiest she'd ever been, in a house where nobody asked her for anything. I've been living in the same house. I built it."

He said nothing and went on listening, the way he listened on Thanksgiving, with nothing in his hands.

"The terms said I could end it any day," I said. "I'm ending it today."

Down the room the tap dripped twice into the sink.

"Okay," he said.

I waited for the questions, who would do the face on the twenty-third, whether he could still come on Saturday and eat a sandwich in the corridor, and for a plan to come into his shoulders, where it always shows before it reaches his mouth, and his shoulders stayed as they were under the coat.

"Who's driving you to Jefferson on the sixth?" he said.

"Odalys."

He put his hand in his other coat pocket and took out his keys, and found the brass one on its paper tag, PAPPAS 3, and held it a little apart from the others. "Do you want the key back?"

I looked at it in his hand, the pencil on the tag worn soft from his thumb.

"Keep the key," I said.

He put it away and went out and drew the gate across, and I heard the cage go all the way down and, after a while, through the wired glass, the Outback start.

• • •

I stayed by the door while the radiators knocked through a whole cycle and went quiet.

The bowl sat on its shelf where it has sat since 2018, gray stoneware, the glaze worn paler at the bottom than I remembered, where his phone and his watch had lain every evening since the seventeenth of November.

It was empty.

Chapter 24 — Declan

At 5:20 on Monday he stood up from his desk and had his coat half on before he remembered there was nowhere to be at six.

He sat back down in the coat and stayed there. Out on the floor the coordinators were working the evening wave, Allentown at a hundred and four percent, Carlisle clean for once, and Nadine did not look up. He could have built the week in four minutes: the gym on Ridge Avenue, the Carlisle numbers, a call to Scranton, the gutters on Brown Street, every evening blocked out and timed.

He didn't build it, and left the evenings empty on purpose and drove home at the speed limit, and at the light on Girard he did not turn toward Frankford Avenue.

• • •

The house was dark at six. He put the phone in the blue bowl in the hall, beside her square brass key and Cora's yellow daisy, and then stood there with nothing in his hands and four hours in front of him.

He tried to cook.

His mother made *halušky* every Friday of his childhood, cabbage and noodles and butter and onion in her one black pan, and he had watched her do it two hundred times and never done it himself. The cabbage went in too soon and the butter went brown, then black, and at 6:52 the smoke alarm at the top of the stairs went off. He was standing under it on a kitchen chair flapping a dish towel when somebody banged on the front door with the flat of a hand.

Mrs. Kessler stood on the step in her quilted housecoat with the Inquirer folded under one arm.

"Are you trying to burn down the real one's house?"

"Cabbage," he said.

"I can smell it's cabbage, the whole block can smell it's cabbage." She looked past him at the haze hanging under the hall light. "Open the back, not the front, the back, you want a draft, not a show. And put a lid on that pan. You don't throw water on it, you put a lid on it."

"It's out. It was mostly the butter."

"Then put the lid on anyway," she said, and studied him, the dish towel over his shoulder. "She's not here."

"No."

"I know she's not here, I've got eyes. I'm asking if she's coming back."

"I don't know, Mrs. Kessler."

She took that and nodded once, as though he had finally given her a straight answer about the recycling.

"I'd like my wave back," Mrs. Kessler said. "Six years the real one waved at me every morning from that step. Throw out the cabbage."

She went home.

He threw out the cabbage and ate four slices of toast standing at the counter. When he put the butter away, the freezer still had Cora's white bean soup in it, labeled THURSDAY in her round hand, a skin of frost on the lid. *For her, she likes white bean.* He shut the freezer and left it where it was.

• • •

On Tuesday at 4:50 Nadine stood in his doorway with a flat parcel in brown paper against her hip.

"A woman with a museum lanyard left this at reception at lunch," she said. "Green felt-tip pen behind her ear. She wouldn't give her name. She said to tell you, quote, slower."

He held out his hands for it.

"Do I want to know?"

"No."

"Good," she said, and put it on his desk. "Is it a painting?"

"It's a cow."

"That isn't an answer."

"It's a painting of a cow."

"She also said if you sand it, she'll know, and she'll come back."

Inside was a foot-square painting on board, a barn and a brown cow in a field gone the color of weak tea under old varnish, a \$4 thrift-store thing. Taped to the back: skewers, cotton wool in a sandwich bag, a bottle marked DEIONIZED WATER in green felt-tip, and an index card.

Surface dirt only, water only, nothing else ever. Alder doesn't know and you are not going to tell her. Slower. —O.

He read it twice and put the card in his shirt pocket.

At six that night he put his phone in the bowl, and after a second his watch beside it, and washed his hands at the kitchen sink. He laid a clean dish towel on the table and the cow on the towel, and rolled a swab, and rejected it for a tail, and rolled another.

One inch of field, low on the left, where nobody would look. Damp, not wet. Roll toward you once, and lift.

The cotton came up gray. He put it on the saucer he was using for a can and rolled another, and it came up gray, and another after that. He did not count them, and when he caught the habit trying, he let it go.

At 7:40 the web of his left thumb began to burn, and he stopped and said to the empty kitchen, "My hand's tired," and sat with it in his lap for ten minutes by the clock on the stove before he did it again, slower.

At ten he stopped, because it was ten.

On Wednesday at 12:35 Nadine put her head around his door.

"There's a Mrs. Alder at reception, and she's brought a tin."

He had a call at one and the Hagerstown numbers open on both screens. He closed one of them.

"Bring her up."

Pauline came in with her good wool coat over the navy cardigan, her hair set, carrying a blue cookie tin in both gloved hands like a christening present, and the office filled with Jergens. She smiled at the window and at the river beyond it.

"Declan, dear, I won't keep you, Corabelle says you have eleven hundred people."

"In fourteen buildings."

"Fourteen buildings." She sat in the chair across the desk without being asked and set the tin on his blotter, squarely in the middle. "Shortbread, Gerald's mother's recipe. I made it last night, and I thought, he won't have had anything homemade in weeks, and he's lost weight, I can see it from here."

"Thank you."

"We've all thought of you, rattling around that big house on your own. We've all had such a difficult autumn," Pauline said. "I said so to Father at St. Denis on Sunday. Everyone has been so upset. And Christmas coming."

He waited, as he had learned to wait in a cold room in Kensington with a swab in his hand.

"Maudie won't answer my calls," she said. "She won't come on Christmas Eve. She's in that factory with her poor hand and won't let a soul near her, and you know how she gets when she's dug in, she was like that at four years old. But I think she'd come around, Declan. I think she'd come around if only it were easier for her. If she could see it wasn't her husband who let her down."

"Who let her down?"

"Well." Pauline smoothed her gloves on her knee. "Corabelle has always been impressionable, everyone knows it. She wanted so much to be helpful, and she got carried away, and none of us saw how far, least of all you. Men don't notice these things, it isn't in them, and nobody would blame you for a moment." She leaned an inch toward him over the tin. "Corabelle won't mind, she'd do anything for her sister now. Tell Maudie you didn't know. We'll all say Cora tricked you. It's the kind thing."

On the floor outside somebody laughed and was shushed, and a printer started up.

"I knew," Declan said.

"Knew what, dear?"

"That it was Cora at the table, from the first Friday. I opened the wine and poured it."

"Oh, Declan, that's just what a man says when he's feeling low. You were working all hours, you didn't—"

"I knew."

Pauline looked at him with Maud's gray-green eyes set in her own soft face, and then down at the tin between them, and turned it a quarter turn on the blotter so the lid sat straight.

"Maud read your texts from October sixth," he said.

"I don't know what that is."

"Make it sound like her. Sharper."

Her face did nothing at all except go smooth, like a drawer shut with the folder in it.

"I'm sure I wouldn't know," she said. "You'd be welcome on Christmas Eve, of course, either way. We always do Christmas Eve. Corabelle would make the lamb, the one with the rosemary that everybody liked so much."

"No, thank you, Pauline."

"You don't have to decide now."

"I stopped waiting for her once, in October," Declan said. "I'm not going to stop again."

"Maudie always did take the hard way," Pauline said. "I'd hoped you had more sense than to follow her."

She drew on her gloves, one finger at a time, and stood. She did not raise her voice, and she did not take the tin.

"You'll regret how honest you've become," she said.

"Probably."

She rested one gloved hand on the back of the chair, looking at the tin and not at him.

"Gerald was honest," she said. "It never kept him home on a Sunday."

She went out past Nadine's desk, and he heard her tell Nadine what a lovely view of the river it was, and then the elevator came, and she was gone.

He carried the tin out and set it on the corner of Nadine's desk.

"I'm not eating that," Nadine said, without looking up.

"Nobody's asking you to."

"She asked me if you'd been eating," Nadine typed something. "On the way in, before she asked which office was yours."

• • •

On Thursday he did a second inch of the field and found a fence under the brown, a thin white line of rails nobody had seen since about 1935. At 8:40 the phone lit up in the bowl in the hall, and he went to it, because it was his mother, who called on Sundays and never on Thursdays.

"Deckie."

"Ma, what's the matter?"

"Nothing's the matter, can't a person call her son?" The AM radio was going behind her, and the kitchen chair by the radiator creaked as she sat in it. "I'm asking about Christmas, are you bringing her?"

"I don't know if she'll come."

"Have you asked her?"

"No."

"Why on earth not?" A pause, and the radio. "Are you eating?"

"Toast."

"Toast isn't eating, Declan. And her hand, is she all right with the hand?"

"A screw came loose. She can't use it for anything fine until January."

"Oh, Deckie." The chair creaked. "Then why haven't you asked her about Christmas?"

"She told me not to come around the studio for a while."

There was a silence on the line, with the radio low under it and a man talking about snow in the Poconos.

"And you're listening," his mother said.

"Yes."

"Well," Greta said, "that's new."

He stood in the hall with the phone, by the blue bowl and the brass key.

"So what are you doing with your hands, then, in the evenings? You were never any good with nothing in your hands, not even as a baby."

"I'm cleaning an old painting."

"Hers?"

"No, it's a cow. A friend of hers left it for me to practice on, water and cotton."

"A cow," his mother said.

"And a barn, and I found a fence tonight."

"Is it any good?"

"The cow? No, it's a terrible cow."

His mother laughed, the short laugh that always surprised her, the one he used to get at the kitchen table at six in the morning when he was eleven and the eggs came out right.

"You come at Christmas," she said. "Bring her if she'll come. If she won't, you come anyway."

"Okay, Ma."

She hung up first, as she always did.

• • •

Friday at 9:12 the phone lit again, and he went and looked, because he had stopped pretending he didn't.

She's not done. She's scared.

Odalys, no name on it but the number, no greeting, a period at the end of each line like a cop.

He typed *Is she* and stopped. He typed *What do you* and deleted that too. He held the phone with the cursor blinking for a full minute by the hall clock, and then he turned the screen off and put it back beside her key, and returned to the kitchen and the fence.

He did not call. A call would have been for him.

• • •

On Saturday he went to the four o'clock vigil at St. Wenceslaus, because it counted for Sunday and because he did not know what else to do with a Saturday afternoon.

He sat in the last pew by the radiator. The church was high and cold and smelled of wax and wet wool, and over the altar, where the painting should have been, there was a pale rectangle on the plaster, cleaner than the wall around it, with a gray ghost of dust at its edges. It was seventy-four inches by fifty. He had measured it without meaning to, and he sat watching it through the whole of the second reading.

Walter Wozniak was in the third pew on the aisle, in his overcoat, with his hat on the seat beside him. At the sign of peace he turned around, looking for nobody in particular, and found Declan at the back, and nodded once, formally, chin down.

Declan nodded back.

At the door afterward Mrs. Hajek came past him in her purple hat, stopped, and put a lemon candy in waxed paper into his hand without a word of greeting.

"For the hands," she said.

"I'm not using them, Mrs. Hajek."

"You will," she said, and went down the steps holding the rail.

Father Tomasz was shaking hands in a cloud of his own breath, vestments with a Phillies scarf over them.

"Mr. Hale." A grip like a dock foreman's. "The Monsignor's secretary has stopped saying irregular, she's down to unusual, you tell her that from me, she'll like it."

"I'll tell her," Declan said.

"Good man. Merry Christmas, if I don't see you. Mind the third step, it's been trying to kill Walter since 1971."

He drove home along Aramingo past the Sunoco where he had bought two turkey sandwiches on Thanksgiving, and parked on Brown Street at 5:52, and went in.

At six he put his phone and watch in the blue bowl beside her brass key, washed his hands, and sat down to the cow.

Chapter 25 — Maud

The cheek went in fourteen seconds. I had laid the gel left-handed and started the white timer at ninety, and fourteen seconds into the count the swab rolled twice where it should have rolled once and took the repainter's pink, and the old flesh under it, and the gray under that, down to a fleck of white ground no bigger than a grain of rice.

The cheek was a saint's, eight inches across, cut from a flood-ruined canvas out of a church basement in Reading, with somebody's 1920s flesh laid over the original, and Frances had given it to me when I was twenty-five so that I could ruin it in private. I had ruined it twice in ten years. This was the third time, on Sunday morning with the boiler down and my breath showing, and it was the worst, because the hand that did it was perfectly steady.

It had held the swab firmly and with no idea where the surface was, pressing where it should have floated and floating where it should have pressed, and the whole time I had felt it was doing well.

I cleared the gel off the saint and rinsed what was left of her and laid her back in her drawer in the plan chest on a sheet of tissue, the white fleck up.

• • •

Eight days without a swab on her.

From the door the table stood at forty degrees with the Virgin's face at the height of my chest, and when I brought the raking lamp in low across her I could see the dust that had settled on the varnish since the thirteenth, a fine gray bloom that shows only from the side, the bloom any surface gets when it is left alone in a room with a radiator. Wrobel's pink was under the bloom. Under the pink was what the workshop in Munich had painted, and I had seen three millimeters of it at the jaw and nothing else.

I turned the lamp off and stood where I was.

My father took us to the museum on the Parkway every Sunday from the year we were six until the year he died, and before the doors opened we drank his milky tea on the steps out of the one cup, and then he walked us up to a single painting and stood us in front of it. Usually it was the Rogier van der Weyden in the Johnson rooms, the two panels with the red cloth hung behind the cross and the Virgin folding forward into Saint John's arms. Cora lasted ten minutes and went to look at the armor. I stayed, because he did, and because he had told me what to do there and I believed him entirely, as I believed him about everything until I was nineteen.

Stand there until it stops being a picture.

I asked him once what it was after that. He thought about it on the steps with the cup in his hand.

Then it's a man in a room with a brush, on a Tuesday. And you can see where he got tired.

So I stood there.

It took most of an hour, with Hamid's heater ticking by the cot and a train passing on the El every eleven minutes. At first she was only a picture, a pink face on a brown ground above a blue mantle, a job with a deadline on it and a monsignor at the end. Then she wasn't. Then there was a sign painter in 1957 in a parish hall basement, with a priest at his shoulder and his wife's face in his head, laying that arch over her left brow in one stroke because it was the best stroke he had and he wanted her to have it. Under him, somebody before him, with a smaller brush and less pride, who had filled a scrape on that brow and toned it and left it a little lower than the rest, as if they knew someone would come later and want to see what had happened. Under them both, a man in Munich in 1886, tired by the time he reached the bottom of the mantle, where his glaze goes thin because he thought nobody would ever look there.

And in front of all of them, a woman in a camel coat with one hand that knew where everything was and couldn't hold still, and one that held still and knew nothing.

It was a job for a steady hand and a voice. I had the voice.

• • •

Joan Teague came on Monday at ten past two.

Mr. Pappas rode up with her, which he does for nobody, and held the lever while she stepped out with a tin flat against her red coat, and then took himself down again without a word. She stopped just inside the door and took in the table and the lamp, and then my face, and stayed on the scar a long while.

"Maud?" she said.

Nobody had said my name to me as a question since November.

"Yes."

"Cora told me where you were. In my kitchen, on the third. She drew me a map on the back of an envelope with the El on it." She held out the tin. "They're only butter cookies. I made eight dozen this week. I can't stop making things."

"Not in here. There's no food in the studio."

She set the tin on the boards outside the door, where Father Tomasz had set his coffees, and came back in with her empty hands held together in front of her. She did not sit, and she did not take off her coat. In six years I had never heard Joan get through a sentence without three exclamation marks in it, and she got through this one without any.

"I held your sister's hand at your table for an hour in September and told her the whole of my mother's hip," she said. "The infection, the second surgery, the night nurse. She nodded in all the right places. I lit a candle for you at St. Monica's every Sunday from the thirteenth of September to the twenty-second of November. I counted them on Sunday night. Eleven candles, for a woman sitting at your table in

your apron, while you were in Bologna with nine screws in your arm and nobody lighting anything for you at all.”

Her hands stayed clasped in front of her, the left one holding the right as if it might get away.

“And the thing I can’t get past is that you never once let me hold your hand. Six years. You shake it, once, and you give it back. She let me hold it for an hour, and I thought, oh, the accident’s softened her. I thought it was lovely. I liked her better.”

“You weren’t wrong to,” I said. “She’s easier.”

“That’s what Ray said.” She breathed in through her nose. “I’m not here to be forgiven. I had it in the wrong place, that’s all, eleven Sundays of it, and I wanted to put it where it goes.”

I had nothing to give her for that, and she didn’t wait for anything. She turned to go, and stopped.

“There’s one more thing, and Ray will kill me, and Declan won’t forgive me, and I decided in the car I can live with both. Did he tell you about Atlanta?”

“What’s Atlanta?”

She shut her eyes for a second.

“Ray offered him Senior Vice President on the twenty-third of November. Network Operations, at headquarters in Atlanta, starting the fourth of January. It paid \$140,000 more than he makes. It’s the job he drew in a little box on the back of a shift sheet when he was twenty-seven.” She held the strap of her bag in both hands. “On the seventh he walked into Ray’s office at eight in the morning and turned it down. Ray asked him what for. He said evenings. Ray came home and said evenings at the dinner table as if it were the name of a disease.”

The seventh was a Monday, the morning after he filled the loss in the corner, fifty minutes for half an inch with my hand on his wrist. He had come at six that night and put the studio key on the shelf by the bowl, and I had told him to wash his hands.

“Why are you telling me?” I said.

“Because he won’t,” said Joan Teague.

She went to the cage and stood in it, and studied the lever, and then me.

“Forward is up,” I said. “Center is stop.”

“Merry Christmas, Maud,” she said, and then, carefully, as if she were labeling it, “I mean you.”

• • •

When the cage had gone down I went out and sat on the corridor floor with my back against the wall, where he had eaten his sandwiches on Saturdays out of waxed paper with his legs out across the boards, and opened Joan’s tin on my knees, one-handed.

The cookies were in layers with wax paper between them, and they were very good. I ate one, and then another.

He had turned down Atlanta and not told me. He had looked at what it would cost me, decided it for both of us, and paid it himself before I could see the bill. It was the corner again, done kindly. I would tell him so, to his face, and not today.

I need his hands, and I need him, and I am never going to get the two apart. I stopped trying on the floor of that corridor with a butter cookie in my good hand.

I put the lid back on the tin.

I would ask him when I could count her whole face aloud without a stumble, and not an hour before, and no later than the evening of the twenty-third, which left three and a half hours for him to learn it on the lighthouse before Frances came up in the cage. If I asked for his hands, they were not going to stand at that table waiting on my voice.

• • •

On Tuesday I drew her face on Mylar.

I laid the clear sheet over the photograph of the face I had taken on the third, under the raking light, and drew the sections in fine marker left-handed, the lines wandering where the hand wandered. There were six of them, the jaw first, where the test was, because it was the part of her I already knew. Then the right cheek, then the nose and the mouth together, because a mouth can't be done in halves. Then the right eye and its brow. Then the left eye and cheek. Last, the left brow, from the arch to the edge of the veil, with the old scrape at its outer end in dotted line. Beside it I wrote in my leaning capitals, LEAVE.

Then I practiced the count.

I set the white timer to ninety and stood at the table with my right arm against my ribs and counted aloud to the empty face, every ten, and then the clear and the roll, and the short words for moving and stopping, each one short enough to get out between two breaths, so that there would never be a second in ninety when he was waiting on me to finish a sentence. I did it six times. Five came out the same length, and the sixth caught on the right eye, at the clear, and I would do it again in the morning until it didn't.

At four I sent Frances a text, because she will answer a text and she will not answer the telephone the day before a job.

Ten o'clock tomorrow, confirmed. M. Alder.

It came back in eleven minutes.

Face done or no deal. F.T.

The shelf over the bowl had Cora's envelope on it, MAUD in her round marker, six pages and fourteen hundred words she had counted without knowing why. I took it down, and it weighed what six pages weigh, and I put it back, because it was not March.

At ten I turned off the lamp and the heater and went to the door.

I put my phone in the bowl, where his had lain every evening for four weeks, and left it there overnight.

Chapter 26 — Declan

At 5:40 on Wednesday the phone lit on his desk with her name on it, and he had it at his ear before the second ring and then said nothing, because he did not know which word would be the wrong one.

"It's me," Maud said.

"I know."

Outside his glass the floor was running the heaviest night of the year, everybody's Christmas on a trailer somewhere between Hagerstown and Scranton, Allentown at a hundred and eighteen percent of slots, and nobody going home.

"Are you at work?"

"Yes."

"I thought you'd be in the car by now. You used to leave at twenty past."

"Not this week," he said, watching the coordinators through the glass.

At her end a train rumbled through on the El, and under it the tap dripped once.

"I'm going to say something," she said, "and I want you to let me get to the end of it, because I've practiced it, and if you stop me I'll lose my place."

"Okay."

"I'm asking. Not telling. That's the first part, so hold on to it." Her voice was very level, the voice she counted in. "Frances is coming at ten tonight, and the face isn't done, and I can't do it with what I've got. I tried with the left hand on Sunday, on a scrap, and went through a saint to the ground in fourteen seconds. It's six sections at ninety seconds each, and it needs a steady hand working on my voice, and I want to ask you if you'll come tonight and—"

"Yes."

"I haven't finished, Declan."

"Yes."

The line stayed open, and he could hear her breathing, and Hamid's heater ticking somewhere near the phone. He kept his free hand pressed flat to the desk.

"Let me finish."

He shut his mouth on the third yes.

"I want to ask you if you'll come and do it. I'm not asking under the terms. There aren't any terms, I ended them on the thirteenth and I meant it." She stopped, and started again lower. "I want you there tonight. I want your hands, and I want you, and I can't tell you which one I want more, and I've stopped trying to find out. You're allowed to say no. If you say no, I'll call Frances and tell her not to come, and the Virgin goes up tomorrow with Wrobel's face on her, and that's mine to carry."

"Yes," he said, and heard how little there was in it, and left it that way.

"That's all you're going to say?"

"That's all."

She breathed out, and he heard it.

"Do you want anything from the house?"

"No. Just come."

"How's the hand?" he said.

"In the brace, and it's staying there. I haven't used it for anything since the thirteenth. Dr. Kaplan says the sixth, and I'm going to do what she says, because I'd like to have it when I'm sixty. Mr. Pappas is leaving the street door open till eight. Odalys is driving Frances and the dog in at nine. Walter says he'll sit on the stairs with his hat and wait, and I couldn't talk him out of it."

"Do you want me to roll the swabs when I get there?"

"Yes, all of them. I can't roll a swab with this, and I won't have time to watch you do two hundred once she's in the chair."

"Two hundred," he said.

"Eat something on the way. You won't eat after, and I don't want you lighththeaded at eleven o'clock over her mouth."

"I'll eat."

"And wear cotton."

He glanced down at his tie. "There's a shirt in the trunk."

"Then put it on in the car," she said, and the tap dripped once, and then she said, "Thank you."

"Half past six."

She hung up first, and he held the dead phone to his ear a while longer before he put it in his pocket.

• • •

Her brass key was in the left pocket of his coat, where it had been since ten to seven that morning. He had taken it out of the blue bowl on his way out of the house, from beside Cora's yellow daisy, and the parcel off the hall table with it, and put the parcel on the passenger seat of the Outback, and he had not asked himself what for, all day.

Nadine took the headset off her ear as he came past.

"Allentown's at one-eighteen," he said. "Carlisle's got nine in the yard, Russ is moving—"

"I know where Carlisle is." She went back to her screen. "Ray says don't come in tomorrow, it's Christmas Eve, and he'll know if you do. Your five-twenty's twenty minutes late."

• • •

Okay. So. One: the Schuylkill to the Vine, twenty-two minutes if the Vine was clear, and it would not be clear. Two: the Wawa on Aramingo, something she would call food. Three: the space across Frankford from the door, under the light, and then the stairs, and then

He didn't know what came after *then*. He let it go somewhere around the Conshohocken curve, in the middle of the sentence, with the river black on his right and taillights packed red all the way into the city, and drove.

At the Wawa he bought a turkey hoagie and ate it in the lot with the engine running, all of it, because she had asked him to. Then he changed into the gray T-shirt from the gym bag in the trunk, in the driver's seat with the windows going white around him, and his hands were steady, and he noted it as he would note a door that sealed.

• • •

He parked across Frankford Avenue at 6:24, under the streetlight, in the space where he had sat with the engine off on the night of their anniversary. Mr. Pappas stood on the step in a cardigan, shaking salt out of a coffee can in long even arcs under Hamid's red sign.

"So," Mr. Pappas said, "big house, small car."

"Yes," Declan said, since there was no arguing with it.

"She told me you come tonight. She told me twice, and she doesn't tell me anything once. You go up, I lock the door at eight, the old lady and the dog I let in myself." He shook the can over the bottom step, though it was already white. "Good."

Declan went back across the street for the parcel, because a parcel on a back seat on Frankford Avenue at night was a broken window by morning, and that was a reason, and he took it. He carried it under his arm into the cage, and pushed the brass lever forward and went up, and on three drew the gate across.

The door was ajar, and he knocked anyway.

"It's open."

She was at the table with the raking lamp low and her right arm held against her ribs in the brace, the camel coat on over her apron. She looked at the parcel under his arm for one second and then back at his face, and neither of them mentioned it. He set it on the shelf over the bowl, beside Cora's white envelope with MAUD on it in round marker.

Her phone was already in the bowl, the gray case with the cracked corner, the screen dark. There had never been two phones in it. He stood a second with his own in his hand, and then put it in beside hers, and unbuckled the watch from his right wrist and laid it across both of them.

"You ate," she said.

"A turkey hoagie, at the Wawa on Aramingo."

"All of it?" she said.

"All of it."

She read his face the way she read a swab coming off the paint, and he let her.

"Wash your hands," she said.

He washed them at the sink, and she talked while he did, in short sentences, as she had given him the terms in November, except that it wasn't terms.

"There are six sections." She turned a clear plastic sheet on the bench toward him with her left hand. Under it lay a photograph of the Virgin's face, and over the face a map in black marker, the lines wandering a little, six shapes numbered in her capitals. "The jaw first, because I know it. The left brow last of all."

He dried his hands and came to the bench, where she had the sheet lined up under the lamp.

"Gel on, inside the line. Ninety seconds on my count. Then clear, one roll toward you, and lift. Then rinse, and the next. I'll be talking the whole time, but while you're on her I'll only use three words. Left means move left the width of the swab. Lift means lift. Stop means stop, even in the middle of a roll. You don't finish anything I've told you to stop."

He looked at the six shapes until they stopped being a drawing.

"If I say again, you do the same place again, with a fresh swab, not the old one."

"Fresh swab."

"If the swab comes up anything but pink, you stop and you tell me. Pink is Wrobel, and anything else is her." She did not look up from the sheet. "And if your hand gets tired, you say so. Before a section, never in one."

"What does Frances do?"

"Sits in the chair and watches. She won't talk, and if she does, you don't answer her, you answer me." She touched the photograph at the lower left with one finger. "She'll look at the corner first, with the UV lamp, before anything else."

"Do you want me to tell her?"

"No. It's in the book, in your capitals. The book tells her."

He bent over the sheet. At the outer end of the left brow, where it ran under the veil, there was a short dotted line, and beside it, in the same capitals, one word.

"What's that?"

"That stays," she said.

He kept his eyes on it until he had the shape of it by heart.

"We have three and a half hours," she said. "First you roll the swabs. Then we do the whole thing on the lighthouse, with plain water, six times through, until you stop waiting for me to finish a word."

The lighthouse was already clamped at the end of the bench, with the timer and a fresh box of large gloves beside it. She had rolled nothing, because she couldn't, and left it for him.

He pulled on the gloves, tight across the knuckles as they always were, and then stood in the middle of the room with his hands empty and did not go to the bench.

"Where do I stand?"

She came around the table and put her left hand on his sleeve, above the wrist, and moved him half a step, onto the place where the boards dip, a yard from the face.

“Here.”

Chapter 27 — Maud

The cage came up at 9:56 with a dog in it.

Bartholomew rode in a canvas tote on Odalys's shoulder, front half out. Frances stood behind them on the blackthorn stick. Odalys drew the gate across and latched it.

"Walter's on the landing below," she said. "He won't come up. He's been there since nine with a thermos. I told him Frances hates an audience, and he said, I know, I'll be on the stairs."

"Thank you."

"I'll sit with him. Call me when you want me." She set the tote down inside the door. Bartholomew got out of it by falling. She returned to the stairs without a word to the table.

Frances came in on the stick and stopped. She looked at the face on the table, at the height of my chest, and then at Declan, standing where I had put him.

"Chair," she said.

"By the lamp."

"How's the hand?"

"A screw backed out. Nothing fine until the sixth of January."

"Who says?"

"Esther Kaplan, at Jefferson."

"Good. She's careful."

It was Mr. Pappas's own chair from the office by the boiler, oak, with arms. Frances lowered herself into it in two stages. Bartholomew lay down across her feet.

"You," she said to Declan. "How many sections?"

"Six."

"How long?"

"Ninety seconds each."

"And if a swab comes up a color you don't expect?"

"I stop and tell her."

"Not me?"

"Her."

"Have you done a face before?"

"No."

"What have you done?"

"The lower half. Ninety-one losses, and the varnish." He did not look at me. "And the corner."

"The corner," Frances said.

"Yes."

"Hold out your hands."

He held them out, palms down. They did not move.

"Hm." She held out her hand to me. "Book."

I gave it to her.

She read with the glasses on the end of her nose, her finger down every margin. It took eleven minutes, and she read nothing aloud until the hinge.

At the hinge she lifted the graph-paper sheet with one fingernail. She had read it in her kitchen, and she read it again.

"Saturday the fifth. Twelve-forty, swab yellow at edge, continued. One-thirty, left hand cramped, continued with right." She let the sheet fall back. "So he knew the rule, and he broke it."

"Once."

"Once is the number I care about, Alder. You could have left this page out of the copies."

"It happened."

"Hm. Corner."

I switched off the room. The UV lamp hummed in the dark. The mantle came up green, and at the bottom left his dots sat in the green, dark, every one.

Frances leaned forward. She had her own loupe, an old black folding one, and held it to her eye.

"Thirteen," she said.

"Thirteen."

"Who laid the retouch?"

"He did. I held his wrist."

"Did he argue about it?"

"He asked who would do it. That's all."

I turned the room back on.

"Face," she said.

• • •

We had done it six times on the lighthouse, with water. He stopped waiting for my words on the fourth. The gel was in its jar, the swabs in another, two hundred, rolled by him between seven and eight.

I stood at his right shoulder. I put my right hand on the table edge in its brace and left it there. He put on the headband, my old one with the taped hinge.

"Begin when you like," Frances said.

"When the train's gone."

It went over at 10:31, the whole length of it, and the jar of swabs rang and stopped.

"The jaw," I said. "Thin. Inside the line."

He laid the gel on. It went on clear and sat on Wrobel's pink like water on glass. I started the timer. "Ten."

He held the brush off the canvas and waited.

"Twenty, thirty."

The El was not due for ten minutes. I had timed the sections between trains. Ninety seconds fits into eleven minutes seven times.

"Forty, fifty. Sixty."

My hand began to go on the table edge, the fine tremor first. I let it.

"Seventy, eighty. Ninety. Clear."

He took a swab from the jar. He set it at the top of the jaw and rolled it toward himself, once.

"Lift."

It came up pink, sign painter's pink in lead white, the pink of Leon Wrobel's Easter Sunday. He dropped it in the can and took another.

"Left. Lift. Left. Lift. Rinse."

He rinsed. I brought the lamp in low.

The jaw was green underneath. Over the green lay a thin warm skin of color, laid in one breath by somebody in Munich. It was a jaw, a real one, heavier than Wrobel's, with the shadow of the veil across it.

"Solvent?" Frances said from the chair.

"Four, in gel. The same as the test on the third."

"Hm."

He did not turn around. He was changing his swab.

• • •

"The right cheek."

"Thinner at the ear," I said. He laid it thinner, and I set the timer going, and counted.

His hand was still. Mine was not. It went on against the table, a fine fast ticking I could feel in my teeth, and I kept my voice above it.

"Eighty, ninety. Clear."

One roll. "Lift," I said, and the swab came up pink.

"Left. Lift."

The next came up pink, and gray at one edge.

He stopped. He held the swab in the air and did not drop it.

"Gray," he said.

I put the lamp on the cotton. It was grime from before Wrobel, a hundred years of candles sealed in under the pink in 1957.

"Dirt," I said. "From before him. It was under his paint. Go on."

He went on. "Slower," I said. "Left. Lift. Change your swab. Left. Lift. Rinse."

The cheek came up out of the pink fuller than I had thought, higher at the bone. There was red in it under the glaze, the red of somebody who had been out in the cold.

Behind me the stick knocked once against the oak.

• • •

“The nose and the mouth,” I said, to Frances as much as to him. “Both halves in one.”

“Go on,” Frances said.

I had drawn this one on the Mylar four times since Sunday, because a tide line across a mouth would read as a scar from every pew in the church.

His brush went around the corner of the mouth and back without a pause. The timer started under my thumb.

“Ten, twenty. Thirty, forty.”

At forty-four the floor began to hum.

It was the El, two minutes early. The trains were on the holiday schedule, and I had not known there was one.

The hum came up through the boards into the table legs. The swab jar rang on the bench. The lamp trembled on its arm, and the light on her face trembled with it.

“Fifty,” I said.

He did not move. The swab was in his hand above the canvas, and the train went over us, all six cars of it.

“Sixty, seventy.”

The hum went out of the table. The jar stopped ringing.

“Eighty. Ninety. Clear.”

A single roll. “Lift. Left. Lift. Left.”

“Stop.”

He stopped mid-roll, with the cotton on her upper lip.

“Lift.”

He lifted straight up. He did not finish the roll. A fleck of pink stayed at the corner of her mouth, and he left it there because I had not said otherwise.

“Rinse.”

The fleck went in the rinse.

Her mouth was closed. Wrobel had given her a smile, a small one, the corners lifted for the parish photograph. Under it the mouth was straight and full and a little dry. It was the mouth of a woman who had not slept.

Frances put her glasses back on.

“Your train was early,” she said.

“It’s the holiday schedule. He didn’t move.”

“I saw. Gel strength at the mouth?”

“The same. Less of it.”

“Hm.”

• • •

“The right eye.”

He wiped the brush between sections and changed his swab before it was spent, and I counted him through it.

“Left. Lift. Same place, again. Lift. Left. Lift. Rinse.”

The eye came out of the pink looking down.

Wrobel had painted her eyes at the congregation, pleasant and a little surprised. Under him the eye was half-closed and lowered. It looked down and to the left, at the child in the straw.

Nobody living had known that.

• • •

“You’re shaking,” Frances said.

“I know.”

“Sit down.”

“No. Arm’s reach, and awake. Your terms.”

“Hm.”

“The left eye,” I said. “And the cheek.”

My hand had gone past the fine tremor into the coarse one. It shook against the table edge hard enough that the brace knocked on the wood. I pressed it down with my forearm and it went on shaking under the arm.

His did not.

He held the swab low on the stick, lightly, as I held one at twenty-five, before Ravenna.

“Lighter,” I said. “Let the gel do the work.” And then, at ninety, “Clear.”

“Left. Lift. Stop.”

He stopped.

“Lift. Rinse.”

The left eye came up beside the right, lowered too, looking at the same place. The cheek came after it.

Above them Wrobel’s arch, one stroke, was the last of him on her face. Under the raking light you could see, if you knew, the stepped edge of something older beneath it.

He put the swab in the can.

“My hand’s tired,” he said.

He said it between sections, as he had been told. He said it to me, quietly, in the voice he had used at ten past three on Thanksgiving.

Frances went still in the chair.

“Rest it. Two minutes. I’ll count them.”

He stepped back off the dip and opened and closed the fingers of his left hand. He did not turn to the clock over the sink.

Frances and I waited, and Bartholomew let out a long breath on her feet and went on sleeping.

The tap dripped. I counted thirty drips, two minutes.

He stepped back onto the dip.

“Okay,” he said.

“The brow.”

I held the Mylar up beside her face, left-handed, so he could see the dotted line once more. Then I put it down.

He laid the gel on the arch, thin, inside the line, and stopped the brush short of the veil.

I set the timer for the last time.

“Ten. Twenty. Thirty.”

My voice was steady, and I kept it on the numbers.

“Forty, fifty.”

Under the gel the arch began to go soft at its edges. The perfect line went gray and slack.

“Sixty, seventy. Eighty.”

The El was not due for six minutes.

“Ninety. Clear.”

He rolled at the outer end of the brow, toward himself.

“Lift.”

It came up pink, and the arch came away in a curl.

“Left. Lift.”

Under it the real brow came up out of the paint. It was lower than his, and darker, with a few long strokes laid the way hair lies. Somebody had painted it while looking at a brow.

“Left.”

He rolled toward the middle, and it came up pink again.

“Lift. Left. Slower here. Slower.”

He was coming to it now, the old scrape at the end of the brow where it ran under the veil, where something had struck her between 1886 and 1957. Someone after that had filled it with a small brush and left it a little low, mended and left showing, and then Wrobel had covered all of it.

His swab came to the edge of the old fill. The edge was stepped. One crumb of the filling stood up proud on it and caught the lamp.

He rolled toward it.

“Leave it.”

He stopped.

The swab sat one millimeter short of the edge. I could see the millimeter, and the crumb catching the light, and the cotton not touching it.

He did not roll again or come back for the crumb, and he did not take a fresh swab and tidy the edge so it would lie flat.

“Lift,” I said.

He lifted straight up.

“Rinse.”

He rinsed inside the line and stopped short of the scrape with the rinse as well. Then he took off the headband and stepped back and stood with his hands at his sides.

The timer was still in my left hand. I put it down on the bench.

• • •

She was not Helen Wrobel.

Her face was broader than his and older, a farm girl's face or a carter's daughter's from somewhere outside Munich. Her cheeks were red from the cold, and her eyes were lowered to the child.

She was a woman who had given birth that night in a stable and had not slept since, looking at what she had, thinking about nobody in the room.

At the end of her left brow, under the edge of the veil, was an old break, mended and a little low.

Frances got up in two moves and the stick and came to stand beside me with her loupe open. She took a long time, the brow longest of all, her head down in the raking light.

"Who drew the sections?" she said.

"I did. On Tuesday, left-handed."

"Show me."

I held out the Mylar. She found the dotted line by the brow and the one word beside it.

"Leave," she read. "You decided that before he touched her."

"On Tuesday."

"Hm. UV."

I turned off the room. Under the UV lamp the face came up dark and even, the old varnish gone with the pink. There were no islands anywhere, only the brow, where the old fill read a shade darker than the paint around it, the color retouching always reads.

"Lights."

I turned them on.

"You knew about the brow," she said.

"Since the third of December. I logged it that night, under the raking light."

"You'll be asked to fill it. By the Monsignor, by the committee, by everybody who sits in a pew and wants her pretty."

"I know."

"Don't let them talk you into it."

"I won't."

She closed the loupe. She turned and studied Declan, and then me.

"Whose hands?" she said.

"His."

She held my eyes over the glasses for a long moment.

She returned to the chair and took a sheet of cream laid paper from her cardigan pocket, and a fountain pen, and wrote one line standing, on the notebook.

I read it upside down. She taught me that too.

Treatment examined 23 December 2026, 11:24 p.m. I certify it. F. Tilley.

She blotted it on the back of the notebook, from habit, and folded it once and held it out.

"Your Monsignor wants it by midnight," she said. "Give it to the man on the stairs."

I took it out to the landing. Walter was on the step below with his hat on his knee and a green thermos, Odalys on the step above. He stood when he saw the paper and took it in both hands.

"Ms. Alder," he said. "He'll have it in his hand by a quarter to. I telephoned the rectory at ten, and he's waiting up in his coat." He paused on the step. "Bernadette will ask me what she looks like."

"Tell her she isn't Helen Wrobel."

He put it inside his overcoat unread, against his chest, and went down one even step at a time.

"Is it done?" Odalys said.

"It's signed. The face is done, and it's signed."

"Did he shake?"

"No. I did."

She put her hand over her mouth and kept it there.

I went back in.

Frances had her coat on. Declan was holding it by the shoulders while she found the second sleeve, and she let him. When it was on she turned around and tipped her head back to see his face.

"You said your hand was tired," she said.

"Yes."

"Before the section."

"Yes."

"Hm." She took the stick off the chair arm. "Do that again. Every time you pick up a swab for the rest of your life."

"Every time."

"What do you do, when you're not here?"

"Freight."

"Hm. Keep the capitals." She turned to me. "The Fuentes girl will drive me home. Don't telephone me tomorrow, I'll be asleep. Telephone me on the sixth, after your surgeon, and tell me what she says, exactly what she says."

"I will."

She came to the door. Bartholomew woke and leaned on my shins. Odalys waited on the threshold holding the tote open.

“Car’s out front,” Odalys said. “Heater’s running. Mr. Pappas is holding the street door.”

Frances stopped in front of me. She was shorter than I am now. She had not been, the year I was twenty-four. The hip had taken an inch off her.

“I came here to fail you,” she said.

“I know.”

She put her free hand on my right arm, over the brace, where it was still shaking, and left it there until it stopped.

“Kid.”

Chapter 28 — Declan

At 12:51 her phone lit up in the bowl, and she asked him to read it to her, because she did not want to stand up yet and was not sure she could.

He took it out of the bowl and read it standing.

"Ms. Alder. The Monsignor has it in hand as of 11:44 p.m. He read it twice and said, Good. He has asked me to tell you the handlers may come at nine. Walter Wozniak."

"Read me the last part again."

"The handlers may come at nine."

"Nine," she said. "Ike will be early. He's been early since 2017." Then, as if it were the strangest thing to happen all night, "Walter texts."

"He signs it," Declan said, and turned the screen so she could see the name at the bottom, spelled out in full.

"Of course he signs it." She was on the cot in the camel coat with her right arm held against her ribs, and under the coat the hand was still going, the coarse shake, steady as an engine at idle. "Put it back, I don't need it till morning."

He put it back beside his own and sat down again with his back to the bench leg, where he had sat at eight o'clock every night to rest his hand.

The work lamp was off. The face on the table was lit by the corridor bulb and the coil of Hamid's heater, and there was nothing pink on it anywhere.

"What happens to the brow?" he said.

"Nothing, it stays the way it is."

"The Monsignor will ask you to fill it."

"Then I'll tell him what Frances told me."

"What did she tell you?"

"Not to let anybody talk me into it." She turned her head against the wall to see the face. "Did you know she'd look like that?"

"No. I thought she'd look like the pink one, only cleaner."

"So did the parish. Nobody alive knew. She looks as though she's been up all night."

"She has," he said. "There's a baby."

Something happened at the corner of her mouth, and went.

"Father Tomasz said to tell you something," he said.

"When did you see Father Tomasz?"

"Saturday, at the door after the four o'clock."

"You went to the vigil."

"Last pew, by the radiator. He said the Monsignor's secretary has stopped saying irregular. She's down to unusual."

Maud put her head back against the wall above the cot and shut her eyes.

"You've been carrying that since Saturday," she said.

"I said I'd tell you."

"Tell him tomorrow that she liked it, at the door."

"I'll tell him."

"Will you come tomorrow night, to the Mass?"

"Last pew, by the radiator."

"Not in the photographs."

"Not in any of them."

Outside, the last El train before the long gap at night went across, and the jar of swabs on the bench gave its small ring and stopped.

"Joan told me," she said.

He sat with that for a while.

"I'm going to be annoyed about that later," he said.

"She came on Monday with a tin of butter cookies, and she stood by the bench in her red coat and told me she'd lit eleven candles for the wrong woman, and then she told me about Atlanta. Senior Vice President, the fourth of January, the box on the shift sheet. I didn't know what Atlanta was. I had to ask her." She opened her eyes and looked at him across the boards. "Afterward I sat on the floor of the corridor, where you eat your lunch, and ate two of her cookies. She said I never let her hold my hand. Six years, and I shake it once and give it back."

"You do."

"I'm going to let her hold it, tomorrow night, if she comes." She shifted the arm against her ribs. "She told me Ray said evenings at the dinner table as if it were a disease."

"He said it louder in his office." He watched her settle the arm. "Were they good?" he said. "The cookies."

"They were very good. Why didn't you tell me?"

"You'd have had to decide what it cost you."

"That was mine to decide."

"Yes."

"You took it off my plate," Maud said.

He had said those words to the back of her head on a Saturday night at eleven o'clock while she slept, and gone to the right half of a two-inch square with a swab, and three hours later there had been a hole in the glaze the size of a shirt button.

"Yes," he said, and kept his eyes on hers.

"That's what you do. You did it with the corner, and you did it again with Atlanta. This time it was the right thing, and I still wanted to be asked."

"Next time I'll tell you, and we decide it."

"We," she said, as if she were writing it in the book.

"I know what I do." He kept his hands open on his thighs. "I can't fix this. I can only stay in it."

She didn't answer, but held his eyes across the boards, and he let her.

"In November you told me I could say it to the elevator," he said. "I'm saying it here. I'm sorry. For the nine weeks. That was mine."

The tap dripped, and she stayed where she was on the cot.

"I'm not asking you to say it's fine," he said. "I'm asking if you can forgive it. You can take as long as you want."

"I heard it," she said. "I'm going to take some of the time. Not all of it."

The heater ticked. After a while she said, "What happens in January?"

"Ray kept me, same job, same fourteen buildings. A hard five-thirty, every day, in writing. He made HR send it on Monday so I couldn't argue with it. Nadine runs the late shift."

"Does Nadine want it?"

"She asked for it in 2023. I told her next year."

"And who goes to Atlanta?"

"A woman from Memphis. She starts on the fourth." He thought about it, rubbing the place on his right wrist where the watch usually sat. "Ray says she's better than me. He said it twice, so it's probably true."

"Are you sorry?"

"No."

"What did you do that night, the seventh?"

"Came here at six. You said wash your hands. Then I went home and slept seven hours, first time since the summer, and woke up and didn't trust it."

• • •

"I'm going to ask you for some things," she said, and he waited.

"I stopped asking you for things in the spring. I don't think you noticed when. It was a Sunday in March. I asked you to come to the museum with me, and you said next week, and I didn't ask again, and after that it was easier not to ask for anything, and then it was a habit, and then I was on a scaffold in Italy." Her voice stayed level, and he could hear that she had practiced this too. "So I'm going to start again. Some of them are small. You're going to have to listen to all of them, because I've been saving them since March."

He shifted on the boards so that his back was against the bench leg and his whole face was toward her.

"I want you to drive me to Jefferson on the sixth. I'll tell Odalys she's off. She hates the parking garage."

"What time is the appointment?"

"Twenty to nine, on the ninth floor."

"I'll be outside at eight."

"When you ask me what I need, and I say nothing, I want you to ask again. Once more, that's all, and then wait."

He thought of a Sunday in August, the laptop on the kitchen counter and her face on the screen with her hair forward, saying *Nothing*, and his own voice saying *Okay. So.*

"Yes," he said, and stopped there.

"I want to come home tonight, not to talk. I want to sleep in my own bed on Brown Street, on my side, and wake up and hear you on the stairs, and then I want you to drive me back here before the handlers come at nine."

"The fourth one creaks."

"I know it creaks. I want to hear it."

"There's soup in the freezer," he said. "Cora's, white bean. It says Thursday on the lid, and for her, she likes white bean."

Maud was silent for the length of two drips.

"Throw it out," she said. Then, "No, leave it. I'll throw it out myself."

"In March, on a Sunday, I want you to come to the museum on the Parkway with me and stand in front of one painting until you're bored, and then stay."

"Which painting?"

"I'll show you when we get there. It has a red cloth hung behind it."

"Will I like it?"

"No. You'll stand there until you do."

"I want you to tell me when you're tired. Not your hand. You. At work, in the house, in the car. I want you to say it out loud and stop, as you did tonight in front of Frances."

That one took him longer. He had been tired since he was eleven and getting up at a quarter to six for the eggs, and he had never once said so to anybody, not to Ray and not to her.

"Yes," he said. "I'll say it out loud."

"And I want you to ask me to Scranton."

He looked up at her from the floor.

"Your mother," Maud said. "She'll have asked you about Christmas, I'd bet money on it, more than once, and you'll have told her you didn't know if I'd come. Ask me."

"Come to Scranton with me on the twenty-sixth." His voice came out lower than he meant it to. "She wants you there, she's wanted you there for six years. She'll make you *halušky* on a Saturday, and she only ever makes it on Fridays."

"Does she know about my hand?"

"I told her a screw came loose. She said, and you're listening."

"Are you?"

"Yes."

"Then yes," Maud said. "And in the morning, on the way back here, we stop for coffee. At the place on Girard that opens at six-thirty."

On the seventeenth of November she had said no to the place on Girard, and to everything else he offered that night.

"Two coffees," he said.

"Two, and that's all of them, for tonight."

He said nothing for a while, and the heater ticked between them.

"Can I ask you for something?" he said.

She went very still on the cot, as she went still over a swab before it came off the paint. "Yes."

"When your hand's back, after the sixth, after whatever she says. Can I still come on Saturdays?"

"To do what?"

"Learn it. Not to be your hands. I'd like to be good at something slow, and I'd like it to be this."

She considered him for a while, her head against the wall.

"Yes," she said. "Eight to six. Bring your own lunch and eat it in the corridor, and in the spring, when it's warmer, you can eat it in here."

"I miss you," he said.

"I'm right here."

"I know. I still do." He turned his hands over. "I've missed you since before Italy. I thought it was the job."

She sat very still, and then she took her right arm out from against her ribs and laid it across her lap in the brace where he could see it shaking, and left it there.

"I love you," she said.

She said it in her own voice, exactly as she said everything, a whole sentence with nothing on either side of it to make it smaller, and she did not look away from him while she said it.

"I love you," he said.

"I know you do. I knew in the chapel, with my head on the bricks. That was never the part I couldn't tell." She drew a breath and let it go. "The evenings were never going to pay for the nine weeks. I've stopped wanting them to."

"I wasn't counting."

"You were counting. You had a hundred and nineteen hours for Walter without opening the book."

"I didn't tell Walter anything. I said ask Maud."

"Because you knew it to the hour."

"I knew it," he said. "I wasn't counting it toward anything."

She looked at him, and then she put out her left hand, palm up, across the space between the cot and the floor.

"Come here," she said.

He got up off the boards and sat beside her on the cot, on her left, where her good hand was. Through the coat the shake in her right arm came into his, and he did not try to hold it still. He put his left hand over her braced wrist and let it shake against his palm.

She turned her face up to him in the light from the corridor.

He put his right hand to her face, slowly, the way he had learned to come down on a surface, and his thumb found the scar. It was a raised line through her left eyebrow, running up and out into her hair, two and a half inches, hard under the skin where the plank had opened it. He had seen it first in the kitchen on the fourteenth of November, and had gone from it to her sister's face and back, and had known then what he had done.

He knew it now under his thumb. He would have known her in the dark.

She was the one who closed the distance. She kissed him the way she said things, plainly, all of it at once, and he kissed her back with his thumb on the scar and her braced hand shaking against his palm, and the heater ticked, and the tap dripped, and neither of them counted anything.

When she drew back an inch she kept her forehead against his.

“Don’t go back to the floor,” she said.

He didn’t.

• • •

At ten to three he turned off Hamid’s heater and checked the plug and the tap, and came back to where she sat with her braid coming loose.

“There’s something in my pocket,” he said.

“I know. You’ve been sitting on it since half past six.”

He took out the key and held it on his palm. It was brass and square-headed, the key to the front door on Brown Street, the one that needed a lift before it turned.

“Is the bowl back?” she said.

“Since the end of November, on the hall table where it goes.”

“Where was it?”

“In one of Cora’s boxes, full of her hair clips. I washed it and put it back.”

“Is her key still in it?”

“The yellow one, yes.”

“Put it in the kitchen drawer.”

“Okay,” he said, and he could already see the drawer, the one with the takeout menus and the dead batteries.

“You took it off the table this morning,” she said, “before you knew I’d call. Why?”

“I don’t know.”

“Yes, you do.”

“Yes,” he said. “I do.”

Then she reached left-handed into her apron for her own keys, the ring with the studio key on it, PAPPAS 3 in the same faded pencil as his, and held the ring out to him.

“Put it on,” she said. “I can’t open a ring with one hand.”

He worked the split ring open with his thumbnail and fed her house key on beside the studio key and let the ring close. She closed her fingers over both.

He took the parcel down from the shelf over the bowl, brown paper, his own thick tape on the corners, and the two phones and his watch out of the bowl, and they went out, and he drew the door to, and the strip of light went off the face behind it.

At three she locked the bottom one with her own key, the house key knocking against it on the ring, and held out her hand for the parcel.

“July,” she said, weighing the parcel on her good palm.

“July. I wrapped it myself. Cora wanted to put a bow on it, and I wouldn’t let her.”

“Good.”

“The man at the supplier said the strong lenses are for faces.”

“He’s right.”

She stood under the corridor bulb and tore the tape with her left hand and her teeth. Inside the white box lay the headband, new, two sets of lenses in a foam bed. She fitted it over her head left-handed, and he did not help, and she settled it and flipped the stronger lenses down.

Then she turned to him in the corridor light and studied him through them, her eyes enormous, for as long as she liked.

Chapter 29 — Maud

“That’s not the same lady,” Ike Sobczak said.

He had come up at 8:41, which for Ike counts as late, with Lukas behind him carrying moving blankets and wearing one earbud, and he had stopped a yard short of the table with his cap in his hand.

“No,” I said.

“I seen the old one at my cousin’s wedding, 1989, I was an usher. She smiled at the whole church the entire Mass, like she was glad you came and she’d tell your mother you looked nice. This one’s not smiling at anybody. She’s looking at the kid.”

“She was always looking at the kid. He painted over it.”

“Leon Wrobel,” Ike said, nodding slowly. “My uncle bowled with Leon Wrobel. Said he cheated on his scores.” He put his cap back on, which is how he signs a clipboard. “I heard you got her back. Different thing, hearing and seeing.”

“Glassine first,” I said. “Then the foam, then your blankets.”

“I know the order, Ms. Alder.”

“I know you know. I’m saying it so it’s said.”

The four of us lifted her into the travel crate on my count, my left hand on the stretcher bar doing nothing useful, because I could not stand there and not touch her.

“You count like a crane man,” Ike said.

“I count like a conservator.”

“Same thing, slower.”

Declan had left the two coffees from the place on Girard on the corridor floor, because coffee does not come into the studio, and he handed me mine.

“My mother called,” he said. “Ten past seven, while you were asleep.”

“I wasn’t asleep. I heard the stair, and then I heard you use the steam wand.”

“I didn’t know it did that.”

“It’s done that for six years.”

“She says Christmas can be on Saturday this year. She cleared it with God. And she wants to know if you eat caraway.”

“Tell her I eat caraway.”

“I told her you’d tell her yourself, on Saturday.”

“You could have said yes for me.”

“I could have,” he said. “I didn’t.”

The coffee had gone lukewarm on the boards, and it was very good.

• • •

St. Wenceslaus was colder inside than the street. Gus had rented an aluminum tower for the morning, two levels of planks on locking wheels, and it stood against

the wall under the pale rectangle on the plaster with a man from the parish holding each leg and Gus himself on the front left one. He had offered in November to clean her with his wife's furniture polish and had not met my eye since.

I stood at the altar rail, my good hand on the brass, and kept my eyes on Ike's hands and off the planks.

"What do you need?" Declan said, beside me.

"Nothing," I said, without turning my head.

"Slack on the left, Gus," Ike called down. "More. Hold it there."

"What do you need?"

He stood with his hands open at his sides and waited, and there was no clock in it anywhere, no watch on his wrist and no glance at the door.

"Stand there," I said, and moved my chin an inch to the right.

He stood there, and he was broad enough. From the rail the tower went behind his shoulders, and Ike's hands came up above them, guiding the stretcher onto the cleat.

"Ms. Alder," Ike called from the top plank. "You want to come up and check her?"

"I can see her from here, Ike."

"Suit yourself, you're the boss."

Walter took a yellow torpedo level out of his overcoat and handed it up.

"It's lived in that pocket since 1971," he told me. "It has never been wrong."

Ike laid it along the top of the stretcher and squinted at the bubble before he handed it down.

"Level," Walter announced, and took the credit, and nobody argued. "I set new anchors in that wall on Tuesday, Ms. Alder. The old ones were set in 1957, and I don't trust anything from 1957."

Then he came to me at the rail with his hat in both hands.

"Ms. Alder. If I may. On behalf of the committee, and of the parish, and of my late wife, who did not care for the pink one either and never said so in front of Bernadette." He drew a breath through his nose. "This parish has been lied to by professionals before. Not by this one. Thank you."

"You're welcome, Mr. Wozniak."

"Mr. Hale," he said, turning.

"Mr. Wozniak."

Walter gave him a nod, chin down, once, and went to find Gus.

Father Tomasz came out of the sacristy with a box of candles on his hip and stopped under the painting.

"Well," he said. "Well, hello."

"She liked it," Declan said to him. "Maud said to tell you. The unusual."

"Did she," he said, shifting the candles. "Well, unusual's over. The secretary read Ms. Tilley's page at eight this morning, and she said fine. From her, fine is a brass band." He tipped his head back at the face. "So who is she, if she's not Helen?"

"Nobody knows. Somebody a man in Munich had seen."

“Half the parish is going to be disappointed.”

“Which half?”

“The Helen half,” said Father Tomasz, and went off with his candles.

• • •

At four, on Brown Street, I took the soup out of the freezer. It was in a quart deli container with masking tape across the lid, and on the tape in my sister’s round marker it said THURSDAY, and under that, smaller, *for her, she likes white bean*, with six weeks of frost grown over the letters.

Declan came to the kitchen doorway and stopped in it.

“Do you want me to—”

“No. I said I’d do it myself.”

He stayed in the doorway. “Are you going to eat it?”

“I do like white bean. She was right about that.” I turned the container so he could read the lid. “It says Thursday.”

“It’s Thursday.”

“Then it’s had its day,” I said, and ran the hot tap over the sides until the block let go, and tipped it whole into the bin under the sink, and rinsed the container left-handed. When I opened the drawer for a dish towel, her key with the yellow rubber daisy lay among the twist ties where he had put it at half past three. I shut the drawer on it and went up to sleep until ten.

• • •

The snow started during the carols.

I saw it begin in the clear panes over the side door, small and slanting, while Ray Teague, in the pew behind me, sang every verse of “O Come, All Ye Faithful” the way he toasts. I was in the second pew on the aisle with the committee. Mrs. Hajek had the front pew to herself in the purple hat, with her lemon candies in a twist of waxed paper on the seat beside her like a reserved sign.

She turned around during the second verse and put two in my left hand.

“For the hands. Both of you, give him his after.” Her eyes went up to the wall, where they had been going all evening. “Walter calls me at nine in the morning and says, Bernadette, she isn’t Helen Wrobel. Like a telegram, and he hangs up on me.”

“She isn’t.”

“No. She’s somebody’s girl from a farm, I think, tired, not so pretty.” She considered it with her head on one side. “Old, a little. That’s all right. My mother would have liked her better. Sixty years my mother sat under Helen Wrobel’s face every Sunday and said the rosary at it, furious, and now look, it was a farm girl all along, and she’s not here to see it.”

Joan came in during the third carol, in the red coat with snow on the shoulders, and edged along the pew past Walter's knees until she was beside me, and said nothing at all, not one exclamation mark.

I took my right hand off my lap and held it out to her, in the brace.

She stopped with her gloves half off.

"Don't squeeze," I said.

"I won't," Joan said, and took it in both of hers.

She held it on her knee through the rest of the carols, carefully, as you hold a thing somebody has lent you, and she felt it shake and kept holding it. Behind us Ray leaned forward.

"Look at that face, Joanie," he said, in the whisper that reaches choirs.

"Ray," said Joan, without turning around, and kept my hand until everyone stood for the procession.

The Monsignor blessed the painting with holy water from the foot of the altar steps.

"Six feet," Walter said under his breath, beside me. "I told him six feet, for the water."

From a pew there was nothing at the bottom left of the mantle but blue. You would need a UV lamp.

At the sign of peace Joan said, "Peace be with you," and meant it as exactly as she had meant the eleven candles.

Ray reached over the pew and shook my left hand and said, "Peace, Maud, peace, look at you," loud enough for the altar boys, and I turned past him and found the last pew. Declan was at the end of it by the radiator, standing, with his coat over his arm. Across the aisle, in the last pew on the other side, sat my mother in her good wool coat with her set hair and her gloves on. She kept her gloves on for the sign of peace. She inclined her head to me down the whole length of the church, the nod she gives Mrs. Haney over the hedge, and I turned back to the altar.

When I came back from communion her end of the pew was empty.

Before the last blessing Father Tomasz put his paper down.

"One more thing, and then you can all go home and fight about the ham," he said. "The painting over this altar was cleaned for our hundred and fortieth year by Alder Conservation, on Frankford Avenue. If she looks different to you, that's because she is. Take it up with Munich."

A few heads near the front tipped back to look at her again, and an old man across the aisle put on his glasses for it. Nobody looked for me. I sat in the second pew under the new lamps with the scar through my eyebrow, one more face among three hundred, and the organ started the last hymn.

• • •

The Archdiocese had sent a young woman with two cameras, and afterward she stood us in a row under the painting: the Monsignor, Father Tomasz, Walter with his hat held against his coat, and me.

"And you, ma'am," she said to Mrs. Hajek, "on the end, please."

"Me? I'm not committee, I'm the radio."

"Bernadette," said Walter. "Come and stand."

She came and took my left arm, and held on.

"Your husband should be in it," she said to me, not quietly.

"He doesn't want to be."

"Stanley was the same. Forty years of weddings, and not one picture of him anywhere. I have to look at the backs of other people's heads to find him."

"Your husband," the photographer said to me, between frames. "She says he helped. Would he come up for one?"

"Ask him."

She went down the aisle to the radiator and came back alone.

"He says no, thank you," she said, "and that you'd know he'd say that."

"I did."

Every time the flash went I found him at the back, in the dark, outside the frame. When she changed her angle he moved a yard to his left.

"Miracle, Monsignor," she said, lowering the camera.

"A conservator. Not a miracle," said Monsignor Pellegrino, and turned to me. "The brow, Ms. Alder."

"It stays."

"People will think it's damage."

"It is."

He considered the wall over his glasses. "Ms. Tilley telephoned the rectory at seven this morning to inform me that if anybody fills that brow she will withdraw her signature in writing. Then she said she was going to bed."

"She will."

"Withdraw it, or go to bed?"

"Both."

"Then it stays," he said, and put on his gloves.

"I'll tell the secretary," said Father Tomasz. "She'll go straight back to irregular."

Declan met me halfway down the center aisle with my coat.

"Your mother left at the Lamb of God," he said. "She stopped by the radiator on her way out."

"What did she say?"

"To tell you the blue is very nice."

"What did you say?"

"Nothing, I held the door."

"The blue was there already," I said, and let him put the coat on me, right sleeve first, and put Mrs. Hajek's other candy in his hand. "For the hands."

Through the glass of the vestibule doors the steps were white, and on the third one down, under the light, with her hood up, my sister stood with her back to the church.

"Wait here," I said.

He took his hand off the door.

He stayed inside the doors, and I didn't look back to see it.

• • •

The snow had covered everybody's footprints but hers.

She was in the navy shop coat with the wooden toggles, snow on the hood and down the front, and her hands were bare and red, with nothing in them but a Band-Aid around her right thumb from the wreaths. She turned when the door went, and it was my face, with nothing through the brow.

"I didn't come in," Cora said.

"I know."

"I stood at the door for the carols. You can hear everything from out here, the doors are so thin, it's like a radio, and the Silent Night was—" She stopped herself, on purpose, and I watched her do it. "I didn't come in."

"How did you get here?"

"The El, it's on a holiday schedule."

"I know about the holiday schedule." I looked down the steps at the street, where there were no cars left at the curb. "Mother left early."

"I know, she came out past me. She said I'd catch my death, and then she said it again from the car with the window down."

"You didn't go with her."

"No," Cora said. "I said I'd take the El."

Behind me the doors went on letting out the organ, quietly, and the smell of wax. She waited on her step without asking me for anything, the snow coming down between us onto her hood and onto my coat.

"March," I said.

She didn't move.

"Bring nothing."

"Okay," Cora said.

Chapter 30 — Maud

At 7:31 on Saturday Mrs. Kessler's curtain moved, which meant I was a minute late.

I pulled the front door to behind me and gave the lock its lift with my right hand, which I can do now for about as long as it takes to lift a lock, and stood on my own top step in my own coat. Brown Street was gray and dry, the sycamore bare over the Dunns' railing. The china spaniel in Mrs. Kessler's window had lost its balloon in January, and behind it the curtain held still at the height of a short woman's eye.

I lifted my hand to her, once, and went down the steps. After a while a hand came out from behind the curtain and lifted about two inches, and went back.

Declan had the Outback at the curb with the door open. I got in and reached across myself for the handle, and then didn't, and pulled the door shut with my right.

"She waved," he said.

"I saw," I said, and put my bag down on the floor between my feet.

"She hasn't waved at me since November."

"You don't wave at her."

"I bring her bins in on Tuesdays."

"She knows that. That's why she doesn't wave at you. She'd have to thank you for the bins."

He thought about that through the light at Girard. "Should I wave?"

"Not yet. She'd think you wanted something." I watched the El pillars go by. "We're out of the low-tack tape."

"What do you need?" he said.

"Nothing, I'll order it."

"What do you need?"

"The tape," I said, "the white roll, from the art store on Chestnut, today, if you can go at lunch."

"I can go at lunch."

• • •

There were two phones in the bowl by the door, and his watch across them, and the radio was on low, on the station Mrs. Hajek had left it on in December. On the bench under the north light lay the Tsangs' grandfather, a young man in a dark blue robe with his hands folded on a book, eleven inches by nine. His face had gone the brown of strong tea under the smoke, and a crack ran across his left cheek from the ear to the corner of the mouth, with somebody's pink laid over it like a bandage.

"Who's he?" Declan had said at eight, hanging up his coat.

"Mrs. Tsang's grandfather. Painted in Canton, by one of the workshops that sold portraits to the American ships."

"He's about twenty."

"He was twenty in 1875. Strictly he's her great-grandfather, but they've called him Grandfather for a hundred years, and he hasn't objected."

"What's wrong with him?"

"Coal smoke, a hundred and fifty years of it. And somebody touched in a crack on his cheek with the wrong pink, around 1980."

"Can you get it off?"

"In fours, by Easter, four minutes on and two with my hand in my lap. Esther Kaplan said on the sixth of January that the screw hasn't moved and she won't chase it unless it does, and I telephoned Frances and told her every word, and Frances said, Hm, then work in fours, and hung up on me."

"She hangs up on everybody."

"She hung up on the Monsignor at Christmas," I said, and set the white timer.

Mrs. Tsang had carried him up herself in February, in a pillowcase. "Is it you?" she said, before she let go of him. "Or is it the sister? The sister stood on my step and cried, and she was very nice, and I want the one who doesn't."

"It's me."

She studied the scar a long time, and gave him to me.

"What's Frances sending this week?" Declan said, from down the table. The envelope from Swarthmore lay by the solvent rack.

"Cantonese export portraits, and the oils they used."

"Is there a note?"

"Read the second half. The first half is wrong. F.T."

"Is it?"

"The first half is wrong," I said. "Don't tell her I read it."

When the timer went I dropped the swab in the can and let the hand shake on my knee.

He had the cow down there, a \$4 painting on board, a red barn and a brown cow in a field still dark under the old varnish. On weekdays he leaves Conshohocken at 5:30, in writing, and is on Brown Street by six. On Saturdays he is here, and he had been in a square of tape in the sky over the barn roof since eight.

"Odalys asked me on Thursday if you'd found it yet," he said.

"What did you tell her?"

"That you don't notice anything outside a frame."

"Good, keep telling her that."

"She asked what you'd do if you ever found it."

"What did you say?"

"That you'd tell me to go slower."

"I found it on Christmas morning, on the kitchen table, under a dish towel."

"I know you did," he said. "I left the towel crooked."

Odalys thinks it is the best secret she has ever kept.

"Slower," I said, without looking up from Grandfather.

He was already slower, rolling toward himself and turning each swab to read it before it went in the saucer.

• • •

At eleven Hamid knocked, in the scorched jacket.

“Cold lady, car man.” He nodded at the quartz heater ticking by the cot, HAMID, RETURN still across its top in his capitals. “You said spring, and I need her back. Monday I have a man coming for a lamp, Murano, 1960s, somebody glued the arm with the wrong glue, and my shop is a thousand degrees at the bench and forty at the door, and the door is where I sit to eat.”

“Spring is the twentieth,” I said, and kept the swab on the cheek.

“It’s fifty degrees outside.”

“It’s forty-nine in here. Ask me on the twentieth. And Pappas says you’ll only lend it back in November.”

He turned to Declan, who did not look up from the cow. “She’s always like this?”

“Yes,” Declan said, and rolled another swab.

“Fine, the twentieth,” said Hamid. “I’m writing it on my door, in the glass, with the diamond pen, so you can’t say I didn’t.” He went back down to his thousand degrees.

• • •

We ate on the corridor floor at noon, backs to opposite walls, with his mother’s green thermos between us and its one cup going back and forth. The tea was milky and stewed, with a spoon of sugar in it, and I don’t take sugar, and I drank it.

“Seven days,” he said, with his eyes on the window at the far end of the corridor.

“Till what?”

“Till spring, when you said I could eat it in there.”

“I said when it’s warmer.”

“The twentieth,” he said, and passed me the cup. “Ma called last night.”

“It isn’t Sunday.”

“She wants us at Easter. She says don’t bring anything, and she means it, and bring the good mustard from the Terminal. And she wants to know if the hand’s better.”

“Tell her yes, and tell her four minutes better.”

“You tell her, she likes it better from you.”

“Easter is Grandfather,” I said. “I told Mrs. Tsang he’d be home by Easter.”

“I know you did.” He turned the cup a quarter turn on his knee. “I want to go anyway. Both days, Saturday and Sunday, not up and back in an afternoon. I haven’t been home for Easter since I was running nights in Allentown. She does a ham with cloves in it, and I’d like to be there when she does it.”

I had promised the Saturday before Easter to Grandfather, and he knew it, and he had asked anyway.

"Then I'll ask Mrs. Tsang for one more week," I said. "If she says no, I finish him on the Friday, and you drive me up after, and I sleep in the car."

"She'll say yes."

"She'll make me ask in person."

"Then ask her in person," he said. "What time is your sister coming?"

"At four. She'll be early, and she'll wait downstairs until it's four."

"Do you want me to go out for an hour?"

"No. I want you at the cow."

"Back to the door?"

"If you like." I took the cup from him. "Tomorrow I want to go at ten, when it opens."

"Do I have to like it this time?"

"You liked it last time. You didn't know which part yet."

"An hour and forty minutes, last week," he said. "Somewhere after the first hour I stopped wanting to know what time it was."

"Your left hand kept going to your wrist."

"I'd left the watch in the car."

"I know. You checked for it for an hour, every few minutes, and then you stopped checking."

On the first Sunday in March I had walked him up to the Rogier in the Johnson rooms, the two panels and the red cloth behind the cross and the Virgin folding forward into Saint John's arms, and left him there. When we came out onto the steps he said, "He's got her. She's not going to fall." Then he said, "Can we come back next week?"

He has said next week to me a great many times, and that was the one he meant.

"Tomorrow," Declan said now, on the corridor floor.

"Tomorrow's Sunday."

"Tomorrow's next week."

"Yes," I said. "It is."

At ten past one he came back from Chestnut Street and put the white roll in my left hand.

"The man asked me what it was for," he said. "I told him a square inch at a time."

• • •

Odalys came up the stairs at half past one, because she has never trusted the elevator, with a museum envelope under her arm.

"Grandfather, before, raking and UV," she said, and put the envelope on the bench. "You owe me a sandwich, Alder. And Frances sent me an article on Tuesday, me, the first one in seven years. For Fuentes, page six."

"What's on page six?"

"Somebody proving I was wrong about Paraloid in 2019," Odalys said. "She underlined it twice."

Then she saw what Declan had in front of him under the tape.

"What the hell is that?"

"A cow," Declan said.

"I've never seen it before in my life."

"Neither have I," I said.

Declan rolled a swab toward himself and did not look up.

"Slower," Odalys told him.

"I know," Declan said, and turned the swab to read it.

"Still Saturdays?"

"Eight to six."

"Lunch in the corridor?"

"For seven more days," Declan said.

"Is she still coming at four?" she said to me.

"Yes," I said, and looked at the clock over the sink, which I never used to do.

"You want me here?"

"No."

"Damn, I wanted to see it."

"There's nothing to see. She's going to sit on a stool for an hour."

"That's the part I wanted to see," Odalys said, and went back down the stairs.

• • •

Cora's letter was on the shelf over the bowl, back in its envelope, MAUD in round marker. I had read it on the first of March, under the raking lamp, once, in order.

None of it asked me for anything. Page four was about the last winter of the shop, the February the cooler failed and she lost every stem for a wedding in Bryn Mawr and bought it all again at four in the morning on a credit card. I had paid her rent that February, on the first, as I always did, and I had not asked her one thing about it.

I put it back on the shelf.

• • •

At four the cage came up, and the gate drew across, slowly, until it clicked, and nobody said sorry to it.

She came one step into the room and stopped, in a canvas jacket I didn't know, with her hair in its clip and nothing in her hands, not even a bag. Her knuckles had healed, and there was a green stain down the side of her right thumb and a small hard callus where a florist's knife sits, so it was somebody's shop, then, and not hers.

She looked at the camel coat on its nail by the cot. Three more months on my back had brought the shoulders home, and they sat back now where mine sit. I watched her see that.

“Stool,” I said.

“Thank you,” Cora said, quietly enough that the radio nearly had it.

She sat on the stool by the door with her feet together and her hands folded on her knees. Declan did not look up, having turned his back to the door after lunch, as he said he would.

I set the timer and went back to Grandfather’s cheek.

It was the slow part, and the boring part. Four minutes, a rolled swab, one pass toward me and lift, the cotton, the can, another swab, the timer, the hand on my knee until it settled, again. The El came through every eleven minutes, and the tap kept time. Grandfather’s robe came up from brown to blue a quarter inch at a time, and the wrong pink on his cheek began to come away from the skin underneath, and nobody in the room said anything at all.

She watched for an hour without filling the quiet. Once, at the eighth set of four minutes, she breathed out slowly through her nose, as she used to at the museum when she had stood as long as she could in front of the red cloth and was about to go and find the armor. She didn’t go.

At ten to five I moved the raking lamp six inches to the left, so that the light came across the portrait from the side nearest the door, and every crack in his cheek stood up with its own small shadow where she could see it from the stool.

Declan lifted the tape off the square he had been in since two, in the grass beside the fence. The grass had come up green under the brown, and a rail of the fence, white, laid in about 1935 by somebody who had been tired by the time he got to the bottom of the board.

He set the swab down in the saucer and turned his left hand over and opened it and closed it.

“It’s not tired,” he said. “I’m checking.”

“Show me.”

He moved his stool back to let me in. I bent over his inch with my loupes, the new ones, the strong lenses down, for longer than he liked.

“What does it look like?” he said.

“Like nobody was there.”

I laid a fresh square of tape beside it on the other side of the rail, and took a clean swab from the jar, and held it out to him.

“Again.”

A Note to Readers

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